H1_hub

1	
2	Samire Gurgurovci: Thank you. I think it's quite informative. Maybe we can skip some questions for the interview and focus on what happened behind the scenes, especially during the different phases of the project. For example, in the preparatory phase when you were identifying the scope and objectives, what were the main challenges at the beginning? How did you identify the objectives before engaging with stakeholders?
3	H1: The objectives were already set when we started the project. All the hubs have the same objectives, but we adapted them based on our local situation.
4	Margit Hofer: Did you have a predefined topic for each hub? Was it broad or rather narrow? Is it more beneficial to have a very specific objective or a broader topic that you refine along the way?
5	H1: It was very specific. When we applied for the proposal, we had already selected value chains and focused only on plant-related topics. We worked exclusively on plant by-products, which we divided into two categories: food-related and non-food-related. This focus was defined from the beginning.
6	Margit Hofer: Do you think starting with a very specific objective was an advantage?
7	H1: It worked for us because we already had the network and topic in place. It might not be the same for others, but it was beneficial in our case.
8	Samire Gurgurovci: Was the network already established? Did you include stakeholders as the project progressed?

9	H1: Yes, we conducted initial mapping at the start of the project. For each event, new participants were included. The mapping is an ongoing process, and we invite new actors to annual events.
10	Samire Gurgurovci: How do you prioritize which actors to involve in specific activities?
11	H1-2It depends on their interest and the relevance to the project's objectives. Most join voluntarily.
12	Samire Gurgurovci: Do you have methodologies to keep stakeholders engaged?
13	H1-2Sometimes the right person inviting them helps bring them in.
14	H1: We communicate extensively before events and collaborate with local actors to select the best topics and locations. This ongoing communication helps maintain engagement.
15	Samire Gurgurovci: What is the best way to communicate with stakeholders for a new bio-economy hub?
16	H1: Online training doesn't work. Face-to-face meetings are much more effective.
17	Samire Gurgurovci: Looking back, is there anything you would have done differently to engage stakeholders?
18	H1: We should have asked hub members to share project information with their partners from the beginning. Expanding beyond our immediate network would have helped reach more people.
19	Samire Gurgurovci: What feedback did you receive from stakeholders on good practices for engagement?

20	H1: On-site events and pre-selected topic-based training sessions worked well. B2B meetings and creating face-to-face synergies were especially effective.
21	Samire Gurgurovci: Co-organizing events with other stakeholders—did that help?
22	H1: Yes, co-organizing worked well. It attracted more participants and allowed for broader engagement.
23	Margit Hofer: Why did matchmaking events work so well?
24	H1: There’s a need for such events because they offer business opportunities and help match producers and users of by-products. These smaller sessions allow for focused discussions.
25	Samire Gurgurovci: Did you face any challenges when implementing activities?
26	H1: One major challenge was the size of the regions. Both hubs cover large areas, making it difficult for people to travel for a one-day meeting. Online training didn’t work well either.
27	Samire Gurgurovci: Why didn’t online training work?
28	H1: We had two types of online training: one in French on specific bio-economy topics, which worked well. However, generic workshops in English didn’t attract participants due to language barriers and the oversaturation of similar EU project offerings.
29	Samire Gurgurovci: If you could do things differently, what would you change?
30	H1: In the West Hub, we had two EU projects on the same topic from the same call starting simultaneously. It would have been better to have one common project to avoid duplication. Better coordination at the EU level would have helped.

31	Margit Hofer: Were the on-site meetings and study visits helpful?
32	H1: Yes, they were appreciated. We hosted partners from an EU hemp project and organized local study visits. Combining study visits with hub meetings made the events more valuable for participants.
33	Margit Hofer: What are the five most important things to consider when organizing activities?
34	H1-2Location is crucial—easy to reach and centrally located.
35	H1: It's also important to balance participant profiles to encourage diverse exchanges. Allow time for discussions, propose various formats like flash presentations and B2B meetings, and co-organize with other stakeholders.
36	H1-3: Mixing formats is a good practice. B2B meetings, study visits, and collective networking work well together.
37	Samire Gurgurovci: What strategies have you considered to ensure the project's long-term sustainability?
38	H1: We plan to apply for regional, national, and EU funding to continue the work. This topic is already a core focus of our cluster, so we will maintain activities even without external funding, albeit on a smaller scale.
39	Margit Hofer: How did you align activities among diverse stakeholders?
40	H1: It wasn't difficult. We had sessions for all types of actors, with no compulsory participation. Everyone wanted to make the most of these opportunities.
41	Samire Gurgurovci: What gaps do you see in strengthening the bio-economy in Europe?

42	H1-2Funding for bio-economy hubs is essential to develop activities and expand the field.
43	Samire Gurgurovci: Is there anything we missed or that you'd like to add?
44	H1: We have a second video on the second hub, which we will share. The work is similar but adapted to each region's specific needs.
45	Margit Hofer: Thank you for your time. The videos are impressive, and it's remarkable how you managed two hubs simultaneously. We'll send you a summary and anonymized transcript for review.
46	H1: Thank you.
47	H1-3: Thank you.
48	H1-2Have a nice week!
49	**Summary:**
50	**Summary of Lessons Learned from the Interview**
51	1. **Clear Objectives from the Start**
52	○ **Having predefined, specific objectives and value chains helped the project stay focused. Working exclusively on plant by-products and dividing them into food-related and non-food-related categories was beneficial.**
53	1. **Importance of Existing Networks**
54	○ **Starting with an established network made it easier to engage stakeholders and implement project objectives effectively.**
55	1. **Continuous Stakeholder Mapping and Engagement**

56	○ **Stakeholder mapping is an ongoing process. New participants are invited to events every year, ensuring continuous growth and diversity in engagement.**
57	1. **Prioritizing Stakeholder Involvement Based on Interest**
58	○ **Stakeholder interest and relevance to project objectives are key factors in prioritizing involvement. Most stakeholders join voluntarily.**
59	1. **Effective Communication and Collaboration**
60	○ **Communication with local actors and co-organizing events with other stakeholders are crucial. This ensures relevance and increases participation.**
61	○ Online training was generally ineffective. Face-to-face meetings and local events worked far better for stakeholder engagement.
62	1. **Challenges in Large Geographic Areas**
63	○ **The size of the regions posed logistical challenges. Traveling long distances for one-day meetings was difficult for participants.**
64	1. **Language and Over-Saturation of Online Training**
65	○ **Online training sessions in French on specific topics worked well, while generic English sessions struggled due to language barriers and the abundance of similar EU project offerings.**
66	1. **Lessons from Feedback on Engagement Practices**
67	○ **On-site events and pre-selected topic-based training were successful.**
68	

	○ B2B meetings were highly effective in creating synergies and focused discussions.
69	○ Matchmaking events provided valuable business and innovation opportunities for participants.
70	1. **Avoid Duplication of Efforts**
71	○ **Better coordination at the EU level could help avoid duplication when multiple projects on the same topic are running simultaneously in the same region.**
72	1. **Best Practices for Organizing Events**
73	• **Choose an easily accessible, central location.**
74	• Ensure a balanced profile of participants to facilitate diverse exchanges.
75	• Offer different formats such as flash presentations, B2B meetings, and study visits.
76	• Allow time for informal discussions and networking.
77	1. **Long-Term Sustainability Strategies**
78	• **Applying for additional regional, national, and EU funding is essential to continue project activities.**
79	• Even without new funding, activities related to plant by-products will continue as they are part of the cluster’s core focus, albeit on a smaller scale.
80	1. **Stakeholder Consensus**
81	

- **The project successfully aligned activities among diverse stakeholders by offering multiple participation formats, ensuring voluntary involvement, and engaging with regional and political actors.**

82 1. **Gaps in the Bio-Economy**

83

- **There is a need for consistent funding to develop bio-economy hubs and expand related activities across Europe.**

84 # Original Transcript

85 10 February 2025, 01:33pm

86 SG

87 SG

Samire Gurgurovci 7:00

Nice. Thank you. Thanks. I think it's quite informative actually, but.

Maybe obviously we can skip some questions today for the interview, but maybe we can just go into the things that happened behind the scene that we haven't touched upon in the video. Like when we said about these different phases of the project in, for example, when we start, when we you had the preparatory phase on identifying the scope and the objectives of the.

Of the project, like what were the main challenges in in the beginning before even starting it? Like what were the main challenges that you had encountered in this in this space? I I think I addressed quite some things from the video, but maybe we need time to look at it as well again.

And.

So yeah, so my question would be.

What? How? How did you come about with identifying with objective project before even starting to engage with stakeholders?

88 ML

H1 8:20

I'm not sure I understand the question because the objectives were already set when we

started the project. All the hubs are the same objectives, so we just completed the objective based on our local situations.

89 MH
Margit Hofer 8:39
Did you understand you correctly so that you had?

90 SG
Samire Gurgurovci 8:39
Mm hmm.

91 MH
Margit Hofer 8:43
You had already the topic of the hub of each of the hub, right?
Did you?
Was it? Yeah. Well, obviously it was fairly broad, right? Or was it rather narrow or did you have to narrow it down? Do you think it's important to have a very, very specific objective and a specific goal and aim working in those hubs?
Or is it sufficient to have a very broad topic and then you go case by case and stakeholder, stakeholder into work?

92 ML
H1 9:17
Very specific when doing the application on the proposal we had already selected the value chains and we only work on plants related topic at visual. So it's already really narrow and then we only wanted to focus on byproducts. So the what we've done is dividing the by products by two category food and non food related.
By products from plants.
But we had this topic from the very beginning for the two hubs because this is.

93 MH
Margit Hofer 9:52
Uh huh.

94 ML
H1 9:54
A topic we are working on at visual is very in general.

95 MH
Margit Hofer 10:00
Do you consider that this is an advantage? So as an example, if I have put follow would do the same as you do, would you recommend to do the same like starting with a very specific objective and a very specific goal?
You don't know.

96 ML
H1 10:17
Yeah, I don't know, but it it work for us because we had the network and the topic, but I don't know if it's.

97 MH
Margit Hofer 10:18
Could be.

98 ML
H1 10:25
I don't know if my teacher friend said any want to. There is a specific recommendation but it worked for us. Having the network and the topic in advance.

99 MH
Margit Hofer 10:35
OK.

100 SG
Samire Gurgurovci 10:37
Network was already established. Did you uh include stakeholders on the way of the did you include different stakeholders on the way of the on the process of the project?

101 ML
H1 10:50
So we had done the mapping that was requested by the project at the beginning and then for each event there are new participants, new mapping ongoing and the two teams that are working with these actors.

102 SG
Samire Gurgurovci 10:56
Mm hmm mm hmm.

103 ML
H1 11:09
Every day. So when there are new actors, they are invited to events we organise each year, so it's an ongoing process of mapping.

104 SG
Samire Gurgurovci 11:21
Mm hmm mm hmm and if you could tell us like how does this go about like practically, how do you and like how do you prioritise these actors to be involved in a specific activities?

105 MB
H1 11:40
The interest they have to come and join us is.

106 SG
Samire Gurgurovci 11:45
OK. So it's kind of a, it's kind of their own voluntary interest and then it fits to the project objective.

107 MB
H1 11:55
It's not only voluntary, but most of them. Yes, they ask for to join us.

108 SG
Samire Gurgurovci 12:02
OK. And do you have any methodologies or?
Mechanism on how to keep them engaged? Or I mean if they come, if if their interest comes from their own self, I guess they are already interested and they are going to keep getting engaged, but maybe other stakeholders that are that came from your invitation.

109 MB
H1 12:32
For them, sometimes.
Right person that meets them can help to have them in different events organise.
That's your question or not see.

110 ML
H1 12:45

And we we do a lot of communication.
On the events and before the events, we work with local actors to select the best topics and best look locations.

111 SG
Samire Gurgurovci 12:49
Mm hmm.

112 ML
H1 12:59
For to have as many people as possible, and it's, as Mikey said, is also an ongoing communication with them. We meet them at fairs, different events, so it's.
There are different exchanges that we have all along the year.

113 SG
Samire Gurgurovci 13:20
What would you say is kind of the the best way to communicate with them? Like think about there is a hub that is going to start an initiative in bio economy. What would you be? What would be your advice on how to communicate with those stakeholders?

114 ML
H1 13:38
Online trainings.

115 SG
Samire Gurgurovci 13:41
And I can't open.

116 MH
Margit Hofer 13:41
OK.

117 ML
H1 13:42
Online training doesn't work. We've seen it.

118 SG
Samire Gurgurovci 13:45
OK.

119 MB
H1 13:46
The best it's if we have the opportunity to meet them, like in face to face can help.

120 SG
Samire Gurgurovci 13:52
And nice. And is there anything that in this phase that you have done and you would have think that you would have done it differently in terms of engaging with stakeholders?

121 ML
H1 14:13
I think one point was said in the video is that we should maybe from the beginning have asked.
The head members to share with their partners.
Information about the project not only contacting our first level of network, but.
Also, building on the second level and third level of networks.
To reach more people, and not only through our network.

122 SG
Samire Gurgurovci 14:42
Mm hmm.

123 ML
H1 14:43
And I don't remember if there was a second.
Recommendation we had for the other hubs so then.

124 LS
H1-3 14:59
Mm hmm mm hmm.

125 SG
Samire Gurgurovci 15:03
And what did you did? What feedback or what lessons learned did you draw from the feedback you got from the stakeholders? They're wearing it?

126 ML
H1 15:20

On what?
I mean you need feedback on on what?

127 SG
Samire Gurgurovci 15:29
Feedback on like good practises for them to be engaged in your project and or.
Good or not, or even not good practises that they had recommended other ways or other formats, other tools to use in engaging with them, working with them?

128 ML
H1 15:52
I don't know if we ask them directly, what's the.

129 SG
Samire Gurgurovci 15:55
OK.

130 ML
H1 15:58
Should be done, but what we've seen is that.
On site, events work well and having training on topics they've preselected work well. We had many requests on legislation in France.
For byproducts. So we tried to have trainings on that during the local events, B2B meetings.

131 SG
Samire Gurgurovci 16:15
Mm hmm.

132 ML
H1 16:23
Worked really well as well, and every time we have a hard meeting, we organise sessions. Like 2 hour sessions where people can just exchange.
Face to face and create synergies like the examples that were in the videos.

133 SG
Samire Gurgurovci 16:39
Mm hmm.
So you would say like, sorry.

134 ML
H1 16:47
Yep.
The only thing I was going to ask is to Co organise with other actors. Worked well not only ourselves but with other local stakeholders to have more people.

135 SG
Samire Gurgurovci 17:05
Right, so also organising this match, making maybe informed.
Events where they could exchange.
It you would say it would be beneficial, right? Yeah.

136 ML
H1 17:20
In our case, that was one of the it's always the one of the highlights of the meetings that we organised.
It to be meetings.

137 MH
Margit Hofer 17:33
Do you think it this match making event work so well because it made a very specific need of each stakeholder?
I need the matchmaking work so well.

138 MB
H1 17:55
Yeah.

139 ML
H1 17:55
You can say it in French and I can translate if you want to say.

140 MB
H1 18:00
We can give to the.
To the participants, some business opportunities.
Or some.
Some innovation projects, opportunities or so.

141 MH
Margit Hofer 18:18
OK.

142 ML
H1 18:22
I've seen in the two hubs that there are many people with the need of using bike products and other people producing bike products and the need was to make them meet because they are working within their own categories. So this need to be meetings, allow them to discuss their needs in terms of byproducts and what they produce and how they could transform them and work together.
But in a smaller.
Format So they don't have to discuss with all the people that are in the same room.

143 SG
Samire Gurgurovci 18:59
And so we.

144 MH
Margit Hofer 19:00
Thanks.

145 MB
H1 19:00
And working about Co products, it's a need, but there is not a lot of events about it. So that's why we are interested.

146 SG
Samire Gurgurovci 19:08
Mm hmm.
Right, so this lack of not having much opportunities, yeah.
Did you experience any challenges or obstacles like when implementing those actions, those activities or events?

147 ML
H1 19:34
One big one was mentioned during the video is the size of the regions the two regions. They are really big in France.

148 SG

Samire Gurgurovci 19:35

And.

Mm hmm mm hmm.

149 ML

H1 19:43

And both hubs so having.

Points to make people meet is quite complicated. It's difficult to have people to travel for only one day meeting.

And from.

One part of the region to the other. So that's one big challenge.

That we had in both hubs.

I think that was the major one. I don't know if you saw if there is another one.

Yeah, making them attending online training was a ********.

150 SG

Samire Gurgurovci 20:28

OK, so why would you, would you say? Why would you say that the on the the online trainings were not really because we had another interview with another hub and they they had different reasons why people wouldn't wouldn't like to have online training and instead have this B2B meetings?

151 ML

H1 20:51

So we had two types of online trainings, 1 some that are organised by us.

On specific topics related to Bioeconomy, where we invite not only the hub members but all the major police valleys members. So it's broader and it's in French and it sounds very specific topic and this one's work. The ones that don't work at all are the.

English one.

That are very generic and that we promote from other new projects. We try to promote the scale up.

Workshops.

And we just don't manage to get people at them.

Road workshops in English and I think that well, there is the language reason.

The quantity reason there are so many.

Eu projects ongoing.
Offering online trainings in English that we it's difficult to make people.
Take part to these trainings online trainings because they are not specific enough, they are not in the language they speak, so it's very difficult and there are just too many of them. So it was difficult to make some of them more interesting to our communities and I don't think we managed at the beginning. We had maybe one or two participants from the hubs.
And now I don't think there is anyone.
Taking back to this training, so the ones that are very focused and in French they work but not the others.

152 SG

Samire Gurgurovci 22:38

Yeah, that makes perfect sense actually, yeah.
Is there is there anything that you would do differently at this point?
I don't know. Maybe, maybe also collaborate with the other initiatives that are happening in the regions or?
Anything that you would think would work different if you had to do it again, you would do it differently.

153 ML

H1 23:12

Well, in in the West Hub, we had two EU projects on the same topic from the same call starting at the same time.
So.
If we could have avoided that, I mean having only one common project that would have helped us because all the projects had to organise events, workshops.
Sending questionnaires to different actors, so it was difficult when we tried to invite each other every time. But still it's the same area, same people.
So the better coordination at EU level would have been nice for us, but it's also that we needed to discuss more with the local actors that were applying to this call at the same time as us.
And for the other one, I don't know.
What could have been done more?
I think we were well prepared because that's the thematic we've been working on in the

cluster for a while. So many things were already taking place and was organising the B2B meetings on by products for I don't know how many years you've heard that there were, yes.

154 MB
H1 24:36
Yes, 5 rooms since five years, yeah.

155 ML
H1 24:40
It has been.
Something working.
And updated through the projects that something that was already working that we reuse for the project.

156 MH
Margit Hofer 24:55
I ask you, I think you are also involved in the on site meetings, you know, organised.
I think by Kevin.
Was that helpful for you too? Because we had several interviews and they were saying these ones were quite successful for them. Was it the same for you too?

157 ML
H1 25:18
I'm not sure I understand which meeting.

158 MH
Margit Hofer 25:21
You know these these.
Exchange meetings like.

159 ML
H1 25:26
I need a study visit no.

160 MH
Margit Hofer 25:27
Yeah, exactly. Study these hits. That's what it was called.

161 ML

H1 25:33

So we had one where we hosted partners from.

A new project from on hemp and we had common trainings together, so it was interesting but more in terms of collaboration at EU level. And the second one since the ones we organised were only study visits.

In France, with local actors, so it's nice for the the actors to go and do A to have a visit of ongoing innovation, success to different topics, but it was not involving partners from. From the construction, but I think it was well appreciated in both hubs having this study visits and we now we try to merge everything at the same time having the hub meeting the study visit which will be even. So it's it's as interesting as possible for the two for all the participants to have everything in one day.

162 MH

Margit Hofer 26:39

OK.

If you would have to do.

Actions and activities. What would or what are the five most important things that one has to consider?

Sorry.

163 MB

H1 27:06

The place.

164 MH

Margit Hofer 27:08

At the place? Yeah, I do agree. OK.

Place is important. You mean it has to be central because your help was so big? Or are you talking about how the room looks like or where you do it? Or what exactly do you mean by place?

165 MB

H1 27:25

The place, easy to to find, to join and to to go. Because we have big region and like.

166 MH
Margit Hofer 27:32
OK.

167 SG
Samire Gurgurovci 27:37
Like a middle point.

168 ML
H1 27:39
Yeah, I think we we worked on this for the MMA workshop.

169 MB
H1 27:39
Yes.

170 LS
H1-3 27:42
It's supposed to.

171 ML
H1 27:46
And So what we recommended was to.
Try to balance the profile of the participants. Have as many different profiles as possible to facilitate the exchanges. The location as Mighty was saying.
Allow me to be meetings and time for the participants to exchange not only attend.
Have done discussion or presentation but have time to discuss together.
Propose different formats.
So this is what we were saying before.
We tried to have many formats, many stations in one day, so we had flash, flash presentations where the participants can.

172 LS
H1-3 28:38
I think this this point is very important for the participants because we have we we mix different formats and the B2B meeting study visit collective network and it's a real good practise I think.

173 ML
H1 28:42
Yeah.

174 SG
Samire Gurgurovci 28:58
So having different type of methods it was it was a good practise.
Right. And you also mentioned that you in the beginning that you had a very narrow plan and you already had an established network before you started the project.
And So what would be have you actually have you considered strategies to ensuring the project's long term sustainability in terms of also their stakeholder commitment?

175 ML
H1 29:39
Well, we would like to have.
Another project that would help us continue the work that has started on this one so.
We'll be applying to.
Regional, national and European projects to get funded on this topic in particular, so we can continue working on on this.
And this, but also as we said, this was something we had started before.

176 SG
Samire Gurgurovci 30:05
Mm hmm.

177 ML
H1 30:11
The project and that increased a lot through the projects, but this is something we we need to maintain as a cluster because this is one of the.
Aim of the classes to allow people to exchange and create this network.
So yeah, getting another EU project would be.
Ideal, but we will try to find solutions to maintain their link between all participants because it worked well and people are pleased with the results.

178 SG
Samire Gurgurovci 30:50
So if this doesn't work, I don't know if I hope you get the findings for it. How would you?
How would you keep the stake orders coming and being committed or engaged through

the project?
Aside from the funding of keeping the project going on.

179 ML
H1 31:17
The the byproducts aspect is one of the clusters topic of work, so it will remain in any case we have.
Our cluster is working on this topic so.
In any case, we are going to work on this and we will still organise events and take part to fairs in France. It's just that.
The scale that will be reduced if we don't have different means, but the work will remain because this is one of the aim of our cluster in France.

180 MH
Margit Hofer 32:00
Can I ask you one more question in between, you mentioned beforehand that you had many different stakeholders.
Was it difficult for you to?
Align the activities amongst the. How did you reach consensus between these stakeholders, or wasn't that an issue at all?

181 ML
H1 32:23
I don't think it was an issue, but I don't my was it difficult. I think everyone was invited.
And there were sessions for.
All types of factors the visit. It's interesting.
Depending on your needs to be to be meetings you are you get the chance to meet similar actors or actors from different categories. The trainings they were open to everyone as well, and the pitch presentation at the beginning was also only on voluntary basis so.
Some partners decided to present themself and their needs and what they work on. Some didn't want to. Most of them wanted to, but it wasn't mandatory.
So I think we had.
Enough formats to make it.
Convenient for everybody. Nothing was compulsory.
But everyone wanted to make the most of these days. So.

It worked well. We didn't have to look for a specific category or factors. We managed to have all of them represented. We worked with the regions as well to get.
Local actors and political actors.
So I may help as well to have a representative number of actors, but we didn't have to look for a specific category requested by the apps.

182 MH
Margit Hofer 33:56
OK.

183 SG
Samire Gurgurovci 34:08
I would have one more question on like in the general view of given you, you have a very long experience and with hubs and what what gaps do you see in strength in the bio bio economy in Europe?

184 ML
H1 34:27
The economy in Europe.

185 SG
Samire Gurgurovci 34:28
Yes.

186 MB
H1 34:42
Good question.

187 MH
Margit Hofer 34:43
It's a tough question, right?

188 ML
H1 34:43
Making you want to say something, yeah.

189 MB
H1 34:47
Be president.

190 SG
Samire Gurgurovci 34:52
I mean, I don't think there is one answer to it. And yeah, I understand the.

191 MB
H1 34:59
But maybe to have like funds to money for the bioeconomy.
Heads to develop activities about this subject, so I I think it can help to develop a mean the world or in Europe.

192 MH
Margit Hofer 35:07
Yeah.

193 MB
H1 35:16
Or phonetics.

194 SG
Samire Gurgurovci 35:20
Yeah.
Does anybody else have anything to add or anything that we didn't mention?
I think we got a little bit.
Because of the video and that and then the questions it got, maybe we forgot something or something got lost in in between but if you have anything else to add please?

195 ML
H1 35:46
We have a second video that we can send you on. The second hub is not well the the the answers and the way we work is comment. So it's quite similar but it's specific to each region. So we will send you the link as well. So you can have a look and see if there are more information that you need.

196 SG
Samire Gurgurovci 36:07
Yes, please mm hmm.

197 ML
H1 36:08

On my side, there is nothing to add, but I don't know if my colleagues want to add something.
No.

198 MH
Margit Hofer 36:20
Thank you so much for your time and yeah, great work, by the way. The videos are great because I've seen them already.
And Luba was sending the links to us as well as the transcript. So these are included a rating in, in the analysis.
But very impressive and great work, and I mean especially you have to handle two hops at the same time, which is quite demanding. And I think perhaps had really a lot to do in this project, so.
Yeah, quite impressive. What you achieved really.

199 ML
H1 36:55
Thank you.

200 SG
Samire Gurgurovci 36:56
Yeah.

201 LS
H1-3 36:56
Thank you.

202 MH
Margit Hofer 36:58
Yeah. Thanks a lot for your time. OK. And yeah, we do a transcript and it's Samir Hussain. It will be anonymized obviously and then you see the summary, we will send you in any case. So that you would have a chance to read through it.
And in case we misunderstood anything, then of course there's always the opportunity to correct.

203 ML
H1 37:24
OK. Thank you.

204 LS
H1-3 37:24
OK. Thank you.

205 MH
Margit Hofer 37:25
Good. OK.
Thanks a lot then and have a good afternoon and thank you so much for your time. OK.
OK. Thanks. Bye.

206 ML
H1 37:32
Thank you.

207 SG
Samire Gurgurovci 37:33
Thank you. Thank you very, very much.

208 MB
H1 37:34
Have a nice week.

209 LS
H1-3 37:36
Bye.

210 SG
Samire Gurgurovci 37:40
Good.

211
Margit Hofer stopped transcription

RuralBioUp lessons learned H2

1	**H2**
2	My first question would be So what was your help mission and what were your roles?
3	**H2-1:** "I don't know if we could really speak about a 'half mission' because this half, created during the project, is like a mirror of past activities of the stakeholders—as we already mentioned. Sometimes during our consultative or informal meetings, there is a very strong core in the H2-HUB region, which even gave the hub its name. The stakeholders are very open-minded and are involved in many national, local, and European projects, so they're well familiar with the European approach and its requirements. I personally appreciate that these stakeholders did not expect a big effect during the project; they understand that results will develop over time with the involvement of other local or regional actors. They are very important—perhaps the basis for economic involvement—but other actors are equally crucial. In conclusion, the mission of this hub is to continue fostering their willingness to recognize their local potential, not only for the bio-economy but also for other branches of industry, and to attract additional relevant stakeholders."
4	**H2-2 (3:19):** [No response]
5	**H2-1 (3:24):** "Other relevant stakeholders for the economy, for the regional economy—and our role is significant. The Institute for Economic Forecasting, within the framework of the H2-hub Academy, has had the chance to work very closely with many representatives of the business environment over the last 15 years, thanks to various European projects (and some national projects, too). This created a very fruitful relationship with these institutions, making it natural to continue the collaboration when implementing the RuralBioUp project."
6	**Margit Hofer (4:26):** "So basically you started with an existing network, right? And then you continued working with that network. My question is: how do you keep the stakeholders involved and engaged? Why do you think they are still motivated to participate in these activities?"
7	**H2-2 (4:33):** [No response]

8	**Margit Hofer (4:43):** "How do you keep the stakeholders involved and engaged? What is the reason for their continued motivation?"
9	**H2-1 (4:56):** "The real reason is that, as I said, there is a core contact point—the hub—which also represents the green energy cluster. This cluster is involved in other European projects within the Horizon Europe programme and in the green economy field. This hub was built by two or three people who were always available to mediate the relationship between us, as regional facilitators, and the other stakeholders."
10	**Margit Hofer (5:56):** "So, if I understand correctly, these contact points play a crucial role?"
11	**H2-1 (6:07):** "Exactly, they are crucial. But remember, they are business people—they're very busy and may not want to dedicate too much time to administrative activities, as we did in this project. However, they fully understood the project's objectives and were very open to recommending the stakeholders we needed to invite. It was a mutually beneficial relationship."
12	**Margit Hofer (7:16):** "When you were setting up your network in the first phase of the RuralBioUp project, what were the major challenges? What was tricky or a bit of an issue?"
13	**H2-1 (7:44):** "As I mentioned, the network already existed at that moment and perhaps needed some development and improvement. Thanks to the project requirements and the local clusters that worked with our institute—who were available, curious, and willing to be engaged—the process was quite natural. We didn't really have to push them into participation."
14	**Margit Hofer (8:41):** "So, would you say that the aim of the project fitted very well with the interests of the stakeholders?"
15	**H2-2 (8:45):** [No response]
16	**H2-1 (8:49):** "Yes, yes, yes. And let me add that we prepared this new project in such a way that, together with the core contact point, we will work very closely, continuing from our previous European project, 'BeRural.' That project was dedicated to a smaller area of the larger H2-hub region—only at the county level. As I said, it was a natural continuation."

17	**Margit Hofer:** "Since you mentioned the size of your hub, do you have the impression that it's easier to work with a smaller group of people, or do you see an advantage to working with a bigger region? In one interview with French participants, they mentioned that the size of the hub was an issue for them. Was it the same for you?"
18	**H2-1 (9:57):** "Yes, yes. For us, it’s interesting because our region comprises six counties that are not so different overall—but each has its own specificities related to mentality, tradition, and ethnicity, given the multicultural nature of the area. We received great support from the Regional Agency for Development, which really knows the local authorities and works closely with them. However, as you mentioned, working in smaller groups allows us to organize more effectively. For instance, we arranged two different kickoff meetings over four days. All of this required special coordination, which we managed well."
19	**Margit Hofer (11:14):** "So, if I understand correctly, your collaboration with the regional development institution was very beneficial. And within your hub, you had stakeholders with different interests or approaches. How did you manage to combine these different perspectives?"
20	**H2-1 (12:00):** "Not exactly different approaches—but there were slight differences in mentality and interests. As regional facilitators, you have to understand the specificities of smaller areas. For example, the Regional Agency for Development has six local offices. They share a general objective but each has a locally tailored target."
21	**Margit Hofer (13:01):** "Basically, you organized different activities tailored to very specific target groups. That strategy worked well for you, correct?"
22	**H2-1 (13:17):** "Yes, exactly. We had to adapt, drawing on our previous experience working with smaller areas. We already knew our target groups."
23	**Margit Hofer (13:39):** "So you already had a good understanding of your target groups, which was a big advantage."
24	**H2-1 (13:54):** "Yes—but at the same time, years ago we faced significant challenges learning the local context."

25	**Margit Hofer (14:10):** "Looking back, what were the best strategies to set up such a network? What would you recommend to other regions looking to establish a similar network?"
26	**H2-1 (14:31):** "Working closely with the regional development agency and professional associations was key. In our case, we collaborated with the ????? (a local organization) that was very effective in organizing the entities. This region, located in the middle of the country, includes three significant minorities—the xxx, the xxx, and the xxx, along with some areas having a smaller (xxx) population. Their historical experience of living together has made them more flexible than regions in the South."
27	**H2-2_X (15:04):** [No response]
28	**H2-1 (15:13):** "They have successfully built a multicultural community."
29	**Margit Hofer (16:10):** "Okay."
30	**H2-2_X (16:11):** "It’s a very serious development of the area."
31	**Margit Hofer (16:16):** "Alright."
32	**H2-2_X (16:16):** "It’s a long-term journey. They are working on multiple project periods—not just 2–3 years. Would you agree, H2-1?"
33	**H2-1 (16:33):** "Yes."
34	**Margit Hofer (16:35):** "Okay."
35	**H2-2_X (16:35):** "So it’s a long journey, and that’s an advantage of this specific region."
36	**Margit Hofer (16:40):** "Okay."

37	**H2-1 (16:45):** "One more thing—I observed that they are very modest. They know a lot but still value collaborating with research institutes."
38	**H2-2_X (16:57):** "Yes, they don’t claim to know everything."
39	**H2-1 (16:59):** "They understand that universities and other entities are necessary. They admit they need external expertise."
40	**H2-2_X (17:09):** "That’s because of the cluster vision involving multiple actors—academia, research, business, and civil society. It’s a distinctive feature of the region."
41	**Margit Hofer (17:51):** "So, what you’re saying is that you have a very heterogeneous group that is open to collaboration. Is that correct?"
42	**H2-1 (18:09):** "Yes, absolutely."
43	**Margit Hofer (18:12):** "Alright. Is there anything from the last two or two-and-a-half years in RuralBioUp that you would do differently?"
44	**H2-1 (18:29):** "Maybe something related to the application form."
45	**Margit Hofer (18:35):** "Okay."
46	**H2-2_X (18:44):** "Okay."
47	**Margit Hofer (18:48):** "Did you receive any feedback from the stakeholders? What kind of feedback did you get?"
48	**H2-2_X (18:53):** [No response]
49	**H2-1 (18:59):** "They are very patient. Almost every time, they ask about financing opportunities linked to

	their participation. They care about their region and its future, but they also have to deal with economic difficulties."
50	**Margit Hofer (19:36):** "Of course."
51	**H2-1 (19:37):** "I was very impressed that during our previous European project 'BeRural'—even amid the pandemic—they participated in all our online events, despite concerns about the economic downturn."
52	**Margit Hofer (20:01):** "Mm-hmm."
53	**H2-2_X (20:02):** "Because of the economic downturn during the pandemic."
54	**H2-1 (20:05):** "Yes. And maybe you know, in Iasi our meetings were organized with the support of the European Commission during the European Cluster Meeting framework."
55	**H2-2_X (20:26):** "Yes, or through European TV clusters that helped regions meet online. During the pandemic, for instance, the Spanish Presidency organized weekly online meetings addressing economic difficulties and collaboration opportunities, similar to what we did in our project."
56	**Margit Hofer (21:11):** "So that was...?"
57	**H2-1 (21:12):** "What I'd like to underline is that the project perhaps should have delivered more practical results—something tangible the stakeholders could see."
58	**Margit Hofer (21:28):** "Mm-hmm."
59	**H2-1 (21:28):** "They expected something concrete from these projects."
60	**H2-2_X (21:32):** [No response]

61	**Margit Hofer (21:34):** "In terms of practical results, what did you have in mind? Were you thinking of guidelines on how to receive funding? I noticed that despite the challenges, they continued participating in online activities."
62	**H2-1 (21:54):** "Yes."
63	**Margit Hofer (22:07):** "This is interesting because our French colleagues mentioned that only face-to-face meetings worked for them—not online trainings."
64	**H2-1 (22:22):** "Please understand me correctly—I'm referring to the pandemic period."
65	**Margit Hofer (22:30):** "Okay."
66	**H2-2_X (22:30):** [No response]
67	**Margit Hofer (22:33):** "Now that the pandemic is over, which activities or actions work best in your hub?"
68	**H2-1 (22:45):** "Actually, that was very much a pandemic-related situation..."
69	**H2-2_X (22:47):** "No, not now, H2-1—I mean in the other project we discussed, 'Rural Development by All.'"
70	**Margit Hofer (22:48):** "Not during the pandemic, then."
71	**H2-1 (22:58):** "Could you repeat the question, please, Margit?"
72	**Margit Hofer (23:01):** "When you organized activities with your stakeholder groups, which ones worked best for your hub?"
73	**H2-1 (23:12):** "I observed that if we organized events in association with other European projects, local events, or even university conferences, local stakeholders were very interested because

	they learned more about the field and felt connected to an active life. In contrast, holding an event solely dedicated to the RuleBioUp project didn't attract many participants. We learned this quickly—that's why most of our events are organized in cooperation with others."
74	**Margit Hofer (24:25):** "So one challenge was also finding corporate partners to co-host events, correct?"
75	**H2-1 (24:39):** "Exactly. It wasn't too difficult because we already know each other in the region. For example, the Regional Development Agency invited us to their events on circular economy, and it was natural to support one another. The biggest challenge was coordinating the timing for these events since every institution has a busy agenda."
76	**Margit Hofer (25:33):** "Okay, so it was more a timing issue."
77	**H2-1 (25:38):** "Yes, exactly."
78	**Margit Hofer (25:43):** "Were there any other structures or support that helped you during implementation? For regions looking to set up hubs and activities, what would you recommend?"
79	**H2-1 (26:25):** "For us, it was very helpful to learn from other consortium partners. I was honestly very inspired by colleagues from other European projects—especially The hubs countrys representatives, with whom we started working 15 years ago. We learned a lot from each partner's approach and adapted those lessons to our situation."
80	**Margit Hofer (27:32):** "Very good. Did you also take part in study visits? Were those helpful for your hub exchange?"
81	**H2-1 (28:01):** "Yes, I did. Stakeholders even asked to compare our approach to other European projects. Some projects had budgets to cover study visits for stakeholders, but in our case, we didn't have enough funding. It would have been more helpful if we had a sufficient budget for public visits."
82	**Margit Hofer (28:47):** "Okay."

83	**H2-1 (28:47):** "I was asked, for example, by a representative from the The hubs countrys Cluster about how and when to arrange these visits. They didn't have enough funds to participate—even though our coordinator invited us, it wasn't possible."
84	**Margit Hofer (29:26):** "Essentially, next time you'd need a more sufficient budget to facilitate exchange with partners—like the The hubs countrys ones, right?"
85	**H2-1 (29:37):** "Yes, exactly."
86	**Margit Hofer (29:41):** "And do you think that with additional budget, study visits would have been a fruitful exchange? Do study visits, in principle, make sense?"
87	**H2-1 (30:07):** "We identified some common issues among our stakeholders. I was a little disappointed that, for example, the The hubs countrys colleagues had the funds but not the time to come, even if we had planned well in advance."
88	**Margit Hofer (30:43):** "Okay, I understand."
89	**H2-1 (30:44):** "I have to admit they are very busy business people, involved in many activities such as work fairs."
90	**Margit Hofer (31:02):** "So that means you need to find good incentives for them to attend."
91	**H2-1 (31:13):** "Yes, exactly. One The hubs countrys colleague who visited Iasi mentioned that two or three might come, but it wasn't feasible given their busy schedules."
92	**Margit Hofer (31:49):** "Mm-hmm. Are there any other activities you'd pursue if you had sufficient funding?"
93	**H2-1 (32:14):** "For example, I would cover travel expenses for representatives of regional authorities and relevant ministries. This is very important because we work with many partners. Even though not everyone can participate, when they do, stakeholders are very pleased to have the opportunity to discuss directly with ministry representatives."

94	**H2-2_X (32:37):** [No response]
95	**H2-1 (32:42):** "When those representatives do participate, the stakeholders are really very pleased."
96	**H2-2_X (32:57):** [No response]
97	**H2-1 (33:03):** "They appreciate the chance to discuss directly with ministry representatives."
98	**Margit Hofer (33:05):** "Mm-hmm."
99	**H2-1 (33:05):** "It’s valuable to have direct discussions—even if the local representatives differ from ministry officials, the mix is beneficial."
100	**H2-2_X (33:10):** [No response]
101	**H2-1 (33:11):** "Even though sometimes the local participants aren’t the same as ministry officials, having both perspectives is useful."
102	**H2-2_X (33:23):** "Ministers, however, are a bit removed from the real issues stakeholders face; they’re somewhat out of touch."
103	**H2-1 (33:24):** "Exactly—they might not fully grasp the local challenges."
104	**H2-2_X (33:31):** "They are somewhat removed from day-to-day issues."
105	**H2-1 (33:34):** "Yes, precisely."
106	**H2-2_X (33:36):** "Ministers tend to be distant from the real-life issues that stakeholders experience."
107	**Margit Hofer (33:50):** "Okay—so to summarize, there’s a difference between political stakeholders and business

	people. The political ones operate in a different level than the local business people, correct?"
108	**H2-2_X (34:18):** [No response]
109	**Margit Hofer (34:23):** We were discussing political stakeholders versus business people. You're saying there's a disconnect because top-level ministry decision-makers aren't as connected to local issues as regional agencies are?"
110	**H2-2_X (34:47):** "Hold on, H2-1—please clarify. She's referring to top-level ministry decision-making versus local agencies that are much closer to the issues people face."
111	**Margit Hofer (35:14):** "Yes."
112	**H2-2_X (35:15):** "So, H2-1, please be clear: in our project, the central political stakeholders differ from the local ones who work directly with local issues."
113	**Margit Hofer (35:21):** "Mm-hmm."
114	**H2-1 (35:23):** "Yes, exactly."
115	**H2-2_ (35:33):** "We have to be careful to distinguish between the top administrative tiers and the local stakeholders."
116	**H2-1 (35:44):** "Absolutely."
117	**H2-2_ (35:48):** "Often, there's a disconnect between top-level administration and those on the ground."
118	**H2-1 (35:50):** "Yes, that's correct."
119	**H2-2_ (36:12):** "We need to be very careful here."

120	**H2-1 (36:18):** "Of course."
121	**Margit Hofer (36:18):** "I think it's similar in Austria—the regional development people understand local needs, whereas in Vienna things run differently. Do you think it would be advantageous to include top ministry officials in activities alongside regional stakeholders, even though they're not in daily contact with farmers or business people?"
122	**H2-1 (36:57):** "Yes. For example, I remember 15 years ago in a (xxx anonomized) programme, there was an option to allocate funds to support the attendance of ministry representatives. When they attended practical events, they gained a better understanding of the economic difficulties faced by entrepreneurs."
123	**H2-2_X (37:51):** "However, the ministry doesn't have the funds to cover their participation, so we must be careful not to place blame—they have specific constraints."
124	**H2-1 (37:55):** "Yes, exactly."
125	**H2-2_X (38:13):** "We need to be cautious and not accuse them of being uninformed."
126	**H2-1 (38:18):** "Yes, of course."
127	**H2-2_X (38:20):** "Just to explain a bit better: thanks to those projects, some Ministry of Economy representatives later supported the creation of the H2-hub Cluster Association and other financing lines in the national budget for cluster development."
128	**Margit Hofer (38:57):** "Understood. Now, how will you ensure that your bioeconomy sustains in your region after the project ends?"
129	**H2-1 (39:13):** "The people in our region really care about their area. They practice bioeconomy—even if they don't call it that—because the Regional Development Agency has long supported them. Our project's deliverables, particularly the sustainable strategy, will likely be integrated into the regional development plan. This strategy is inspired by local stakeholder suggestions as well as other ongoing projects."

130 **H2-2_X (39:26):**
"That is a complication—development without the project framework."

131 **Margit Hofer (39:32):**
"Understood correctly."

132 **H2-1 (39:36):**
"People in the region care deeply about their landscape. They continue practicing bioeconomy, supported by the Regional Development Agency, even if they don't label it as such. Our sustainable strategy will eventually become part of the regional development plan and serve as an official document."

133 **H2-2_X (40:42):**
"Sister projects…"

134 **H2-1 (40:44):**
"I mean, the national, local, and regional stakeholders have periodic meetings with the agency. Based on their recommendations, they develop financial lifelines."

135 **H2-2_X (40:46):**
"Not necessarily."

136 **H2-1 (41:04):**
"In the framework of the regional development plan, the financial offer will fulfill these expectations, and the agency will adopt our sustainable strategy as an official document. This was even discussed in our hub meetings—one of the directors participated in our meeting."

137 **H2-2_X (41:44):**
"Actually…"

138 **H2-1 (41:47):**
"Yes, one of the directors was present at our hub meeting."

139 **Margit Hofer (42:09):**
"Okay, thanks. Now, what are your top lessons learned for regions that want to establish their own bioeconomy hub? What are the key points?"

140 **H2-2_X (42:40):**
"Like teaching the followers how to do it?"

141 **Margit Hofer (42:44):**
"Exactly."

142	**H2-1 (42:47):** "First of all, focus on the local bioeconomic potential—understand your resources and traditions. For instance, even xxx hub visiting xxx hub is very beneficial because his visits help advertise his properties here."
143	**H2-2_X (43:11):** "
144	**H2-1 (43:12):** "Yes. It’s very important to have strong local resources. Collaborate with local authorities to identify influential figures within civil society."
145	**H2-2_X (43:18):** "In other words, they need to understand how the local framework and network of interests function."
146	**H2-1 (43:18):** "Exactly. It’s crucial to identify the main interests related to bioeconomy, build contacts, and start from there. In our area, there’s a strong interest in preserving local natural resources, ensuring good administration, and making the best use of what they have."
147	**Margit Hofer (45:17):** "That makes perfect sense. Essentially, you tapped into the strong local interests, understood the stakeholder mentality, and that’s why your bioeconomy initiatives have worked so well within the network."
148	**H2-2_X (45:47):** "You have to align with their interests and stay as close as possible to their local priorities."
149	**Margit Hofer (45:51):** "Mm-hmm."
150	**H2-2_X (45:57):** "Because if you impose something from the top down, they won’t participate."
151	**Margit Hofer (46:05):** "Yes, exactly."
152	**H2-2_X (46:08):** "It has to be built bottom-up."

153 **Margit Hofer (46:09):**
"Very much so."

154 **H2-2_X (46:12):**
"Bottom-up is the only way."

155 **Margit Hofer (46:20):**
"Okay. Is there anything else from your experience that you'd like to add—any other key lesson we haven't mentioned yet?"

156 **H2-1 (46:44):**
"Would you like me to add something else?"

157 **Margit Hofer (46:48):**
"Anything at all—this is an important final point."

158 **H2-1 (47:04):**
"I think it's very important that stakeholders feel they belong to a bigger picture—one that serves the national interest. I was very impressed by the mentality of some influential people in our region. They think not only locally but also in terms of national values and interests. We were fortunate to sometimes receive moral support from the H2-hub Plaster Association, which includes experienced consultants."

159 **H2-2_X (47:45):**
[No response]

160 **H2-1 (48:05):**
"In that organization, one consultant who had worked at the Ministry of Economy during our European project was very helpful. Whenever we needed clarification, I could simply call her or someone else from the association—and they would assist us. They never viewed it as just our project, but as a project in the interest of the country."

161 **Margit Hofer (48:49):**
"That's a nice, common goal you all share."

162 **Margit Hofer (49:15):**
"Thank you so much for your time. We'll clean up this interview and send it to you for review, along with the report, so you can verify that we understood everything correctly. I think I've got a very good picture now. Thanks again, and have a good afternoon."

163 **H2-1 (49:43):**
"You too. Thank you so much. See you—bye."

164	**H2-2_X (49:45):** "Thank you."
165	**Margit Hofer (49:46):** "Thanks a lot. See you then. Bye."
166	
167	Below is a consolidated list of lessons learned and insights drawn from both transcript segments:
168	• Leverage Existing Networks: • Building on pre-existing relationships (e.g., long-term ties with the Regional Development Agency and past European projects) was key to engaging stakeholders.
169	• Understand Local Specificities: • Recognize that even within a relatively homogeneous region, differences in mentality, tradition, ethnicity, and local objectives require tailored approaches for each county or local office.
170	• Establish Dedicated Contact Points: • Having a core hub or contact team—composed of business people who facilitate communication between regional facilitators and other stakeholders—proves crucial, even if those individuals are very busy.
171	• Adopt a Bottom-Up Approach: • Initiatives need to be built from the ground up by aligning with local interests and priorities, rather than imposing solutions from the top down.
172	• Tailor Activities to Stakeholder Preferences: • Organizing events as part of larger local or European gatherings (rather than standalone project events) increases participation and engagement.
173	• Plan Realistically (Time & Budget): • Adequate budgeting and scheduling are essential—especially for activities like study visits—to account for the time constraints of busy business stakeholders.

174

- Focus on Tangible Outcomes:
  - Stakeholders value clear, practical benefits (such as financing opportunities) and are more motivated when outcomes are visible and directly linked to their local needs.

175

- Learn from Consortium Partners:
  - Drawing on experiences and best practices from partners (e.g., The hubs countrys representatives) provided valuable insights and helped adapt strategies effectively.

176

- Differentiate Between Stakeholder Groups:
  - Recognize that local, operational stakeholders (like regional development agents) and top-level political figures have distinct perspectives and incentives, which calls for different engagement strategies.

177

- Foster a Sense of Belonging to a Bigger Picture:
  - Ensuring that stakeholders feel connected to broader national interests—and not just local projects—can enhance commitment and long-term collaboration.

178

- Embrace Flexibility and Humility:
  - Stakeholders' willingness to acknowledge their limitations and collaborate with academic and research institutions underscores the value of openness and adaptability.

179

Transkript

180 13. Februar 2025, 12:03PM

181

MH

Margit Hofer 0:03

And.

I think we're recording now.

OK.

Yeah.

So we are exclusively talking about the hubs, so not about the evaluation, because this is

a very separate task from you. But we are only talking about the hubs and how it was set up and how you felt about it. What were your insights? So that's the main topic basically, OK.

182 CP

H2-1 0:45

I don't know if we could really speak about half mission because.
This half creating created during the this project. It's like a mirror about the past activities.
Of the stakeholders in both also in this project as we already mentioned.
Sometimes during our consult to meetings or other or informal meetings.
There is a core very strong core in in the region. I mean in the central region.
Which gave also the name of the hub.
And the stakeholders are very open mind and we're involved in in many.
National or local, but also very many European project. So they are very familiar with the the European approach and.
The request and and so on and I.
Personally.
Appreciate very much that this stakeholders do not really.
Expect big effect.
During the project and right now they know that the things will happen with the time, with the involvement or or also of other local or regional actors, not.
Not.
They are very, very important. They are maybe the basis for the economic involvement, but other actors are also.
Very important, so to conclude.
The mission, if if we need to, to call it so.
Of of this hub is to continue.
Their willingness.
To.
Be aware about their local potential.
Not only for bio economy, also for other.
Branches of industry and.
To to attract. Maybe this this could be a really mission to attract also.

183 RI
H2-2_X 3:19
None.

184 CP
H2-1 3:24
Other relevant stakeholders for the economy, for the regional economy.
And our me and our role.
The Institute for Economic Forecasting in the framework of H2-hub Academy had the chance to work very close with the many representatives of the business environment during the last 15 years, let's say thanks to to different European project, most of them, but also some national project and.
It was developed on this way.
A very fruitful relationship between.
These institutions, and it was natural to continue the collaboration also for implementing the RuralBioUp.

185 MH
Margit Hofer 4:26
So basically you started already with an existing network, right? Yeah. And then you were like continuing this work with this network. My question would be, I mean obviously you managed well to have a network.

186 RI
H2-2_X 4:33
None.

187 MH
Margit Hofer 4:43
How do you how do you keep the stakeholders involved and engaged? Why do you think they are still motivated to participate in these activities? What is the reason for that?

188 CP
H2-1 4:56
The the real reason is that, as I said, there is a core, the hub contact point.
Which represents also the green plaster, the green energy cluster, which on it's turning also involves in some other European project also in the frame of Horizon Europe programme and also on this field by economy and they they.

Where this half contact point built by two or three people.
Well, where every time available to intermediate the the relationship between us as regional facilitator and the other state Helders.

189 MH
Margit Hofer 5:56
You are saying if I understand correctly that these contact points that they would play a crucial role.

190 CP
H2-1 6:07
Crucial but.
They are. They are business people. They are very busy and they will want to.
Be able but they want to.
Wish to to dedicate such.
Time to the administrative activities as we did in in this project, but.
They they first of all, they understood the project, the objective of the project.
And they were very open to recommend us, the stakeholders who we would need and who who we should to invite in the project activities.
It was.

191 MH
Margit Hofer 7:01
Mm hmm.

192 CP
H2-1 7:03
Did I look at how do you say rachipl? It was a mutual.
Or a relationship based on mutual.
Benefit.

193 MH
Margit Hofer 7:16
OK so.
When you are thinking on the first phase of rule bio app, when you were asked to OK please do set up your network or sort of motivate your network. What what are the major

challenges to set up such a network? What do you think or what was tricky for you? What was a bit of an issue?

194 CP

H2-1 7:44

As I said, the network.
Did exist at at that moment and.
Maybe the network was.
Little bit develop and improve thanks to the requirement of the project.
And.
Thanks to the clusters which the local clusters which worked with our institute, they were available and curious and full.
They you were they agreed to to be engaged.
The project activity, there's a natural process actually.
We didn't need to for them in a way for us.

195 MH

Margit Hofer 8:41

So would you say that the the aim of the project fitted very well together with the interest of the stakeholders? OK, OK.

196 RI

H2-2_X 8:45

None.

197 CP

H2-1 8:49

Yes, yes, yes.
And let me allow me, please also to mention without to know, we prepared in a way this new project will by off because with the Court of the of the pop contact point, we will work very, very close together in a previous European project, be rural and that project was dedicated to a smaller.
Area of the bigger region xxxx. It was only at the level of county.
And.
As I said, it was a natural continuation actually.

198 MH

Margit Hofer 9:34

Since you mentioned the size of your hub, do you have the impression that it's easier to work with a smaller group of people, or do you see an advantage to work with a bigger region because at some point I had done an interview with the French people and they were saying 1 issue for them was really the size of the hub. Was it the same for you?

199 CP

H2-1 9:57

Yes, yes. And for us, for example.
Hard to hard to believe, but in in this region, our region.
There are 6 counties and they are not so different, but they have.
Some specificities.
Related to.
Mentality, tradition, ethnicity. Because the area is multicultural.
And we, we had a real great support from the regional development from the regional Agency for Development.
Who that which knows the people?
The local authorities and so on, and they work together. But as you already mentioned, on smaller groups, that's why we organise more happy things.
Two, two different kickoff meetings in in four different.
Days and so on.
It all, all all this required a kind of special coordination in in our opinion. So we do have this.

200 MH

Margit Hofer 11:14

Mm hmm.
Oh yeah, this is this interview's only about your opinion and how how you did it in your half. So what I understand from you is if I may summarise, first of all this collaboration with regional development institution is a good thing or was a good thing for you. And then it also have like.
In your hub you had like different interests possibly or different approaches in your stakeholder groups.
So how did you manage to to combine these different interests? So how?

201 CP

H2-1 12:00

Well, not not, not not. Excuse me. My gift. Not different approaches. What different mentality and maybe smaller interest, different interest. But with the small differences. But even though you have to to understand very well as regional facilitators.
The specificity of smaller areas, for example, the regional Agency for Development.
Has six different offices local offices.
Because they have such different.
Not different, but with with the small they have.
Objective object staying general objective but with small difference specific object.
At at local level.

202 MH

Margit Hofer 13:01

OK, so basically what you did was you organised.
Different activities and more activities, specifically with.
Our special adapted to very specific target groups, right? OK. And this was a very good strategy for you. Yeah, obviously because it worked out, right.

203 CP

H2-1 13:17

Yes.
Yes. And we had to to adapt we already.
Had worked.
With the smaller areas.
And.
We knew from our work experience.

204 MH

Margit Hofer 13:39

So so you also knew?
OK, so basically you knew already your target groups already. They will correct.
So this is a big advantage from from this perspective, right? OK.

205 CP

H2-1 13:54

But with with years ago.

We had also.
Big challenges we had to learn the local state.

206 MH
Margit Hofer 14:07
Yeah, now looking.

207 CP
H2-1 14:07
And.

208 MH
Margit Hofer 14:10
And looking backwards, what were the best strategies to set up such a network? I mean, if if you look back.
In these recent years where you set up that network, what were the really good strategies that you would also recommend to other regions that would like to set up a similar network?

209 CP
H2-1 14:31
To work with first of all with the, let's say regional not to with special local but the regional.
Association.

210 RI
H2-2_X 14:42
Development agency.

211 CP
H2-1 14:46
Professional association and in in our case there were the plaster.

212 MH
Margit Hofer 14:46
Mm hmm.

213 CP
H2-1 14:53
They are very good to organise the entities.

And very specific.
And.
I I explained maybe with another occasions this gentle region is in the middle of the country.

214 RI
H2-2_X 15:04
None.

215 CP
H2-1 15:13
And contains.
3 minority that will help help me, the Hungarian one, the German one.
And the the H2-hub.

216 RI
H2-2_X 15:28
And also some areas smaller aroma xxxx population.

217 CP
H2-1 15:32
Yes, yes. And they had during the history they had to to live together and that's why maybe they are more flexible.
Or more.
Than the South.

218 RI
H2-2_X 15:49
A relatively strong minority, so.
They are strong minorities.

219 CP
H2-1 15:57
Yes, yes.
And they they succeed to to.
Build a community, a multicultural community.

220 MH
Margit Hofer 16:10
OK.

221 RI
H2-2_X 16:11
I'm very serious development of the area.

222 MH
Margit Hofer 16:16
K.

223 RI
H2-2_X 16:16
Long term on long term meaning they are working not on 2-3 years projects but on.
Multiple.
Periods of projects, but then do I say right, H2-1?

224 CP
H2-1 16:33
Yes.

225 MH
Margit Hofer 16:35
OK.

226 RI
H2-2_X 16:35
So it's a long journey leisure.
In the area advantage of this specific region, to put it crisis.

227 MH
Margit Hofer 16:40
OK.

228 CP
H2-1 16:45
And do one more thing, if I may. I observed they are very.

229 MH
Margit Hofer 16:46
Mm hmm.

230 CP
H2-1 16:53
Modest ralluka.
It's correct in English.

231 RI
H2-2_X 16:57
Yeah, they don't.

232 CP
H2-1 16:59
But I mean they they know a lot, but they do look after the collaboration with the the academ with the Research Institute.

233 RI
H2-2_X 17:09
They don't know everything.

234 CP
H2-1 17:11
And universities and.
In other areas in in the country, very hard they they admit that they need also the people from.

235 RI
H2-2_X 17:24
You know why the cluster vision with?
Multiple actors. How do I call it the cluster approach, H2-1? It was with three.
Academia.

236 CP
H2-1 17:38
Yes, triple helic, triple helic and.

237 RI
H2-2_X 17:40

Research and.
Business people, civil society. So they are really working strong with this vision.
So it's a specificity of the region.

238 MH
Margit Hofer 17:51
Mm hmm.
OK, so you put what you are observing is that you had a very heterogenous group, so many or at least they are looking around or or. They're open for collaboration. Is that correct?

239 CP
H2-1 18:09
Yes, yes.

240 MH
Margit Hofer 18:12
K.
Is there something where you are saying?
During this last two years, or 2 1/2 years in RuralBioUp, is there anything where you say you would do differently?

241 CP
H2-1 18:29
Maybe related to the application form?

242 MH
Margit Hofer 18:35
OK.
Right.

243 RI
H2-2_X 18:44
OK.

244 MH
Margit Hofer 18:48
Did you also receive some feedback from the stakeholders or from those people you were working with?

245 RI
H2-2_X 18:53
None.

246 MH
Margit Hofer 18:55
And what type of feedback was that?

247 CP
H2-1 18:59
As I said, they are really patient, but.
Almost at every occasion they ask about the financing opportunities.
Based on the participation on their participation to the project, because as I said, they are business people.
They do care about their region and the future, but.
They have to deal with the economic difficulties.

248 MH
Margit Hofer 19:36
Of course.

249 CP
H2-1 19:37
I was very impressed to, for example, during the previous European project, be rural already mentioned.
That they even they were so upset and.
They participate to all our online events.
During the pandemic I I mean.

250 MH
Margit Hofer 20:01
Mm hmm.

251 RI
H2-2_X 20:02
Because of the economy downturn during the pandemic.

252 CP
H2-1 20:05

Yes.
And maybe you know.
In Yash, our confidence will organise under the European Commission's support to during the European, in the framework of this European.

253 RI
H2-2_X 20:26
Cluster meeting.

254 CP
H2-1 20:27
Yes, or European TV or how we call it clusters, meet regions and during the pandemic.
The Spanish Presidency organised.
The Nice weekly online.
Meetings.
Related regarding the the economic difficulties and opportunities to collaborate between the European actors belonging to the cluster and they they in a way we did do at that time the same in our.
Project we wrote that.

255 MH
Margit Hofer 21:11
So this was, yeah.

256 CP
H2-1 21:12
What? Excuse me? What? What would I try to do? Underline that this project.
Maybe should have also.
A more practical result.

257 MH
Margit Hofer 21:28
Mm hmm.

258 CP
H2-1 21:28
They expect something from these projects.

259 RI
H2-2_X 21:32
None.

260 MH
Margit Hofer 21:34
Mm hmm yeah.
In terms of practical results, what exactly are you thinking on? Do you think about like?

261 RI
H2-2_X 21:41
None.

262 MH
Margit Hofer 21:50
Guidelines on how to receive funding or OK, so do I also understand you correctly? Because one thing is very interesting. What you are saying. They were still taking part even in the online trainings, any online activities?

263 CP
H2-1 21:54
Yeah.

264 MH
Margit Hofer 22:07
And this is actually something where the French people, as example has had huge hassles because they were saying for them it was really only the face to face meetings that worked but not at all the online meetings and not at all the online trainings.

265 CP
H2-1 22:22
No, please, please, please understand me correctly.
During the pandemic.

266 MH
Margit Hofer 22:30
OK.

267 RI
H2-2_X 22:30
No.

268 MH
Margit Hofer 22:33
OK. And how do you feel about now, I mean about any the pandemic is over, so which activities or actions work best in your hub?

269 CP
H2-1 22:45
Very pandemic actually.

270 RI
H2-2_X 22:47
No, no, no, not now. No, H2-1. No. But then he was the other project we're talking about. Rural development by all.

271 MH
Margit Hofer 22:48
No, not in the pandemics, no.

272 CP
H2-1 22:58
Could you repeat the question please, Margaret?

273 MH
Margit Hofer 23:01
When you did activities with your stakeholder groups, which of these activities worked best in your hub?

274 CP
H2-1 23:12
Maybe it is a particularity, but I observe that if we organise something.
In association with other events.
Belonging to other European similar European projects or local events, or I don't know, conferences at the university, that the local universities, the people are are really interested because they find out.
More things in the field and they they they feel connected to to a active life, but just to

organise a separate event dedicated only to the rule by app project.
Brought us not so many. Not so big. Old. Yes. And we understood this very quickly. And and that's why we're here.
Our most.
Events are organised in cooperation with others.

275 MH
Margit Hofer 24:25
OK. So one challenge was then obviously for you also to find different other.
Corporation partners where you were able to do some common events. Is that correct?

276 CP
H2-1 24:39
Oh, it's not so difficult because we know each other as I know in the region and for example, the regional development Agency invited us also to to.
Their events in the field, I mean circular economy by economy and so on.
And.
It was very natural to to call the rate and to support each other.
The the the excuse me, the most difficult was.
The start to to communicate in the view time about this event because every institution has.
A busy agenda and so on. And.
This was maybe a little bit difficult, but.

277 MH
Margit Hofer 25:33
OK, so it was more like a time constraint and a timing issue that you were observing. OK, OK.

278 CP
H2-1 25:38
Yes, yes.

279 MH
Margit Hofer 25:43
Was were there any structures or support?
That were that was helpful for you during the implementation. I mean, what else you were

saying? The corporation was one thing that was really made it easy to implement activities and actions. Was there anything else you could think of?
You're totally professional. So you know how to set up activities and actions and meetings and so on.
But in case you would be a region that would like to set up hubs and activities, what would you recommend these regions?

280 CP
H2-1 26:25
I'm not sure if I really understood the question, but for us was very helpful.
To to find out how did or so the other consortium partner.
Because I I was very honestly, I was very inspired from the colleagues very inspired because actually we we work in other European projects with.
The hubs countrys representatives, but we started actually with them 15 years ago, maybe between our countries there are a lot of scenari.
OS.
And.
Actually, from every consortium partner we learned out when and we let us inspire. This was very, very good.
We we learn about something from their approach.
And we try yes it to, to to our situation.

281 MH
Margit Hofer 27:32
OK, very good.
OK.
Did you took also part in the study visits? Did you have the impression that also the study visits?
Were helpful for you because you were saying it was good to see. You know how the others do that and this hub exchange.
I think you also took part in the study visits, right?
Was that also something?

282 CP
H2-1 28:01
Well, actually I did.

It's looking this was the point a little bit too.
Asked by our stakeholder for example, to compare to other European projects.
There there where the the appropriate budgets to cover the study. Visit also for the stakeholder. But in our case it was not.
It was not the case.
And that's why maybe it would have been more helpful if we would have enough budget for public visit.

283 MH
Margit Hofer 28:47
OK.

284 CP
H2-1 28:47
This is I I was asked about, for example the.
Claspers representative, when and how and because they do not have the enough financial resources to take part on such statutory it's also, for example the projects scale up.
Organise the something very interesting. We know the coordinator because she coordinated also the Bureau of Project and we were invited, but it was not.
Possible.

285 MH
Margit Hofer 29:26
Oh, OK, so basically what you're saying the next time you would need to have a little bit more budget or actually quite sufficient budget in order to foster more this exchange with, as an example the The hubs countrys since 1:00.

286 CP
H2-1 29:37
Yes, yes, yes.

287 MH
Margit Hofer 29:41
And do you think that this additional budget or this study visits would have been?
A fruitful exchange do you in principle think that this study visits would make sense?
Mm hmm.

288 CP
H2-1 30:07
We identified some common issues in the activities of our stakeholders.

289 RI
H2-2_X 30:12
None.

290 CP
H2-1 30:17
I was a little bit disappointed. May I recognise that they they were not.
At the necessary time, I don't know. For example, the The hubs countrys college would have the money, but they didn't have the time to come in. Even if we plan this with a month ago, I don't know.

291 MH
Margit Hofer 30:43
OK. Yeah.

292 CP
H2-1 30:44
Because I I have to admit they are really they are stakeholders, are really very business busy business people and they are involved in in many activities they go to work fairs and and so on.

293 MH
Margit Hofer 31:02
Mm hmm. So that would mean that we need, we would need to find good incentives for them to come, right?

294 CP
H2-1 31:13
Yes, yes, because in particular.

295 MH
Margit Hofer 31:15
OK.

296 CP
H2-1 31:19

One The hubs countrys colleagues, one of the The hubs countrys colleagues who came to Yash.
Said to me that they are really interested and the two or three maybe would come, but I don't know. They are in their approach. It could be a very.
Good organised team.
To come to a study with so it was not possible.

297 MH
Margit Hofer 31:49
Mm hmm.
Are there any other activities where you think that would be beneficial for a help or for network?
If you would have sufficient money, what would you do?

298 CP
H2-1 32:14
For example, I would do sure the travel expenses for the.
Representative of the regional authorities and all the ministries in charge with the field.
We are involved in.
This is very important, very important, because we we have some.

299 RI
H2-2_X 32:37
None.

300 CP
H2-1 32:42
Friends or people who?
We work with whom we work and so on, and they try to participate to some of our events, but we did not receive all this. But when it happened, the stakeholders.

301 RI
H2-2_X 32:57
None.

302 CP
H2-1 33:03
Were really, really very pleased.

303 MH
Margit Hofer 33:05
Mm hmm.

304 CP
H2-1 33:05
To to have the opportunity to.
Discuss directly.

305 RI
H2-2_X 33:10
None.

306 CP
H2-1 33:11
With the representatives from ministry expression.
'Cause they are very good constraints, right? Not.

307 RI
H2-2_X 33:23
The chair.

308 CP
H2-1 33:24
It may not be the local boy. Let them promote early stakeholder.

309 RI
H2-2_X 33:31
She has some picture in the portal.

310 CP
H2-1 33:34
Minister.

311 RI
H2-2_X 33:36
The ministers are a little bit away from the real life issues that stakeholders are facing.
They are a little bit in in others.
Years.
To put it I don't know what I'm saying, right? But there are technical.

312 MH
Margit Hofer 33:50
OK. So would you.
OK so.
Is it? Is it correct if I would summarise it under the topic that's saying?
That, oh, excuse me just a minute.

313 RI
H2-2_X 34:18
None.

314 MH
Margit Hofer 34:23
Sorry, my daughter touched the ring. 100 of apologies.
Yeah, we were about the the political stakeholders and the business people. So you're saying that they're sort of not the same understanding a bit, so that the political people are a bit in a different streamline than the business people.

315 RI
H2-2_X 34:47
No. Hold on a little bit, H2-1. I think you should be more clarifying here.
She was talking about ministry top level, very much central level political decision making, while the local ones like the central regions and the agency.
Is very well connected to the issues that people have.

316 MH
Margit Hofer 35:14
Yeah.

317 RI
H2-2_X 35:15
That she was talking about the Central High Level administration. So I I, H2-1 please correct me, but please be very clear about this, because political stakeholders, if you are talking for our project that's are direct.

318 MH
Margit Hofer 35:21
Mm hmm.

319 CP
H2-1 35:23
Yes, yes, yes, I mean, I mean.
For.

320 RI
H2-2_X 35:33
Different original development agency, which is very, very close to the issue that business stakeholders and other stakeholders are facing are doing their best to help them.

321 CP
H2-1 35:44
Yes.
Yes.

322 RI
H2-2_X 35:48
If OK, so we have to be very careful about distinction and the central part tiers of administrative power that probably what is in every country, it's a little bit of a disconnect between the top, top, top, top administration political levels and the top.

323 CP
H2-1 35:50
Yes.
Yes.
Yes.

324 RI
H2-2_X 36:12
The real down.
We have to be very careful here. Excuse me, but.

325 CP
H2-1 36:18
Of course, but.

326 MH
Margit Hofer 36:18
Yeah, I think I do understand you. I think it's it's a bit the same in Austria too, so.

The regional development people, they are, they aware about the regions and about the needs of the stakeholders.
While in Vienna, things run a bit differently, so this is. Yeah. Do you think it would be an advantage to include like these top people from ministry into different into different activities and actions and bring them together with the regional stakeholders?
The local don't know farmers, business people and so on.

327 CP
H2-1 36:57
Yes. For example, I I remember at the beginning.
15 years ago, we were involved in the project in the framework of Southeast Europe programme.
And it was a possibility in this programme.
To allocate some funds in the total budget.
Who to support the assistance of the representatives from ministry?
Because if if they come to to very practical.
Events in such a project is our they are, they have the chance to understand better the the economic difficulties of the entrepreneurs especially.

328 RI
H2-2_X 37:51
But but the ministry does not have the money to announce them, so the work we have to be a very figure about these issues because you don't want to how to put it to say well, they don't know. They have certain very specific reasons why they don't. They are not able to lower everything meaning.

329 CP
H2-1 37:55
Yes, we, yes.
Yes.
Yes.

330 RI
H2-2_X 38:13
We have to be very careful, not large accusations that people are not informed.

331 CP
H2-1 38:18
Yes, yes, of course.

332 RI
H2-2_X 38:20
Levels so.

333 CP
H2-1 38:21
And just to to explain a little bit better, thanks to to the to those projects, at least at the Ministry of Economy, some representatives supported a little years later the constructions of the H2-hub Cluster Association and other financing.
Lines in the national budget for helping the cluster.
Thanks to to those European project at the beginning.

334 MH
Margit Hofer 38:57
Yeah, OK, I understand.
Now my question would then be how will you continue? So how will you make sure that your bio economy?
Will sustain in a way.

335 CP
H2-1 39:13
In in that region or how?

336 RI
H2-2_X 39:13
This is complication.
H2-1, after the project, after the end of the system, ability issue of the action plan.

337 MH
Margit Hofer 39:17
Yeah, in your region.
Yeah, exactly.

338 RI
H2-2_X 39:26

Development without the project.
Right.

339 CP
H2-1 39:31
As I said, we are not in a way because.

340 MH
Margit Hofer 39:32
Understood correctly.

341 CP
H2-1 39:36
The the people in the region do care about their area. They are landscape.
They they practise by economy without to know that it is called by economy, since a lot don't period of time, the regional Development Agency supports them and is.
And nose.
Our project and it's deliverables. I meant, I mean this sustainable strategy which you I think it would be considered also by the Regional Development Agency in the near future and because they they.
Let me inspired about the suggestions of the local stakeholders and also from the of the other projects ongoing project and it would be the case I I suppose also.

342 RI
H2-2_X 40:42
Sister projects the sister.

343 CP
H2-1 40:44
No, no, I mean the national, local, regional, they they have periodical meetings. I mean, this video development agency with the stakeholders and based on on their recommendations, they develop financial life lines.

344 RI
H2-2_X 40:46
Not necessary.

345 CP
H2-1 41:04

Or access.
It's more correct in the framework of regional development plan.
So they are, they are, they are.
Expectations will be fulfilled with this financial offer and and then I think that they.
Will use the original development agency as a as an official document. Also, this sustainable strategy of our hub at the end of the day.

346 RI
H2-2_X 41:44
Actually.

347 CP
H2-1 41:47
Because it was discussed in in our hop meetings at which also the Regional Development Agency to park representatives of it and even the director, it's like one of the It's directors took place for our half meeting.

348 RI
H2-2_X 41:47
He actually.

349 MH
Margit Hofer 42:09
OK, baby, thanks.
I'm just looking at my questions, yeah.
There're not many left.
But what are your top lessons learned? Foreign regions wanting to establish their own bio economy hub?
So what are these really important points? If you want to set up a bio economy hub?

350 RI
H2-2_X 42:40
Like teaching the followers.
How to do it?

351 MH
Margit Hofer 42:44
Sexy.

352 CP
H2-1 42:47
Looking first of all, at the local biocompatential.
And the idea on the resources and the traditions.
Because.
If you know maybe.
Even.
The.
Prince Charles of the Great Britain visit.

353 RI
H2-2_X 43:11
King Charles.

354 CP
H2-1 43:12
Continues to visit Transylvania and so on is the best.

355 RI
H2-2_X 43:18
His properties here.

356 CP
H2-1 43:18
Advertise. Yeah. So it's it's very important.

357 RI
H2-2_X 43:22
No, for real.
Are his properties.

358 CP
H2-1 43:25
Yes, yes, it's very important to have local resources.
This is first of all to to collaborate with the local authorities to find influence representatives of the.
Social society.
Of the civil Society of the Civil society.

359 RI

H2-2_X 43:54

Say something. They need to know the way the local frame frameworks and local network of interests is functioning. First of all, that's the most important thing, and know what are the.

360 CP

H2-1 43:55

Please.

361 RI

H2-2_X 44:14

Main interests that would relate to.
Buy economy issues.
Does it make sense what I'm saying and then?
Build contact those people and be start building from there.
Because in our area it was a strong interest in local resources maintaining local environmental natural resources.
Good administration to put it like this conservation and good use of local people became aware of what they have. Am I right, H2-1? Do I say right?
And being aware of their potential.
And their willingness to preserve it and make the best use of it.
Does it make sense?
So a good local 1.

362 MH

Margit Hofer 45:17

For me, it totally makes sense. So basically you hooked up with a very strong interest of the stakeholders. You try to understand the mentality and how these networks or these stakeholders worked. And this is sort of where you started to to implement the bioeconomy and where you started to implement the activities and in actions. And this is also the reason why it worked out so well with you within this network.
Is that correct?

363 RI

H2-2_X 45:47

You have to blend on their interest and and yet as close as you can to their local interests.

364 MH
Margit Hofer 45:51
Mm hmm.
Mm hmm.

365 RI
H2-2_X 45:57
Because otherwise they won't come, they won't care.
Does it make sense?

366 MH
Margit Hofer 46:05
Yes. Yeah.

367 RI
H2-2_X 46:08
You cannot impose it top down.

368 MH
Margit Hofer 46:09
Very much.

369 RI
H2-2_X 46:12
You have to build it bottom up.

370 MH
Margit Hofer 46:20
OK. Is there anything else in your experience where you are saying, OK, this is something I explicitly want to mention or something where I'm where you are saying, OK, this is something I want to point out or this was something very important that we haven't mentioned so far.
Did I squeeze you out already?

371 CP
H2-1 46:44
If I forward something or what?

372 MH
Margit Hofer 46:48

Anything. It could be anything. What you are saying. OK, this was something totally important. And this is something I still want to mention. This was a very important lessons learned that we haven't talked about so far.

373 CP

H2-1 47:04

Well, I think it's very important to.

That that somebody feels that belong to, to.

An to a bigger picture to and in our case to to the.

National interest. I was very impressed about.

Their.

About the mentality of some of the influence persons in in the region, I think.

And this courting, because they think also to the national values and and interest. And in our case we we were very lucky to have the support sometimes only the moral support of the H2-hub Plaster Association because there are some consultants.

374 RI

H2-2_X 47:45

None.

375 CP

H2-1 48:05

In this organisation, with a huge experience.

One of them worked at the Ministry of Economy during the time we had this. Those mentioned the European project.

And when we'd like to clarify some aspects, I I simply call her or somebody else from the association. And if it is possible, they they help us, they don't think that it it is all. It's about our project but of the project in interest of the country at the end.

376 MH

Margit Hofer 48:49

K Yeah, it's a nice common goal you have, right?

OK.

Then I think.

I'm I think we've covered all the questions that we've noted down here. I mean, we jumped a bit back and forward, but it was a very interesting interview. Thank you so much.

377 RI
H2-2_X 49:07
None.

378 CP
H2-1 49:14
We thank you.

379 MH
Margit Hofer 49:15
And and thanks for your time. And then we will do it. As I mentioned beforehand. So we clean up the interview and yeah, and then we'll send it to you. You go through it, but also for the report itself, we will send it to you beforehand so you can have a check and you can have a look just in case that you are sort of that we understood everything correctly. But I think I got a very good picture. Again, thanks for your time and have a good afternoon, OK.

380 CP
H2-1 49:43
You too. Thank you so much. Thank you. Thank you. See you. Bye.

381 RI
H2-2_X 49:45
Thank you. Thank you.

382 MH
Margit Hofer 49:46
Thanks a lot. See you then. OK bye.

383 CP
H2-1 49:55
I don't know how to do.

384
Margit Hofer Transkription beendet

Interview Lessons Learned H3 Hub

1 **Transkript**

2 19. Februar 2025, 09:03AM

3 ML
0:04
Yes.
OK, now I started the recording.
I will now go just through, you know, the different phases that we had in the project and then for each phase you try to remember what in your app, what worked well, what maybe did not work so well, what would have to help you to, to to, to better manage the challenges.
What are maybe good activities that you implemented that you would kind of recommend to to other hubs and and so on?
But let me start just by asking very generally, how would you summarise like the main purpose of your hub?
Like in a few sentences, what was the main?
The reason for existence of your hub. What did you want to achieve in the end, summarising in a few sentences?

4 KC
0:54
I probably.
Probably I will start.

5 ML
0:59
Yes, please.

6 KC
H3 1:00
We decided to establish the hub in a region which is in economic troubles, Let's say like this because it's a region supported by a just transition funds. So this region has a very long history of mining and now the mines are going to close and the economic basis / work of the region should be somehow transformed. So that was the first reason why we

choose the H3region. Also we know that there is Brain Drain of young People. ML Because the young people, even the educated, graduated people leave the region to abroad, because It's a border region with Germany. so a lot of people in this region are travelling for a job to Germany.

7 KC

H3 H3 2:29

So, Troubles in this region and we believe that through bioeconomic and the hub, networking and these support we can help them to stay and start to start to thinking about building value change and start to making some business in the region and stay in the region and not to leave the villages and even the city centres and so on.

8 ML

2:38

Mm hmm.

Yeah, yeah. And now after, after the implementing the hubs in the last years, do you feel that you succeeded in these two main challenges, like the brain drain and finding new kind of value chains for the regions? How do you see the success of your hub?

9 KC

H3 3:16

It's a hard and probably tricky question, and always people in a team saying that I'm too modest. So, I would say that not yet, but it's only two years and people still ML ..Not afraid, but... you know we have a Soviet history and people are rather shy ML To try something new and go for a new business and start to think about startups and so on. We are rather conservative and if we would like to start something new, usually we need something that we know that money comes back to us if we invest ML. We need some trust that it know we will not go bankrupt.

10 ML

4:16

Yeah.

OK.

11 KC

H3 4:21

So probably this is too short way or too short, very odd to say that the project help this

region, but H3-2is speaking with people in the region more than me, so probably she would she would be more optimistic but she's smiling.

12 ML
4:25
Yeah.
Yeah, I mean yeah, because it's it's it's very, it's very ambitious. Of course the objectives that you, I mean as you said, I mean it's it's of course long term objectives and very, very big economic objectives. But maybe you can and I find it very interesting because you say it's mainly also about changing culture, changing attitudes and that's of course nothing that you can do in a in a project in two years. But maybe you have like.

13 H
H3-2 4:42
None.

14 ML
Martina Lindorfer 5:05
Little pieces, let's say, of evidence for first successes.

15 KC
H3 H3-3 H3 5:11
Do we have some? I I think small, but H3-2 probably will follow.

16 H
H3-2 5:16
Yeah, I agree with H3. We we have the main thing in this region, the young people because they're leaving for universities and then they're not coming back. But and this is really for a long, long term. ML H
Maybe what we are having now is a vision of something, of a change. ML We are bringing this to this region.
Some new businesses... we are trying to connect with different businesses; trying to get them into this region to show them this is the place where they have space and they can do their, you know, business from the start. and yeah, we have a connection to some little businesses.

17 ML
Martina Lindorfer 6:22

Yeah.
Yeah. And maybe I'm, I imagine, a spiral economy is like a more like a modern, let's say, economic.

18 H
H3-2 6:28
This is maybe.
Exactly, and if?

19 ML
Martina Lindorfer 6:35
Change so maybe it's also easier to work than with the younger generation that are more open instead of like the older, more classic generations.

20 H
H3-2 6:45
Exactly, exactly. But it goes slowly. Somebody has to start and then others will come.

21 ML
Martina Lindorfer 6:48
Yeah. Yes.
Yes, I understand.
OK. Then maybe you can shortly say what was your role in the project, your main roles and responsibilities? And also, I mean, how did you go about this in the in in your, in the checkup, did you have very clear roles and very clear hub structure or was it rather like whoever has time does whatever comes next?

22 KC
H3 H3-3 H3 7:17
It helped us a lot that we have the national hub ML, Because then we have some, you know Headquarters or how to say it so. So then there is a probably, you know, Ms x (anonomyzed) and Mr x (anonomiezed). So they are the heads of the national hub. They have a very good connections. So they built up a network between the stakeholders ML KC and even the policy makers and th ML ese groups of population. And I and H3-2we are rather regional let's say managers. My role, especially my role, is rather a project manager rather to collect network and to listen and do what the national hubs
Want to implement in in the regional. So there is the CEO, Let's say. I'm somehow

cooperating with H3-2to implement it in the region and Hana's role I see rather local facilitator? How you would call it your role?

23 ML

24 H
H3-2 8:57
Maybe something like that. I wasn't in the project from beginning, so.

25 ML
Martina Lindorfer 8:59
Yeah, yeah.

26 H
H3-2 9:01
I was sorry, but yeah.

27 KC
H3 H3-3 H3 9:03
H3-2 came in a time when we saw that we need to be more in a contact with the people in the in the region. So when we saw that it's impossible to...
Somehow from the main capital, just observe and sending emails and so on. We start to cooperate with H3-2and she she's more active in contacting people. She's travelling in the region more than more than we. So she is probably contact point and regional facilitator.

28 ML
Martina Lindorfer 9:42
Yeah, that's that's interesting. That's already a learning that you saw. OK, there was like a role missing this time. More direct link to the people. And then you introduced this role. Would you then say now to set up kind of works very well or would you still see gaps in the structure of the hub that you see some roles maybe or some persons are missing that would have, I don't know, important link to or do you think it's now kind of working out well?

29 KC
H3 H3-3 H3 10:08
H3-2helps us a lot because all of us are sitting in the city centre, you know? So what to do in the region which is 200 kilometres far away?! and H3-2communicates a lot with the

people by travelling to the region. So this is very important for us and helps us a lot! And the CEO brings us some

30 Connections to policymakers or brings a new project, a new money have some, you know, trainings and so on. So they bring they knowledge.
I take care about fitting these knowledges and networking in a project; to fulfil the KPI and so on.
And H3-2communicate with the people and take care about the region. So I think that now it's working good, probably now we can see the gap. Am I right? Do do you think that there should be some some more role to help us in the region?

31 H
H3-2 11:35
I I'm thinking about that.
I don't know now. Now we are like this and it's like just more work this way. And maybe we'll see on the way, but.

32 ML
Martina Lindorfer 11:49
H3-2, do you then have very direct contact also to the to the policy makers or to the governor, local government then in the region that you work in or is it rather really more working with the with the, I don't know with the SMEs and associations?

33 H
H3-2 12:07
Yeah, I I wasn't.
not Directly speaking with somebody from government, but there is a connection via the CEO of Hubs, so.

34 ML
Martina Lindorfer 12:19
OK, OK.
OK. Thank you. That were like more the general questions and I would like to go like to the through the different phases of the project, starting with what we call like the preparatory phase, you know that was like before you even started building your hub, there was about how did you manage to find your concrete scope, your concrete objectives, your, your, your themes, how did you go about identifying the value chains

you wanted to address?
And also assessing the state-of-the-art of the bio economy. So what was your method to like to narrow down this big, this big topic to something very specific for your hub and and yeah, how challenging was that and how did, how did it work out?

35 KC
H3 H3-3 H3 13:05
Again, the national hub helps us a lot. They have the knowledges and a lot of studies and the strategies and analytical documents. ML
Then, especially me, I prepare the desk study: What's the gaps? What's the strong points in in this region, etc.

36 ML Then we start to thinking about the value chains: What's the most promising parts to focus on?

37 ML It was probably October 2023 when we decide to Have some, let's say conference or or networking event.
And we Invited the stakeholders, the policymakers and all the important people which we thought it could be good to have them in a hub. There was a big advantage that the CEO and the national hub has the contact persons, who know the national hub and Who know the people. And because of that, they ML wanted to come for the conference.

38 The conference was rather a Speaking and learning event about what's bio economy? Because the bio economy is not so well known as A term in the H3 country. So it was Some kind of presentation.

39 We even presented boots made from the hemp. So even some Practical things to see that that’s a product of bio economy. So we tried to persuade them that bio economy has a sense and it's a way how to build up development in the region.

40 And then we showed them the SWOT analysis ML and tried to think with them, with the people in in the conference - the stakeholders of our hub - to think what's the best way how to develop the regions? So then we choose the 3 value chains.

41 But all these exercise or all of these discussions were based on massive desk research - based on a lot of analytical documents, strategic documents and so on.

42 ML
Martina Lindorfer 16:14

Yeah.
And was it done challenging for you to kind of because in the end you had to kind of prioritise the topics and so on was it, was it easy to or was it rather challenging to find common to kind of combine the different interests, the different priorities to decide and to really to decide on the three value chains?
Or was it very controversial between the stakeholders?

43 KC
H3 H3-3 H3 16:41

It was mainly based on the discussion and discussion wasn't so tough...because we had the data. So based on these data ... It's logical that we decide for these value chains. So it wasn't so tough or hard to persuade them ML. Ands also because of our background - the CEO is also the director of the research institution.

44 ML Taking care about the crop fields and so on and bi biomass and so on. So because of our background and we know more people in agriculture and this Type of stakeholders. So we decided to go do this way.

45 ML
Martina Lindorfer 17:46
OK. And would you like from them like looking at the method, how you did it with like first doing the test then having this conference, would you do it exactly the same if you did it again or is that is there something that you would do differently if you had to do it again?

46 KC
H3 H3-3 H3 18:04
It's a hard question, I think no, because it was the only way. I can't see another method how to persuade people to come, to show them what is bioeconomy, show them that this is our Task. This is what we would like to support in this region. This is a final product. What you - stakeholders - in in this region can reach.
So it was, I think, the best way how we did it. I can't imagine that we will do it probably online or hybrid or on in a different way and even a few days after the conference, we have a study visit and it was also not so successful. The interest of the people was rather low. Lower then at the conference. So at the conference there were much more people than in a study visit.

47 ML
Martina Lindorfer 19:02
Yeah.
OK.
OK, alright. Interesting. You're the first person who says that.
Why do you think? How come you think?
You don't know.

48 KC
H3 H3-3 H3 19:28
Because we we took them to composting plant. If the people see a thing that it's not their way of a business, probably ...because We also face that if some farmer have a cow and they care about milk and yoghurts and this stuff, they Don't think that their job could also be about composting. They just see their main Business and don't care about the value chain.

49 ML
Martina Lindorfer 20:10
OK, OK.
OK. And why you do you then think that the conference was interesting for the the stakeholders, what what motivated them to go to the conference?

50 KC
H3 H3-3 H3 20:23
I think so. I think so, because at the conference we also had a presentation about Financial subsidies and financial opportunities and this is the topic which is always the best topic.

51 ML
Martina Lindorfer 20:36
OK.
OK. OK. Yeah. Interesting. OK. Thank you. Then let's let's go to the next next next phase. So now you have identified your stakeholders and you have you kind of trying to build up your your network and then the next step is to really work with the stakeholders, that is that was actually your task when you really had to to develop this action action plan with the stakeholders really narrow down concrete actions, concrete.
Milestones.

Create also management structures, harmonising the different interests and also harmonising the actions with the regulatory framework. So how, how did that work out?

52 KC

H3 H3-3 H3 21:20

It was for me. Yeah, it was the first step. When I start to communicate with the stakeholders. And it was just, sending emails and anything comes back to me. So that was that was a few months that we start to think that we really need a person who will be in a More close contact with the stakeholders. So then then H3-2starts to to work on it. And what about the KPIs and goals and these?

53 ML

Martina Lindorfer 21:42

Yeah.

54 KC

H3 H3-3 H3 21:50

Everything happens in the in the. In this conference we started to think about the action plan, about the goals, about the main vision of the hub, and this this action plan; the main pages were written in the conference with the stakeholders. So we guided them through some questions, through the studies, through the data and we Altogether discussed what could be good. And my main role was To be sure that the objectives and tasks will be in, you know, in line with the DOW of the project.

55 So we started with the DOW. What's necessary to be done, then see what's the possibilities in the region and based on the desk studies, we somehow see how to fulfil the KPIs of of the project. So it was somehow the discussion method.

56 ML

57 ML

Martina Lindorfer 23:29

And yeah, and along the way, how then did you still involve the stakeholders after the conference? We had the conference then in the conference you decided on the actions on the timeline and so on and how in the process did you done kind of keep the stakeholders involved in what way with which methods or?

58 H

59 KC

H3 H3-3 H3 23:53

H3-2communicated a lot with them. I know that they have some conference also in a circle of about innovations and so on. Probably, H3-2, it's it's your task or your question and you will answer it better than me because I just know that you invite them and you communicate with them. But I don't know how.

60 H

H3-2 24:10

we had some other conference.
And some meetings there and.
As you said, the KPIs maybe helped us even to get the structure to see what, what, what do we need to do a bit and.
How we kept the interests of people.
Were very hard!
And to be honest, we maybe Got interest of some people, but we lost on the way of the interest and got some others. So we not always Managed to keep the interest of the same people the whole time.

61 But it's slowly and slowly getting better.
But yeah, it's we are still on a long, long way probably.

62 ML

Martina Lindorfer 25:16

Yeah.
Yeah, I understand. Maybe you can tell me on the one hand, what was maybe especially challenging, keeping them on board and on the other hand, we're like maybe also have some concrete examples of what worked well, how did you achieve middle, I don't know, mid little actions or ideas or something that worked out well in, in kind of keeping up the interesting motivating stakeholders.

63 H

H3-2 25:50

To persuade them that. This way, the bio economy is good to be followed. There are ways to.
To.

Which?
Different.
Different.
Interests can can use and you know, and maybe.
Somewhere on the way, we also got interests of some people who were only searching for, for money to get.
But so they lost interest if they saw that. It's also hard work.

64 Not only free money. and on the other hand, we have some people who just are used to hard work.
And they are used for their old ways to do stuff, and they are.
Only it takes time to persuade them that new ways of bio economy.
Which is quite many times connecting to old, old fashioned ways in in agriculture. Actually the composting it's old method. [Martina Idee Handbook: Methoden finden, die das Alte valorisieren und trotzdem Neues ansprechen]

65 ML
Martina Lindorfer 27:20
Yeah.

66 H
H3-2 27:21
So.

67 ML
Martina Lindorfer 27:23
So I am. I understand. Yeah. You said it now several times that. So I need very interesting that you said you had it, that's this you have to work a lot on this culture and attitudes and convincing people to be open to something new. So could you imagine any action, any would you have needed any additional action in the in the in the project maybe to address this more if you could do the project again and you could have I don't know extra funds extra money from I don't know.

68 H
H3-2 27:23
Yeah, but.

69 ML
Martina Lindorfer 27:51
Different or new activities?
Can you think of something that would have helped you to work more on this? You know, convincing people of trying something new and.

70 H
H3-2 28:04
I was thinking about maybe more..trying to more address the younger people and the way younger people are rather to be connected using maybe Some virtual reality or because that's what I saw.
Too.

71 KC
H3 H3-3 H3 28:28
Oh, probably. H3-2lost the connection, so I will continue. She even starts to the same way as us I was thinking, Martina, you know that we together in a bioloc.

72 ML
Martina Lindorfer 28:45

73 KC
H3 H3-3 H3 28:45 in the Bioloc project, the marginalised group which we are focused on is the young unemployment people. H

74 And to be honest, I am so shocked that in the H3region is so classical thinking: “we are not going to do anything more. and we don't know what is bioeconomy and we don't care”. And the more BIOLOC region: if we are speaking with the younger unemployed people - they care! They are asking us, they want to cooperate with us! So you know: one Republic, two regions - and such a different approach of the people! So, it's not about what project actions you do, it's not about the project tasks, it's about the people with whom we are implementing the project!

75 ML
Martina Lindorfer 29:36

76 H

H3-2 29:45

This is this is very much I think connected also with the education in H3Hub region. In H3region we don't have any university. So then you can see that clever people are leaving the region and they're not staying. Young Graduated people, they are almost not there.

77 KC

H3 H3-3 H3 30:12

And in BIOLOC region there is one huge university and also a lots of private universities so.

78 H

H3-2 30:25

Universities, Technical University, yeah.

79 ML

Martina Lindorfer 30:31

Yeah, well, interesting. So I would already come to like the the the general summing up. So would you say in general looking at the whole project, when I ask you now for you, I don't know, 123 main learnings, would this be one of the main learnings to rather address younger people to work more with the younger people and find methods to engage younger people?

80 H

H3-2 30:51

Maybe. Maybe bring it to to schools rather.

81 ML

Martina Lindorfer 30:56

82 KC

H3 H3-3 H3 31:02

Mm hmm.

Yeah, yeah.

83 H

H3-2 31:11

Yeah. We were also connected to like all high schools, which are a little connected with Agriculture or environment and something some subject where they would be interested in bio economy.
So maybe more...More push in this way or more information bring through this channel. Which is not that it will work now, but maybe later. Maybe the young people, the really young people, will start thinking about it later and maybe they will come Back to the region and to start their businesses.

84 KC
H3 H3-3 H3 31:56
I will add something. All projects start with the head hunting of the stakeholders and my advice for your deliverable is to know what your stakeholders are and choose the method how to Persuade them, how to reach them. Because for young people suitbale are the workshops, webinars are cool and they will join it. But in the H3region the old old fashioned thinking people, don't care about webinars or workshops and so on.
So is the method for the stakeholders group.

85 ML
Martina Lindorfer 32:44
OK, so you mean?
Have more time to choose the method instead of choosing the the the the stakeholders.

86 KC
H3 H3-3 H3 32:54
Mm hmm mm hmm.

87 ML
Martina Lindorfer 32:56
OK.
Anything else that comes to your mind like as your main lessons learned from the project? Anything, if you would do it again, imagine you had to do the whole thing again. Something that you maybe would do differently next time.

88 KC
H3 H3-3 H3 33:11
The channel is the important thing.

Face to face interviews, face to face reaching the stakeholders. In Bioloc its more about the webinars and some attractive conferences and so on. The young people like it more.

89 ML Here in the H3region we know that if we start to Be more Strictly face to face orientated, it helps us more. It has a lot. because at the beginning I was just writing e-mail: Please come! Please, there is some opportunity! But no one cared. But if H3-2starts to go on regional travel there and speaking with the people, it helps us.

90 ML
Martina Lindorfer 34:04
Yeah, I understand.
And on the positive side here, of all the activities that you implemented, all the actions, all workshops, whatever, is there something that you found like most if you would have to choose one thing that you found like you're most proud of that, I don't know that was more successful.
You enjoyed most or that you. I don't know. That had the greatest impact or whatever.

91 KC
H3 H3-3 H3 34:34
A hard, hard question. Hana, do you think that you have something in your mind? What's we? What? We are proud of.

92 H
H3-2 34:44
Oh, I don't know. It's just long.

93 ML
Martina Lindorfer 34:46
Don't be modest. Be very be the opposite of modest.

94 H
H3-2 34:48
Hard work.

95 KC
H3 H3-3 H3 34:50
Well, well, I'm. I'm proud that we have some few people, few stakeholders who are still continue some activities with us.

96 ML
Martina Lindorfer 34:59
Yeah, yeah.

97 KC
H3 H3-3 H3 35:02
We probably we could have probably four team members if they if they are interested staying but they we we lost them because they don't care about the the the topics what we offer but we have a few.

98 ML
Martina Lindorfer 35:13
Yeah.

99 KC
H3 H3-3 H3 35:18
We are proud that we have some few core stakeholders, core members and that's I think the success because We know the hard work: To find them, reach out to them. So I'm. I'm glad that cooperate with us. They want the, CEO. XXX (anonomized), prepared some festival. It's called our field. It's festival in open field and they there will be some presentation place and the the stakeholders will come.

100 ML
Martina Lindorfer 35:27
Yeah, yeah.

101 KC
H3 H3-3 H3 35:52
It's free to 200 kilometres far away from the region, and they will come to present themselves. In the festival. So I think that it's great that we have a few of them and they want to follow us and join join the join the the Hub vision.

102 ML
Martina Lindorfer 36:12
Yeah, it's just talking about this has to be sustainability of your have, have you thought about that? Are there any strategies how to keep up your results and your structures?

103 KC
H3 H3-3 H3 36:24

Because we have a national hub, the the we, we will definitely follow with the regional hub. If we start the job and we start to connect the people in the region, we will definitely continue in this this activities if we have some few stakeholders which are cooperating with us.
We will try to find them partners in the region.
And to put them in a value cain somehow.

104 Help them to develop their businesses in the region and.
If now we have some contacts in the region, we will also invite them for another project meeting, because we have also some some national projects which are focused on the development, regional development. So we will definitely.
Try to invite them for another trainings for another workshops. So our job will continue because where the the national hub have the project for the for, for for this field.

105 ML
Martina Lindorfer 37:39
Yeah. Thank you. And then I would come to my very last question now like going more to the European level. Is there anything or do you think what could help on the what is needed on the European level to strengthen the bio economy?
Sector. Is there anything you can think of that you would say European policymakers, any gaps that they're under European level?

106 KC
H3 H3-3 H3 38:06
Yeah, definitely yes. Because I work mainly on the project. When I was in a maternity leave and yeah, at the end of the year, I come back to my my job. I leave the I end the maternity leave and I'm working in the Ministry of Agriculture, which take cares about the bio economy.

107 ML
Martina Lindorfer 38:07
That.
Yeah.

108 KC
H3 H3-3 H3 38:27
And it makes me angry that they don't want to see the bio economy as a priority because

they ask me: “Where is it written that we have to treat bioeconomy as a priority?”. So for for the EU, the policymakers to be more, let's say, not imperative, it's not not good word, but to try to persuade the national politics that bioeconomy is a important topic.

109 ML

Martina Lindorfer 38:43

OK.

K.

Yeah. OK.

OK.

Yeah. Super. Thank you that that was it. Anything else that you want to any message that you have not said so far?

110 KC

111 **Key Experiences and Lessons Learned:**

112 **1. Stakeholder Engagement is Fundamental**

113 • **Challenge:** The region's population is conservative, risk-averse, and hesitant to engage in new business ventures without guaranteed returns.

114 • **Approach:**

115 ○ **Initially relied on emails, which proved ineffective.**

116 ○ **Key Success:** Hiring a **local facilitator** (Hana) who engaged stakeholders **face-to-face**, which built trust and increased participation.

117 • **Lesson: Direct, personal engagement** is crucial in regions with conservative attitudes. Emails and online methods were not effective.

118 KC

119 **2. Tailored Communication Methods are Essential**

120 • **Finding:** Different stakeholder groups require **different engagement methods**:

121

	○ **Older generations:** Prefer **face-to-face meetings** and traditional outreach methods.
122	○ **Younger generations:** Respond better to **workshops, webinars**, and potentially innovative tools like **virtual reality**.
123	• **Lesson:** Understand stakeholder demographics and **adapt communication methods accordingly**.
124	KC
125	**3. Importance of Local Relevance and Trust Building**
126	• **Challenge:** A lack of trust in new initiatives and fear of business failure hindered participation.
127	• **Strategy:**
128	○ **Conducted a regional conference to introduce the concept of bioeconomy, including practical examples (e.g., products made from hemp).**
129	○ Focused on presenting **financial subsidy opportunities**, which attracted stakeholders.
130	• **Lesson: Financial incentives** and clear demonstrations of practical benefits are powerful motivators.
131	KC
132	**4. Data-Driven Decision Making for Value Chains**
133	• **Approach:**
134	○ **Conducted a comprehensive desk study analyzing regional strengths and gaps.**
135	○ Chose three value chains **aligned with local expertise** (e.g., agriculture and biomass) through stakeholder discussions.

136

- **Lesson:** Decisions should be **data-driven** and **grounded in regional strengths**, making them logical and acceptable to stakeholders.

137 KC

138 **5. Building Long-Term Relationships Over Quick Wins**

139

- **Challenge:** Sustaining stakeholder interest over time was difficult. Some stakeholders lost interest when realizing the required effort.

140

- **Success:** Established a **core group of committed stakeholders** willing to continue collaborating on future projects.

141

- **Lesson: Quality over quantity** in stakeholder engagement. Building a **small, dedicated core group** is more impactful than having a large, disengaged network.

142 KC

143 **Key Recommendations for Future Hubs:**

144

1. **Prioritize Face-to-Face Engagement:**

145

- **Particularly in conservative regions, personal contact is essential for building trust.**

146

1. **Understand Stakeholder Needs:**

147

- **Tailor communication channels and engagement activities to specific demographic preferences.**

148

1. **Involve Younger Generations Early:**

149

- **Focus on school collaborations and youth-oriented initiatives to foster long-term regional engagement.**

150

- Use **modern technologies** (e.g., VR) to make bioeconomy appealing to younger audiences.

151	1. **Leverage Existing Networks:**
152	○ **National hubs with established stakeholder and policymaker connections significantly ease regional hub establishment.**
153	1. **Demonstrate Immediate Value:**
154	○ **Financial topics and funding opportunities consistently attract stakeholder attention—use these as entry points for engagement.**
155	1. **Be Patient and Persistent:**
156	○ **Cultural and economic transformations take time, especially in post-industrial regions. Long-term strategies are essential.**
157	**Recommendations for European-Level Policymakers:**
158	• **Push for stronger prioritization of bioeconomy** at the national level by emphasizing its strategic importance in EU policies.
159	• Develop **incentive structures** that encourage national governments to treat the bioeconomy as a **key development sector**.

Transcript_H4 Hub

1 **Transcript**

2 13 February 2025, 02:01pm

3 So just to start off, maybe you can just tell me shortly like what is the mission of your hub and what is your role as well?

4 K

H4 - 1 0:56

Yeah, sure. So Hub is the H4 hub. It's actually the full country, but we are based in (xxxx – anonomized), so that's where H4 Bio Economy Foundation is based, quite a rural area of in the middle of H4. So there is quite a lot of agriculture in the area, particularly around Dairy and animal farming.

So our own role within the project was to kind of use the project to help the region, implement and understand bio based solutions and how they can be used to kind of better manage agriculture and agricultural emissions, and also make more economic opportunities for farmers in the area and in H4 in general as well.

Our role in the project. So, I've been working on the project since it started, as the project manager. So, our role is kind of within the home was to kind of organise all of the activities that needed to be done, organise the kick off meeting, engagement with stakeholders, organising city visits, network events, trainings, coaching these kind of things.

5 SG

Samire Gurgurovci 2:40

We gonna go maybe a little bit further into the study visits cause so far we know that you have been quite successful in that and it proved to be one of the best engagement strategy but maybe first you can tell me a little bit how did you initially identify the scope and the objective of the project and what if any challenges did you experience during this phase?

6 K

H4 - 1 3:02

Yeah. So I suppose just the start of it was to actually read the Grant Agreement once that

was released, before the kickoff meeting of the project. I was the project manager, but I was working closely with my other team members within H4 to plan out what was it that we're going to be doing for the rest of the project. So, kind of plan out the trainings, the study visits, all of the plans that we were going to be doing throughout the project.
And yeah, I think we'll start talk a bit more about the kind of stakeholders to get involved in the project later. But yeah, that was the main thing to kind of read up about what it was we had to do.
Most of the work that we were doing on H4, the time was more so around,

7 startup finance and this kind of thing. Another aspect of it was to form a closer relationship with (xxx – anonomized) County Council. We work with them quite a bit and we needed a kind of contact person within the organisation to work with, so this turned out to be a lady called Elaine Coleman, who was at the time economic development officer. And since she's been in this role since the start of the project as hub contact point for ourselves at the H4 Hub. She's now gone on to another role with (xxxx anonomized) County Council as a circuit bio economy reach officer.
So she kind of got more of an understanding of biocompat.

8 SG
Samire Gurgurovci 4:46
Were there any resources or information that you thought would have been helpful to have from the beginning?

9 K
H4 - 1 5:13
Yeah. What would have been helpful actually was something similar to what we were trying to build with rural spots. So that kind of online platform with the different resources available, I think a lot of the time European projects, they kind of they work on a similar initiative, but then the funding might run out and then the platform kind of is no longer alive. So something that I've been kind of thinking about within the H4 bioeconomy hub is having some kind of platform where all of the information from previous European projects and other ongoing initiatives could be there and I think something like that will be very helpful where it's kind of a one stop shop for a bio economy in the region. So for example like something within the H4 bio economy where you can get information on who's working on what, who is working on what projects, because there is actually similar enough projects ongoing at the moment around rural development and bioeconomy. It

would have been helpful to have lists of what partners were involved, and then you could kind of see which ways you can kind of collaborate as well.

10 SG

Samire Gurgurovci 6:24

Anything you would have done differently during this preparatory phase?

11 K

H4 - 1 6:32

Yeah.

That's a good question.

Yeah what I was just mentioning there kind of seeing who else is working on what, because I know there are other H4 partners that are working on similar initiatives and we did end up in the end doing a joint study visiting, networking event, there might have been other things that we could have been working, if I had a better overview of what they were working on so we could collaborate with them further. That's probably yeah.

12 SG

Samire Gurgurovci 7:34

Yes. So now maybe you can tell me how did you identify and prioritise the stakeholders and what engagement methods were more effective or didn't work out as well?

13 K

H4 - 1 7:40

Thanks.

Sure. Yeah, for identifying the stakeholders, I actually I did a good bit of stakeholder analysis before, not before the project, but just as it started, so that I know who to invite when the time came so. I made quite a collage excel with all the details of the different people I was considering to invite or then circulate that with my team members who would kind of add or subtract depending on what they thought themselves, we thought it was important to get people from different levels of government from the H4 Government through southern kind of the regional assemblies, and then the county councils as well, so that we got different levels of government. We also got people from industries that will be relevant for our own hubs such as dairy and forestry and then cooperatives as well. And then people who are working within bioeconomy, research and biotechnology.

And this kind of thing. So I think quite an extensive stakeholder analysis and we actually still use a similar enough one today that we kind of have been building on since then.
So that was for identifying the stakeholders. So what was your second question? It was engagement.

14 SG

Samire Gurgurovci 9:11

What engagement methods worked out well and what didn't work out well?

15 K

H4 - 1 9:16

Yeah, yeah, I suppose we didn't really have any particular stakeholder engagement methods. So to start off, when I invited them to be part of the project, I emailed them with information on the project and then I asked them to join an online meeting, so then I would have an online meeting with them kind of discuss the project, do a presentation, discuss the project. Then I followed up with them a few weeks later to actually invite them to the kick off meeting and a few other emails just to give them further information on the events so that they could prayer accordingly. And then we started off with a study visit to our own facility, xxx Biocoming foundations facility, xxxx (anonomized). And then we went to a hotel conference room and then I gave presentations on H4 hub RuralBioUp. And what we were going to be discussing throughout today. And then the afternoon session was more of a workshop. The plan was originally to have them fill out stickers on posters kind of thing both, you know, we were kind of at a round table and people just prefer to sit down and have more of a discussion. So what I did was I kind of became the note taker and then we would take a break between each discussion and people were able to put the notes on the poster if they were felt it was relevant. But mostly I was the one just taking notes and engaging with the discussion.

16 And then yeah, that was that was that was it really. As for us kind of stakeholder engagement methods and then?
Just always be following up with stakeholders through emails invitations to the different things we were organising, but yet I would say no real kind of other methods I would say.

17 SG

Samire Gurgurovci 11:11

Kind of adapting to the stakeholder group as well, like finding the right strategies for the right people to involve them, right? Yeah.

18 K

H4 - 1 11:18

Exactly. Yeah. Yeah, yeah.

19 SG

Samire Gurgurovci 11:21

And.

What did? Did you give any incentive to stakeholders or what motivated them actually to be part of the project?

20 K

H4 - 1 11:32

I'm not too sure exactly. I would say that it was a few different aspects. One of the things that we did do was like I mentioned, we did a kind of a trip to our facility at the national Bio Economy campus. And this was actually one of the first times that people were able to visit the facility. So this was a pilot scale facility that we have been trying to get up and running for fermentation and it's kind of the first time people were invited to visit. So I would say that was one of the interest that got people as well and then kind of the discussion of the project itself. I was saying to them that they can take part in whatever they thought was most relevant to themselves. So that kind of formed wasting their time with stuff that they didn't want to do. So whether that would be study visits, network events or whatever was that we were organising.

I think it's also good opportunity to collaborate with the stakeholders, so some of them are actually working on similar initiatives or kind of got ideas to work on similar initiatives and it allows us to get more people working on the same topic rather than working on it separately. So that was another thing as well.

21 They were the main aspects I would say I tried I always try and keep if we're having a stakeholder engagement kind of meeting or workshop or trying to keep it as interesting as possible and as informative as possible so that it kind of keeps people engaged rather than sometimes you can go to these workshops and it's more so you know, it's project heavy and it's not actually getting too much information from the stakeholders which is the most important aspect and it can be overlooked.

22 SG

Samire Gurgurovci 13:26

Did you also not just coming to our mind because you said also you had the regular

informative emails or you were informing them regularly, did you have stakeholders that were more active in the sense of more interested and wanting to be part of the practical part? And then other stakeholders that were less involved? How did that work out?

23 K

H4 - 1 13:26

We kind of had some that had turned up on the day for the kickoff meeting and then didn't follow up too much since then. But then there were others, of course, who were a bit more interested. They'd probably be the ones that I'd be working with more closely anyway on other things. So yeah, it kind of depended on the person and sure, like I said, we kind of kept it so that people can be as engaged or not engaged as they saw fit. So yeah, so that was the case. There were some people that were more interested and taking part and then others who kind of weren't.

24 SG

Samire Gurgurovci 14:34

Right. So maybe now we can talk more about the field visits and like?

25 K

H4 - 1 14:40

Sure.

26 SG

Samire Gurgurovci 14:41

How was the preparation

How did you go about it? And did you follow up with other side of visits afterwards?

27 K

H4 - 1 15:03

Yeah. It can take a good bit of preparation and logistics to organise these. I organised one before starting a ruralbioup, actually, where we had a few 15 The hubs countrys stakeholders from the spring cluster come to H4 and for a three day visit and we explore different bioeconomy opportunities in the southern region of world. So I kind of knew what was involved in organising one of these study visits before I start the project and then we started the project and I'll be I found the task lead of study visits. So we organised them a kind of pilot study visit and this was in collaboration with SPRING where we visited northern Italy, The hubs countrys sites. So it was kind of between myself and

the manager director there, Mario colleague Leonardo. And so between the two of us we picked whatever was free dates that we would go. And I think there was sometime in March 23.
Yeah. From there, your kind of both doing the logistics as well as well, I suppose organising the people is or the logistics as well, but you're inviting the people while you're still kind of preparing the agenda.
And preparing the flights and accommodation and this. So yeah, you kind of have to do it concurrently. I invited people from the hub firstly and then I invited other stakeholders that I thought might be interested in whether people heard through word of mouth and we didn't really promote it on LinkedIn. We kind of kept it to just emailing people invites specifically. And yeah, people were quite impressed with how that went. So that was the kind of main foreign study visit we did. And then we also organised several times to temporary site in the national Bio Economy campus. So like I say, we're trying to set up a fermentation facility there and to do that work, it's one of the main aspects is to organise people on site to kind of give them information on what is actually happening because they might read articles we recently got awarded €5 million funding from the H4 Government. And so, we were trying to kind of provide information about the facility on the ground so that people could get a better understanding of what it was previously.

28 What it is currently and what we hope to do within the future. So I think in total we've probably organised three study visits there alone. One of them was in collaboration with the mainstream Bio project, where we worked with MTU, mostly technological university. So we did a joint event, Joint City visit and it seems to go well because people do get a better understanding of what it is that we're trying to do there. That might not be able to be done through an article or an online meeting. So I think that's impactful, yeah.

29 SG
Samire Gurgurovci 18:19
Right.
And why did you decide to not make it public like?
Why did you decide? Maybe you had a thought behind it that you didn't decide to open up in LinkedIn or any other social media, but kept it in this circle of the stakeholders that are already established.

30 K
H4 - 1 18:42

Yeah, I think you get people that are the most interested involved.
I think people prefer going to an event if they have been directly invited or just kind of publishing it on to LinkedIn or something like that. If you maybe send an e-mail, personalise it, tell them why they might be interested in attending. Then you can also tailor to visit a bit more to whatever group it was that you were inviting, whether that be for example primary producer of might have less scientific knowledge or might be more interested in what kind of feedbacks were being used within it, whereas researchers biotechnology researchers might be more interested in the more fermentation capacity of the plant, this kind of thing. So I mean targeted invites you can actually, you can you target the audience. You know, if you publish it widely on on LinkedIn, you kind of you're not too sure who it is. That's terminal pretty.

31 SG

Samire Gurgurovci 19:37

Right.
Yeah. would you say that the study visits is this one activity that brings up all the stakeholders together that everybody's interested in actually such as researchers, farmers et cetera ?

32 K

H4 - 1 20:18

Yeah, yeah, I would say that, you know,
With the webinars, there's actually quite a lot of them at the moment with the different projects, a lot of European projects they offer webinars, there's probably a few that offer studio visits as well. But yeah, I think, yeah, like you say, everybody can kind of turn up to somewhere on the day once they've been invited and it also leads to kind of more discussion. You know, you're not just joining something for 45 minutes or 60 minutes. And you're finished. You're kind of there for half a day or a full day and you have lunch and you kind of discuss what it is that you could be working on or other opportunities that you could be collaborating with the people on. So it kind of leads to more discussion than can be done online, in my opinion.

33 SG

Samire Gurgurovci 21:04

Right.

Right. But and did you, did you experience any kind of difficulties or challenges at this phase?

34 K
H4 - 1 21:21
And.

35 SG
Samire Gurgurovci 21:22
Something that we can conclude as lesson learned not to do it again.

36 K
H4 - 1 21:28
I'm trying to think now.
There was, yeah. I'm not sure if it's as relevant. No, no, probably not.

37 SG
Samire Gurgurovci 21:38
It's OK, share it. Maybe it will.

38 K
H4 - 1 21:41
Yeah. Yeah. Well, we had. We had an environmental group join us before for only study visits where we kind of took them through a tour of the facilities and yeah, they were. More like, honestly, what we're trying to do is make this more sustainable and that true you know creation higher value bio based products that reduce you know carbon intensive industries, Bush these people are more on the ecology side of things. And they were kind of asking us to, you know, have more biodiversity on the site. And this kind of thing, which I don't know, it's not really part of our plan perse. So, yeah, that could have been, probably the most difficult one, most difficult aspects of the thing that we had because it wasn't really an area that we know much about within our small organisation. So yeah, maybe that's something that we can look into further.

39 But yeah, that's probably not as relevant to the project really and I'm not sure of a lesson learned there, but.

40 SG
Samire Gurgurovci 22:53

No, I think it's a very important aspect actually like to kind of study the people you are involving and aligning the interests.

41 K
H4 - 1 23:18
Yeah.

42 SG
Samire Gurgurovci 23:18
Anything you would do differently at this point at this phase?

43 K
H4 - 1 23:22
No, no, I don't think so. No, I was shopping off work yet.

44 SG
Samire Gurgurovci 23:24
OK.
Right.
So, we talked now we touched upon a lot of the activities, is there other activities that you have done and you thought that it worked out very well or it didn't work out really well, apart from the side visits?

45 K
H4 - 1 23:58
Yeah, yeah. I mean the networking events are another thing that that are quite good. And what we did was in one example, we kind of used both we kind of planned for all day of activities ourselves and MTU most technology university to plan full day of activities with study visits and network events.
So that the networking events were between the study visits so that we can go into schools, potential collaborations and that other successful networking events that we've had is that we've the last year we organised. All Island bioeconomy summer. We helped to organise it and with the help of a rural, as well the All Island bioeconomy, so much so, this is the largest bio economy networking event in H4. So it brings together kind of 100 stakeholders in the area and it was one of the main events in the work calendar there last year. So I would say that was another ruralbioup success.

Sorry, what was? What was the other part of the question? What? What didn't work out well?

46 SG
Samire Gurgurovci 25:10
What? What didn't work out well?

47 K
H4 - 1 25:16
I would say maybe the trainings because yeah, we're still trying to organise trainings, online webinars and I think people that were targeting to organise these are either very busy, have already kind of produced webinars and don't want to redo them.
Yeah, it's kind of difficult to organise, organise the webinars.

48 SG
Samire Gurgurovci 25:46
You mean only to organise or also to get people engaged in it?

49 K
H4 - 1 25:53
Yeah. So the way that we were doing it was that we would actually do the webinar and record it and then publish it on YouTube we didn’t have it live because we thought the logistics of having it live is just too difficult.

50 And because also there will be thought there wouldn't be as many people joining, whereas if we just recorded and uploaded onto YouTube then we could continuously use that and just promoted on LinkedIn. But yeah, we see if we're having trouble actually getting speakersn and organise and if we do then they cancel. So I would say that's probably a more difficult aspect of the of the project is to try and get these webinars, yeah.

51 SG
Samire Gurgurovci 26:38
Maybe. Maybe another question on stakeholder engagement that did you, did you have any feedback mechanisms from stakeholders that you received and what kind of feedback, if there is any?

52 K
H4 - 1 27:10

Yeah, I didn't really answer that perse. So the kind of approach I would take it was more so emails to the group, all of them, whether that be invites to study visits, network events, these kind of things, or just updates on the project updates on the activities of H4 in general and then.
When we did send their kind of action plan to them, then I gave them the opportunity to kind of provide feedback on it and some of them did. Some of them did provide information that we didn't discuss the kickoff meeting because they forgot or they wanted to get further information before saying it. And yeah, they kind of sent me that through an e-mail. And then I updated the action plan, but that was the main kind of feedback I would get.
What we might have done actually better is have feedback surveys for some of the events that we did do, such as the kickoff meeting or city visits, our network events like have a feedback survey to see if people were interested both.
Yeah, we actually didn't end up doing that. So maybe that's one of the lessons learned as as you were mentioning.

53 Like we did have certain information on there and then some people were asking to maybe include something else that we did. But yeah, no, we didn't have to adjust anything. It was just kind of what we did within the action plan and then we kind of work towards that. But there was no major, major adjustments really throughout the the project, I wouldn't say.

54 SG
Samire Gurgurovci 29:15
Is there anything you would do differently in this phase?

55 K
H4 - 1 29:26
Yeah, probably just what I meant to know about the surveys, it probably would have been helpful to have a quick survey after each event.
But yeah, that's it really, I would say.

56 SG
Samire Gurgurovci 29:38
Right. OK. And.
have you considered or are you thinking about what are the strategies to ensure the long term sustainability of the hub? I mean you touched upon a little bit of on it.

57

H4 - 1 30:10

Yeah, yeah, I would say that the actual next event that we're planning is in April. And so as part of that, we're going to actually be having a joint meeting between ourselves, our boiler, then other projects that we're working on as well, including primed, which is a research project that we're involved in European research project where we're working on the same value chains as in RuralBioUp.

And it's more research focused and we're also collaboration with the (xxxx – anonomized) Club contact Point who is working on a project called Pathways to Resilience. So we're kind of trying to see what it was that we did within the rural bio project and how we could implement that within these other two projects that are working on similar value chains.

So that's kind of what that workshop is going to be about. And that's kind of our continuation plan is to see. What results from a project that we could actually implement into these two new projects that have similar objectives?

So yeah, that's what I would say as a continuation plan. And then also the fact that we work with (xxxx anonomized) County Council, who is to hold contact point to I think.

In the grant agreement, is the one who's meant to be continuing this on once the project is finished. And so yeah, that's still kind of the plan. And that's what we're hoping to do.

In this workshop is to kinda see how we could do that.

58

Samire Gurgurovci 31:44

Move forward the right, yeah.

OK, so thanks a lot about all these insights. if somebody comes and asks you what are your 5 tips on how to do establish a bioeconomy hub? What would you say?

59

H4 - 1 31:56

Yep, Yep.

Yeah.

First one is the stakeholder engagement I mentioned. It's important to get the right stakeholders at the right time as well.

Planning is obviously an important aspect and that kind of goes within the stakeholder engagement. I would say keep it interesting. You know these stakeholders, they might get invited to other things and if you keep the both the meetings interests and then the stuff

that you're actually offering as part of the project interesting, then they're going to be more willing to take part.
They'd be the main kinda aspects 'cause there is cuz there is a lot of coming from rural development projects and other ongoing initiatives that are working on kind of hub creation as well. So you there's a lot of work on it and I would say not to start from scratch not start from zero. So like I say we're kind of going to be working on in a workshop now in April, where we're going to be using the results of this project.
Let's see how we can leverage it into other projects so that we're not again just starting from scratch. So once I look at other stuff that was ongoing, I'd say even within the country. So H4, there's quite a lot of information that is out there about different hubs and they go by other names as well. But you know, you can kind of see what the results are from that, who was involved, in that project and read some deliverables. Yeah, I would say Don't reinvent the wheel.

60 SG
What are your thoughts on gaps that you see in strengthening the bioeconomy in Europe in general?

61 K
H4 - 1 34:29
Yeah, maybe I would have said maybe some more lack of collaboration.
But, you know, recently H4 Bioeconomy Foundation and SPRING who, you know, are also involved in the project, starting new collaboration with bioeconomy clusters in Europe. So several of the, I'm not sure how many maybe seven or eight of the main bioeconomic clusters when in Europe kind of signed a cluster agreement, there and during the week in Brussels.
So that we can kind of collaborate further to grow the bio economy within Europe.
So maybe I would have said lack of collaboration before, but maybe that hopefully won't be the case anymore with this kind of new agreement, I would say.

H5

1 **Transcript**

2 7 February 2025, 09:06am

3 ML

Martina Lindorfer 0:46

So the reason why we're doing this interview is really, is to gather the lessons learned for our deliverable and also the handbook where we try to share our experience of the project with upcoming projects or anyone who can get inspired by us and tries to or wants to establish a bioeconomy hub. They should profit from our experience and from our lessons learned. So we now will go through all the phases that we had in the project, the main tasks lets say, in order to see how each phase individually went for you, what was easy, what was challenging and what maybe you would do different next time. You can share a bit of your experience and you can talk very openly. It's not for the monitoring, it's not for the evaluation and all your answers will be anonymized.

4 Could you summarise what was would you say the main mission of your hub is? So what was the purpose of your hub? What kind of difference in the end should your hub make in your region?

5 DL

H5-1 2:36

I will start with mission. We are a research institution, for research mostly on trees but we decided to cooperate with organisation which gather together different agriculture sector. NGOs, as well, producers.

The overall goal, of course, is to promote local bioeconomy and to transfer our knowledge from different countries as well, knowledge from science to the practitioners. Our interest as foresters and as tree growers is make connection with agriculture sector and to push them to look at trees from different perspective and to to catch how trees could benefit from all this. The practical needs and goals as well as this, the European ones and all these so horizontal priorities.

6 ML

Martina Lindorfer 4:01

OK, so connect different perspective from different disciplines to gain economic profits for the region.

7 DL

H5-1 4:07

Yeah. And also normally foresters and agriculture sectors, they are concurrence for one of resources which is land. DL And we are going with also with this mission to make peace that we could keep both trees and agriculture production on our land and we should not compete and fight. They should cooperate and to argue that socially also how we are working and what we are doing is that we are not over exploiters for our land, but we are producing a lot of different kind of goods, yeah.

8 ML

Martina Lindorfer 4:51

And.

Yeah. Nice. So, enhance the cooperation, combine different perspectives. So maybe right away would you say that this last years of the project you could improve on these goals?

9 KM

H5-2H5-2 (Guest) 5:16

I think we can improve in these goals because as H5-1 mentioned, we work in forestry, but as the project says, the main goal would be bioeconomy. So then the bioeconomy is also together with agriculture and so now we have the contacts also in agriculture. So now I think we could do it better because we have both the agriculture and the forestry together.

10 ML

Martina Lindorfer 5:44

OK. So that was for you, like a main result of the project that you could establish kind of this partnership or at least start this this network? Do do you see that as the main result of the project.

11 KM

H5-2H5-2 (Guest) 5:58

Yeah, I think the networking is a good result because now we could do more, because now we know the people also from the agriculture sector, what we didn't know before so

well and also they didn't know us as well. Well they know of us but we didn’t have a personal connection.

12 DL

H5-1 6:18

Yeah. And I I think success is also because for example, during the outlast meeting some other NGOs came to us and said that they would like to have some training and even some events for their members. So that is the start to benefit from our previous activities. That's not as fast as we would like to have, but it will happen.

13 ML

Martina Lindorfer 6:36

Maybe once again, what was concretely your role in the project or your main responsibilities? Did you have concrete roles in the project?

14 Maybe you have a coordinator for communication or for management or for whatever networking or so?

15 DL

H5-1 7:07

I would like I could say that for communication and networking. We are working both, for publicity it is mainly me and other ones involved in projects they are active in Z7, so they help both of us to organise events and sometimes also to make some content of event. And Christophe is more involved in administrative part.

16 ML

Martina Lindorfer 8:02

OK. And did this work alright? Would it have needed like clearer roles, maybe different roles, additional roles to manage the hub?

Or it just worked well the way you did it? as I understand you did it more like, let's see who has time to do something and be very flexible with the responsibilities and everyone does a little bit of everything.

17 KM

H5-2H5-2 (Guest) 8:32

No, I think this project is maybe quite hard to divide some roles because I think there's a specific of the project, it's not that it's very divided some different tasks they are quite connected.

18 DL
H5-1 8:50
Yes, because when it's more related to economy and to economic terms and to calculations, then xxxx (anonomized) will do because he has a PhD in economics and when it's more about how to use resources and what kind of resources we could use in different ways, then it's me, because I have a background in biology and forestry.

19 And as we are joking in our events, so when we are both present, I say that of us are educated in forestry. I have a degree in biology. He has degree in economy and finally we are specialists in the bioeconomy.

20 ML
Martina Lindorfer 9:45
OK, I'm super. So then I would start already with like as I said, going through the different phases of the project, the first phase, we called preparatory phase. So you remember maybe where each hub had to find a concrete scope, concrete objectives for the hubs. Also, you had to identify the value chains you wanted to work with.
And you had to assess the state-of-the-art. A state of art of the bio economy in your region and also to see if there are gaps that you wanted to fill.
So all in all, how did you experience this phase and maybe also you can quickly again remind us of how you accomplished this. So how did you initially identify the scope and the concrete objectives of your project?
How could narrow it down to something more concrete?

21 DL
H5-1 10:50
Since this initial stage, starting to implement the project, initially we wanted to work narrow it down just in forestry but due to at that time, political processes and also what was happening in the social media and socially, we understood that we should work wider and therefore we changed our partners, which are not project partners, but partners in our hub.
A more wider auditorium for the H5n Agriculture council.
And also in agriculture council, as members are Forest Owner Association, they are also included. So, we look in a more wider perspective. I think that that was our success.

22 ML
Martina Lindorfer 11:56

And was it then hard? Because it's interesting you did it the other way around. You know, you didn't start like from a bigger scale and narrowed it down. You kind of opened it up. Because you then included more and more stakeholders, as I understood. And was it then difficult together with these new stakeholders to define concrete objectives because you know I understand that it is a task of negotiation, whether to focus on this objective or on the other one? What makes most sense for all of us? Was that a difficult process or was it quite clear?

23 KM

H5-2H5-2 (Guest) 12:35

I think it's quite difficult because we have different stakeholders because we wanted a pool of stakeholders. So there are different stakeholders, but it's also hard because they have different interests. For example, the association has different interests like some businessmen or like a stakeholder, so it's not always fitting together what they want, what are their interests for them. And also stakeholders, if they are from agriculture, it means that some are for example baking bread and others are growing some potatoes and some are from the forest, so it's also hard for them to find something common because they are from different industries. Although all are from agriculture or from forestry, but there are different industries and also different levels what in which they work in these industries.

24 ML

Martina Lindorfer 13:40

Yeah, I mentioned that that's a difficult process, but so how did you manage this process? Because you had to come up with clear priorities, clear topics, clear objectives. So how did you in the end reach a decision among these different interests?

25 DL

H5-1 13:47

Yeah. In our case solution was to speak with them more in general. To catch those topics, which are interesting for all of us. For example, in the first meetings we talked about funds and the fundings where we could cooperate and we introduced it with ourselves and we tried to look what's common for all of us and also regarding that, this hub is in cooperation with agriculture organisations, but the stakeholders have been involved with also through another one networks. We have very good cooperation with them, planning region, which is the largest one in H5 and nearby which we are and where we are both of us are living in this planning region and also we cooperated with cluster of clean

technology, some that we have project and there is activity, you could follow us. So, when we are cooperating with these NGOs it is easier to reach Target Auditorium because when we are writing there is a signature foresters or forest research institutes, they took it as like a spam. Oh, it's for foresters. That's not for us. That's for foresters, because they are doing this screening also by, by the sender, who is sender. But the ones that message comes from innovation with the planning region, or from Clinton cluster or another one. And then it's different if they accept, if these managers of organisation do accept that we are coming and doing something together oh then it's OK then it's for us. That's so that's how we solved it.

26 ML

Martina Lindorfer 16:15

OK, so summarising maybe this phase of the finding the priorities among all partners. Is there something you're proud of you, well that you would say worked well, or is there something you would say, that you would do differently next time if you repeat it again?

27 DL

H5-1 16:42

So about what we are proud is that now when we say bioeconomy, it's not mixed up with organic farming anymore. When we started the first thing, we did was explaining what is biological farming or organic farming and what is Bioeconomy and then that those bonds are not the same.

Yeah.

That's the first step. First mind step.

28 ML

Martina Lindorfer 17:19

OK. And something that you would do differently if you did it again this first phase?

Or maybe not. Maybe you would do it exactly the same because it's worked out well.

29 DL

H5-1 17:38

Maybe I will remember later on what, what, what we could do different.

30 ML

Martina Lindorfer 17:41

OK, OK.

31 DL

H5-1 17:45

It.

Maybe in the beginning, we didn't sort out such short terms about our project task and activities.

We, as we had the web page which we had later on, but it would be good to have it from the beginning. Have one paragraph of summary of project what we are going to do and then to send out to everybody to be prepared.

32 ML

Martina Lindorfer 18:23

Summary: Have better information about the projects that will be helpful. In the beginning of the project.

33 KM

H5-2H5-2 (Guest) 18:49

I think yes, maybe in the beginning it would be better that we maybe could do invest more in the screening of the stakeholders probably. But I think we have a good connection with the contact points, so it was good to see that we could use stakeholders that were already in the contact point.

34 ML

Martina Lindorfer 19:16

Yeah, that would actually already be my next question because that is now actually phase two is the stakeholder engagement phase.

That would be everything that you know we did in our first kickoff meeting when we introduced this stakeholder mapping methods? And ask you to map your stakeholders and create the stakeholder engagement plan. So really to see which stakeholders do we need on board, also to see how can we diversify our stakeholders, how can we get many different stakeholders on board. How can we reach them? How can we communicate with them?

So how? How did that work for you? You already started to

comment on that so. What was your main method actually? How did you identify and how did you prioritise your stakeholders at the beginning?

35 KM
H5-2H5-2 (Guest) 20:14
So how we started in the beginning we had the hub contact point. Who was the organisation who are different members from the agriculture and forestry. So it's basically like the bioeconomy corporation. And then we went to them and then we saw which stakeholders could be used in this project. In cooperation with the contact point, we got a stakeholder database.

36 ML
Martina Lindorfer 20:51
How did you decide who could be used for the project? That was like kind of you decided on your own evaluation?

37 KM
H5-2H5-2 (Guest) 21:03
Yes, basically, we just propose to all the Members who are in the Council, do they want to join? Do they want to join the project?
So who wanted just signed the forms and then we included them as a stakeholder and then send information to them about the project and the meetings.

38 ML
Martina Lindorfer 21:18
OK, that's how you reached out. You first, you identified them from the list and then you sent them invitation emails with information.

39 KM
H5-2H5-2 (Guest) 21:34
Yes.

40 DL
H5-1 21:35
Yeah.

41 ML
Martina Lindorfer 21:35
And did that work out? I mean, I can imagine if you sent like an e-mail inviting them that many would be kind of reluctant and not be too motivated because so how did you in the

end really motivate him to, you know, that they should join because they gained something out of it?

42 KM

H5-2H5-2 (Guest) 21:52

OK, in the beginning there was this first hub meeting. So in that first Hub meeting, there were most of the members of that organisation and then we just introduced the project and they who wanted to join the project when they already saw what the project is about, then they decided to join the project.

43 ML

Martina Lindorfer 22:19

OK. But was it an issue that through this method you didn't reach enough stakeholders or also because the task was also to gain different stakeholders with different backgrounds and also from different institutions and different stakeholder groups like policy, industry, NGO and education etc? Was that an issue for you to kind of not be able to cover the different groups?

44 DL

H5-1 22:45

This we solved through the connection with different NGOs, so that one association of agriculture sectors that we got agriculturist and land managers.
By cooperating with them planning region, we got source who is a local policy makers and implementators and who is working with local entrepreneurs in a wider scope by cooperating with clean technology cluster, we got those ones who are working in in technologies. So finally, we reach a different target audience by cooperating with different organisations, which gather them together as well as those persons who are on social organisations. Which are involved in NGOs on government organisations, they are these more active ones which really wanted to do something more.

45 Excluding just their business. So that's the way how to attract the active persons who wants the opportunities and who wants to take part in some activities.
So we did not this so much. That was not like spam tool but more targeted.

46 ML

Martina Lindorfer 24:14.

OK. So just to see if I understood it correctly, your tactic was rather to engage the ones

that are more active and rather focus on the more active and more interested ones. And in your case, those were the ones from the NGOs. Is that correct? OK.

47 DL
H5-1 24:34
Yeah.
Those ones who are members in NGOs and who is visiting this meetings of NGOs or who are active in this NGOs. So it means those are not the managers of NGOs. They are members of NGOs.

48 ML
Martina Lindorfer 24:52
Were there groups that were especially difficult to engage?

49 KM
H5-2H5-2 (Guest) 25:05
Yeah, I think we didn't have so many from academia and from the government.

50 ML
Martina Lindorfer 25:11
Yeah. OK.

51 DL
H5-1 25:13
I think that government, it could be also because there's not so many persons.
They are overloaded with their duties and they are not so interested to send us the information, but we are we are not going to promise anything. That is the thing and yeah.

52 KM
H5-2H5-2 (Guest) 25:48
Because the government stakeholders need to be in every project, then there is in ratio because there should be some from the government. So yeah they are overloaded.

53 ML
Martina Lindorfer 26:05
Yeah. So what they probably need is very good, concise information from time to time rather than like really dedicating there to personal time.
Summarising now this phase, like this stakeholder engagement phase again, is there

something you think that went especially well? You're proud of where you think about it is something that we really achieved. And on the other hand, is there something that you would do differently the next time?

54 DL

H5-1 26:34

I think that the cooperation with the planning region and we work together also with H5n State Forest Company.

On the we got very nice session with them together in the forest and I think that we broke some myths about the forestry and about forest management.

That was very nice during our project. ML And also this changing of attitude of agriculture sector position Bio, because when these producers, when they heard this BIO in H5, it means that if something is BIO it means that there are some restrictions and some limitations for them and therefore they're trying not to do something with Bio. Because those restrictions are not compensated with some additional funding or something, therefore they are not so happy about that. But when we are telling the vehicle means that are you and you are dealing with bio economies and things are feasible.

55 ML

Martina Lindorfer 27:40

OK, super and something you would do differently next time. Is there some?

56 DL

H5-1 28:13

It's hard to attract them for personal meetings. Where is this? When we are could show something in practise, not on screen, but we still are in process and that is what we are doing now. But I think that we could start earlier and not very slow.. We, we could next time start more intensive in the beginning, in connection with practice.

Not so much presentation, not so much indoors. To go somewhere to see something. But that's harder to attract.

57 ML

Martina Lindorfer 29:07

You mean?

Starting the involvement more through practical exercises and less with like presentations, you mean?

58 DL
H5-1 29:16
Yeah.

59 ML
Martina Lindorfer 29:19
H5-2 anything that you would like to add?

60 KM
H5-2H5-2 (Guest) 29:22
Yes, maybe in the beginning could be good to join some other projects faster and then just go to working together with them.

61 ML
Martina Lindorfer 29:35
How do you mean join other projects?

62 KM
H5-2H5-2 (Guest) 29:38
I mean, there are other for example horizon projects or intra projects and then I think in the beginning we could start to cooperate with them.

63 ML
Martina Lindorfer 29:47
OK, from the beginning on, OK.

64 DL
H5-1 29:50
Yeah. Yeah. And that, especially in organisation of events. For your understanding in H5 there are 1.8 million citizens. And you could calculate how much is proportions which is active in economy, and which is active in the bioeconomy. There are not so many. When a lot of project are inviting them to all project its too tiring, but if we are having join activities all of us are happy, plus we are learning from each other.

65 ML
Martina Lindorfer 30:26
Yeah. Makes sense. I understand what you mean. Thank you. OK, then let's move on to the next phase that we called like working with the stakeholders.. You know where you had to develop this action plan together with your stakeholders. So really develop this

joint actions, the milestones to plan resources, to build up this management structure for the app, to harmonise your Roadmaps with the regulatory frameworks and their regional policies, etc.
So how did you experience this phase? What was maybe challenging was difficult, what did you gain from this phase?
Maybe let's start with what strategies were successful to work with your stakeholders to decide on what activities you want to implement, how to prioritise activities and then results?

66 KM

H5-2H5-2 (Guest) 31:43

We are working quite a lot through the contact point, because the contact points knew the members and they also knew what they want to know more or in what activity they would be interested more.

67 DL

H5-1 32:02

Yeah, and this horizontally point. Feedback for evaluation of our activities.
So we understood that the best way how to do it, is during the meeting.
In the beginning, they said that, oh, yeah, there's a lot of information. So let's enjoy the meeting and we will fill it later on. And it's very hard to fix the data when is later on because it's later on somehow extends a lot and we already know that that is problem.
But as we were in new editorial for first time, we said yes, OK, let's do so, but we learned it very quickly that that doesn't work. It's just for first one, for next ones we were already more clever.
Yeah, and maybe it is also connected to the age structure because most of our stakeholders are in their middle age and they like to work with paper documents a lot, and therefore we work as well with surveys as with online ones and other solutions.

68 ML

Martina Lindorfer 33:46

You said in the second workshop, then you changed your strategy. You started at the first you thought you could decide everything at the meetings. Then you learned it doesn't kind of work out. And then you changed your strategy. What did you then do differently that and in what sense did it work better?

69 DL

H5-1 33:57

So yeah, because after each meeting or activity, we needed to have this evaluation forms and prevalence process and activities and other things. And for first one we accepted that they will do it later on or not. And for next ones we try to do it in when we met then we are doing almost everything and this processing of documents or ascending of additional information from our side that's for later on.

70 ML

Martina Lindorfer 34:22

OK. We're talking about the evaluation forms.

71 DL

H5-1 34:41

Yeah, I am talking about this feedback.

72 ML

Martina Lindorfer 34:46

Yeah, I get it. Did you learn something from this? What feedback or what was the feedback of your stakeholders about the whole process? Were they happy about the process, about the workshop, about how you decided your actions or in the end, they said, well, it didn't quite work out so well for me or next time could you please do it differently or was there something that you gained out from the feedbacks?

73 KM

H5-2H5-2 (Guest) 35:28

So the question was, what did you learn from the feedbacks?

74 ML

Martina Lindorfer 35:35

I imagine that after the workshops you organised that the participants or the stakeholders or the community communicated back to you and told you probably if they liked it, if they didn't like it or if they would join next time or what they found especially interesting or not so interesting or helpful or not so helpful. If there was something you know coming back from the stakeholders.

That made you draw lessons for.

75 KM

H5-2H5-2 (Guest) 36:03

There's one. One thing was that in the matchmaking event, we had some theoretical part and then we went to the forest and show in the forest. And then the feedback was that the stakeholders would like to see more practical things, like go in the forest and in the next match making event would will be in February. We will take that into account and we organise event and the first part would be inside and the other half would be then in the forest.

76 DL

H5-1 36:40

And to attract attendees, we used several networks, we are cooperating with vision planning regional.

Our next meeting will be as one of activities of pizza (?) Main Innovation Week. So yeah, so there we will be trying to attract new stakeholders for the existing ones.

77 And also, they like that we have such this part when they have time to speak with each other. For communications, to make friends and all these things.

78 ML

Martina Lindorfer 37:32

Yeah, yeah.

OK. Yeah. That's a good lessons learned. Yeah. It's like a motivating factors would be practical activities, activities in the forest and activities for matchmaking and getting to know other stakeholders. Yeah. Makes sense.

79 DL

H5-1 37:50

Yeah.

80 ML

Martina Lindorfer 37:53

And then when we come like then to the next phase, which is rather the implementation of the action and activities. So first of all, you had to kind of agree on your action plan and the next step is then of course implementing the actions that you're agreed on.

So overall of all the activities, all the actions that you did in the project which actions or activities did you like most or would you say were most successful?

81 KM
H5-2H5-2 (Guest) 38:22
Within showing the good practise examples there is in the forest state or within the forest.

82 DL
H5-1 38:30
Yeah. And also inviting for lectures. Who are the practises?
Some bioeconomy, but in some special way, some persons who are involved in agriculture as well. In the last meeting we invited the professor in bioeconomy as well, so we are cooperating with the bioeconomy ecosystem activists in H5 not only with another project but also those who are working in that field outside of our institution. And in such way we also let them know that we are active and there is project.
As well that there is somehow diversification of our activities for our stakeholders.

83 ML
Martina Lindorfer 39:43
Yeah. OK. Nice.
And during the implementation of the action, were there any unexpected challenges or problems or obstacles you had to deal with?

84 KM
H5-2H5-2 (Guest) 40:00
I didn't have nothing in mind in the first.

85 DL
H5-1 40:03
Weather condition. As they are real farmers the majority of our stakeholders.
They go together during winter time, so in summer and spring and autumn times they are busy with the farming and other stuff.
And when we organise events in winter, and if there is too slippery or too icy roads, somebody decides not to come. Yeah, yeah. That's why I say weather condition, and not other issues.

86 ML
Martina Lindorfer 40:56
OK. Could you imagine now thinking about like support structures. Is there anything that you would have needed or that would have helped you in the project, maybe from the whole project structure, from any kind of support that you could have gotten in addition

not only for your region but overall for the whole team, the whole project team?
Is there anything that you think would have helped you to better implement the project?
I don't know anything more meetings, more trainings, more exchange, more kind of also communication material, more whatever clearer structure, clearer management structures, additional roles.

87 KM
H5-2H5-2 (Guest) 41:46
Yeah, maybe in the beginning more information about what is a hub and maybe some other examples would have bene useful.

88 ML
Martina Lindorfer 42:04
So to really know what the hub should look like, how it should be structured, how it should be built, have good examples for that.
KM
H5-2H5-2 (Guest) 42:14
Yes, more of that. And also examples of already existing hubs and maybe that these existing hubs could share some experience or just see how they work or how it looks like, because I understand that could be different hubs or different ways how to manage the hubs and.

89 DL
H5-1 42:34
That took us some time to explain to our partners. Because they said we will cooperate with you, but what is happening? what is our obligations?

90 KM
H5-2H5-2 (Guest) 42:55
It is because many of them already are in one in some organisation or in some different cluster and then there is hub and then they want to know what's the difference between the hub or the cluster if they are already in five clusters, what would be the benefit their benefit to be in this hub?

91 ML
Martina Lindorfer 43:09
I understand. Yeah. And do you think that in the end, it made a difference for them or would you say in the end it doesn't really matter being a hub or not or is it in the end just

something to make to kind of upscale the cluster or did it get clearer in the end for the stakeholders or for you?

92 DL

H5-1 43:18

In simply words, it's the difference between hub. In hub it's like they are, as I understood working in certain H5, so they are point where from where information is coming and shouting and through which one it is accessible and they should not pay those because it's projects they should not pay for cluster and other ones they should pay something. And there is coming activities for free and also this extension and even funded some activities and that I think that was the thing also which led them to continue to cooperate with us and to stay focus on that one, because it is voluntary, but they should not pay. And also they got some benefit from that one.

93 ML

Martina Lindorfer 44:45

OK, getting some free information and some free benefits.

94 So we are almost at the end. So just do you have any ideas on the sustainability of your hub? Did you have the chance to think about any strategies about how to ensure the sustainability of your hub?

95 KM

H5-2H5-2 (Guest) 45:11

I think the Hub will stay because most of the members or most of the stakeholders are members of the contact point, so they are related to the contact point and so the contact point is the next who need to continue the hub, so I think it wouldn't be any problem. And I think that we have a good right and check the contact points. So we could also be involved in this hub actions through the contact point in the future.

DL

H5-1 45:45

Yeah. And just something that came to my mind, I don't know what it is, is it age, is it business specific or what? But our stakeholders are very ''lazy'' to take part in online events. Because where we're getting that information, we are sending out all of them that there is such and such nice webinars. But they are very passive to visit webinars.

96 ML
Martina Lindorfer 46:27
OK. Yeah. Maybe they are just spending too much time in front of computers and are happy if they can meet people in person.

97 DL
H5-1 46:38
Yeah, that is like this whole horizontal challenge. And we would be happy if they if they use the information more if they connected, more to the webinars and to listen it's something and to take a look from different approach. But what they don't do that.

98 And for this sustainability issues. Maybe one of the ways and also one of the activity as organisation could be is that we could become a Member of this hub NGO.
And then we could continue activities from inside, because we also do some agriculture activities or long term tree plantings are agriculture crops. So we are also living agriculturists in spite of status of forest Research Organisation. Maybe that one could be also a way how to keep more alive or more active our connection.

99 Because from our hub the information are extracted but we are not involved in an active process, but as members we could also be involved in a more active process.

100 ML
Martina Lindorfer 48:36
OK, So my last two questions that are now more general questions. So imagine now because you know we're collecting these lessons learned now for other regions who might also build bioeconomy hubs. So imagine there's another region wherever in Europe, who wants to build a bio economy hub, what are for you like the top lessons learned from your experience where you say, OK?
You should know this or that.
Before you start building your hub, is there something that comes to your mind? So something you think about that would help me a lot, if I had known that from the beginning on?

101 KM
H5-2H5-2 (Guest) 49:18
Yeah, maybe about the hub information, how the hub will look like. We didn't know

exactly what we it would look like when we started doing it. It would be much easier for them if they have the clear picture, what it will, how it will and what will be in the end.

102 DL
H5-1 49:39

103 We would like to encourage others too cooperate with NGOs and associations, because there are more active people and a these CEOs or directors or heads of Engineers, they know their members and they know to whom to what to spread to avoid a spamming of projects. We learnt this from previous projects, but in this one we started to use this approach from the beginning.

104 ML
Martina Lindorfer 50:43
OK. And very last question now looking more also on the EU level. Do you see some major gaps on the EU level that need to be kind of filled in order to really move bioeconomy forward? Is there anything that if you could talk to, I don't know a EU official, what does bioeconomy need in Europe to kind of get to the next level?

105 KM
H5-2H5-2 (Guest) 51:15
I don't know if this is a good advice, but I think that what they saw also in the last matchmaking event that maybe not all who are involved actually understands what is bioeconomy.

106 'Cause, I think there could be different stakeholders or different people think that the bioeconomy is something different. It's not the same understanding. Not everybody understands the same concept of bioeconomy. I don't know how itcould be fixed, but I think that's probably some gap there.

107 DL
H5-1 51:55
And also.
I don't know how, but also to change the attitude or classification or stereotype is that by beconomies, it's about simple things.
Maybe that it is in H5, but that's also what I know from colleagues from other countries. So when it's applications when it's artificial intelligence as a result let's worry that's very smart. That's yeah. But the bioeconomy is bio-based, it's natural grown. That's very simple,

and that's not so high level, let's say. Yeah, but the real bioeconomy that includes also some IT solutions who is working with biometrics that include some IE who is working with recognising biomaterials in the processes. So that is to highlight that the economy is the more just to harvest, grind and timber, but that it includes also this processing and other things that is wider.

108 ML

Martina Lindorfer 53:45

Yeah, good points. Mm hmm. I see what you mean.

Great. Thank you. So I already took one hour of your time. Thank you very much. As I said, we will use the information in an anonymous way for the handbook and for the lessons learned report and then hopefully next upcoming projects will profit from everything that you have experienced.

RuralBioUp lessons learned H6

1 **Transcript**

2 14 February 2025, 10:03am

3 ML
ML
Martina Lindorfer 0:35
Yes, excellent. So let's start with to go back like to sum up again, maybe you could say in a few sentences what was like the main mission of your hub, what was its main purpose?

4 MS
H6-1 0:54
Yes, OK. The main objective of the H6 hub was to promote the development of a sustainable bioeconomy. In particular, through collaboration among the different stakeholder, the local stakeholder.
That includes different realities. So for example, businesses as means, but also resource Centre, university, policy maker and Sector association.
In particular, our idea was to support the valorisation Of biomass and bio based innovation through collaboration, but also through knowledge sharing and opportunities for networking, but also for funding opportunities.
So share information about funding opportunities and give the possibility to the stakeholder to create a new partnership and collaboration.

5 ML
Martina Lindorfer 2:07
So maybe like the summing up, what would you say you you now are named several key objectives, which of those you would say you reached fairly well and maybe are there others that you were not able to reach so good?

6 MS
H6-1 2:07
So all.
Sorry I don't can't today the question.

7 ML
Martina Lindorfer 2:29

Well, now you just summarised the the objectives of the hub, several objectives. And now my question is, is now, you know as the project it is coming to an end, I'm just curious, do you think that you achieved all of these objectives quite well or are there some that you achieved very well you would say and others maybe not so much?

8 MS

H6-1 2:33

OK, OK.

OK.

No, no, I think that we achieved this objective.

Yes, we have some problem after the beginning with stakeholder and in particular with the policy maker. But I think that during the process of the hub activities we reached most of these objectives, yes.

9 ML

Martina Lindorfer 3:03

Mm hmm.

OK. And what was your concrete role and responsibility in the hub?

10 MS

H6-1 3:17

Yes, I am the reference point for the H6 hup in particular, as the project manager of the H4 Green Chemistry Association.

In particular, I coordinated all the activities of the H6 hup.

11 ML

Martina Lindorfer 3:31

OK. What kind of structure did you have? Did you have very concrete roles, let's say the core team, did you had a fixed core team and with very clear responsibilities or was it more like more flexible and and more dynamic that whenever something came up, you kind of took parts or so or we had a very clear roles and responsibilities?

12 MS

H6-1 3:55

No, I have clear responsibility. Yes, yes, yes.

13 ML

Martina Lindorfer 3:59

Yeah. OK. So then I would go through the different phases of the project, you know. Being you've seen it in the in, in in the interview guidelines. So let's start with what we call the preparatory phase. So that is, you know, that was the first phase when you really had to find the focus of your hub, the thematic kind of focus that you have to define your concrete scope, the concrete objectives of the hub to identify the value chains you wanted to work with and also assess the state-of-the-art of the bio economy.
So what was your kind of method to to, you know, to find this focus to identify the like this this main key objectives and how did you go about it and how did it work out?

14 MS
H6-1 4:44
Yes.
We start with a study. Studying the state-of-the-art and the state of bio economy in our region in particular, we will do a SWOT analysis. So we focus on the strengths, weaknesses and opportunities of the bio economy in our region. After that our second main point was to engage the key stakeholders of the region.

15 ML MS
And in particular, we try to engage all the different stakeholders. So as I said before, SMEs, businesses, but also resources, policymaker and association.
To understand their challenges, their needs and but also their expectation from by economy and. ML MS
Our idea was to create a network that can Help us To identify the main aspect Where we have to focus during the hUb activities.

16 ML
Martina Lindorfer 5:59
Mm hmm, where the animated major challenges in this first phase. Anything that was especially difficult, maybe I could start start, maybe you could think of something already.

17 MS
H6-1 6:11
Yes, yes, yes, yes. I totally think about the difficulty to get in contact with local authorities because they have a lot of responsibility. They have a busy schedule, so. ML

18 They often don't have time to actually actively engage with the project activities with the hub activities, so this was a very hard point.

19 ML
In particular, during the first part of the hUP creation and the hUP activities.

20 ML

21 MS
And I think the second challenge was.
Create activities and opportunities for all the different types of stakeholder because they are very different. They have different priorities and also different levels of awareness about by bioeconomy opportunities. So I think that these are the main challenges.

22 ML
Martina Lindorfer 7:14
Did you find any solution or how did you solve kind of this problem as you said that there were very different priorities. So how in the end could you motivate different stakeholders with different interests and different priorities to still find something that they would kind of they all of them would have an interest in?

23 MS
H6-1 7:35
We tried to understand what are the priorities that can bring together stakeholder. For example, I remember that during the first period of the hub we create some questionnaire about the bio economy and the expectation, their needs. and in this way we tried to compare the different Responses. and in this way we try to ML MS Focus on the most common aspect.

24 ML
Martina Lindorfer 8:14
OK, so in the end we could find topics that were interesting for all of them, OK? And was there would have there been anything that would have helped you in at the beginning? Was there something, I don't know, some kind of support information?

25 MS

26 MS
H6-1 8:37
Yes, because we work with..., we are involved and we coordinate in a lot of different European projects and initiatives about bio economy sector with the clusters. So in this

way we have assessed more structured data or existing initiatives and marketing opportunities. So this was a very important point. but also, We are experts in the public funding raising. We have also some information about, for example, the opportunities on the defending opportunities, so we can Share concrete information about that and finally... at the beginning of the of the of the process of the creation of the hub, we have a lot of collaboration with the other two xxx hubs, so the xxx region and the xxx region (anonomized).
And this was very, very, very important for us because we had the opportunities to ML MS have best practice examples from similar hubs to help us t ML MS o programme the activities and so on.

27 ML
Martina Lindorfer 10:02
Yeah, yeah. And is there anything that you would do differently if you had to do it again this first phase?

28 MS
H6-1 10:11
I think that we try to...Have a more contract/Concrete(???) contact with the policy maker, probably trying to involve them at the very beginning, at the very start phase of the project. So I think that could be easier to engage them during the process of the hub. Because we tried to involve the policy maker after some months from the start of the hub and this create...

29 ML MS

30 ML
Martina Lindorfer 10:53
Yeah. OK. So do I have them on board right from the beginning? The policy makers would have been, yeah.

31 MS
H6-1 11:00
Yes, yes, yes, yes.

32 ML
Martina Lindorfer 11:02
OK.

I mean then I would come to the second phase and I think you have kind of already touched upon that. So that would be the stakeholder engagement. As you remember we we tried 10 or we we provided some exercises to do the stakeholder mapping to see which stakeholders you needed in the team to get really diverse stakeholders also to create a communication strategy with the stakeholders.
So but as I understood you all, that's what you already did like in this very first phase, right?

33 MS
H6-1 11:32
Yes, yes, yes.

34 ML
Martina Lindorfer 11:34
And what kinds of incentives worked for you to engage stakeholders? You know, how did you motivate them? How? What did you offer them that that made them think, OK, they, they would join? Yeah.

35 MS
H6-1 11:47
Yes, we saw that the Two main important aspect for stakeholder...After... give concrete Opportunities for them Was providing visibility opportunities for stakeholder. We saw that when we gave them the possibility, for example, to be speakers at workshops or a webinar or ML MS be part of promotional videos where they can present themselves, their activities, their needs... ML MS This help us very much to increase their engagement and their involvement in the activities.

36 ML
Martina Lindorfer 12:31
OK. Yeah.
OK. Was it for them also important that it is an international project, so very more interested to be visible in the region or it was it an issue than as well that there would maybe also be visible like in in other countries or in a in a wider context?

37 MS
H6-1 12:52
I think that the second option yes, because we see that we collaborate a lot especially

after 2-3 months from the start of the hup, we saw that the collaboration with other, for example European project or European activities was very helpful to engage stakeholder because they have the opportunity to create new collaboration to know different realities. For example, to know about the best practise that were there. That gone OK in the other countries. So I think that yes, also a more big vision was great.

38

Martina Lindorfer 13:45

OK, so then I would go to the next phase that is then really the working with the stakeholders because the idea was really to to develop everything. It is Co creative method. So you know there was the time when you had to to come up with the with the action plan and trying to develop this action items and and agree on milestones agree on common objectives and actions and so on and also harmonise the road maps with the regulatory frameworks in the region.

One. So how about how was that process? How was it possible to, for for you to find actions together with the stakeholders for the action plan?

39

H6-1 14:26

We start to write the action plan as we shared a questionnaire - As I mentioned before- with stakeholder to understand their needs and expectation, but also their vision about the bioeconomy and these help us to identify key priorities and the focus area and also to select our true value chain To focus on during the hub activities.

After that we try to discuss and structure and create specific meeting with the stakeholder to try to implement these preliminary information and to have feedback about the action plan that we create and in this way we implement it and we change the information. That they think that are better in another way. So yes, this was the day. Our approach.

40

Martina Lindorfer 15:32

OK.

Let's do it. Yeah. OK. Yeah. It's just to make sure that I understood it correctly. So like you, the Happcore team, you defined kind of, you wrote the first version of the action plan based on these needs assessment and then you kind of showed it again to the

stakeholders and ask them if they needed some wanted to have some changes or is that the way? Yeah.

41 MS
H6-1 15:39
Yes.
Yes.
Yes, yes, yes, exactly.

42 ML
Martina Lindorfer 15:59
OK, so I imagine in that case I mean rather than very contradictory opinions as you presented like your your idea of the draught that then different interests came in and people were saying. But I think rather this is a is a more important priority or we should rather do this action instead of this action.
And did that happen or?

43 MS
H6-1 16:21
Yes. Because as I said before, the stakeholder are very different. So the priority are very different as well, but we try to Put together the main important point for stakeholder and to focus on that point.

44 ML
Martina Lindorfer 16:42
Well, for you were there any, like, major challenges or problems coming up in this process of kind of creating this action plan, anything that was different, difficult challenging?

45 MS
H6-1 16:55
Yes, I think that the point is the same that I said before because as policymaker also stakeholder as they have their activities, their priorities. So sometimes with challenges to obtain feedback from them and have a constant engagement of them in the in this process.

46 ML
Martina Lindorfer 17:18
Yeah, yeah.

How did how did you in the end succeed to kind of what do did you do? Try out to keep them engaged during the project? What was what were your methods to kind of keep them, keep them on board?

47 MS

H6-1 17:37

We tried to demonstrate them that they will have Benefits to be part of this process because they will decide about the activities of the hub and so that their involvement will be very important ML vAlso for them, not only for us.

48 ML

Martina Lindorfer 18:08

OK. Is there anything that you would do differently concerning this setting up of the action plan?

I think what you're fluent now.

49 MS

H6-1 18:17

About the action plan in particular, no. But what I have to mention what I I'd like to mention is that: It was very difficult to ask to have feedback about the impact assessment of the hub activities. We tried to send, for example, the questionnaire online, but we ML received no feedback. It was very difficult for us. So I think that a very good aspect could be to ask stakeholders during the event (in presence) To complete the questionnaire. So in this way they can't say no.

50 ML

Martina Lindorfer 19:11

OK, I understand, but did you get any other feedback from stakeholders during the process? Because often you often times you know, the feedback is kind of between persons and people come to you and say, well, I don't know this this action versus or this this, whatever meeting was especially interesting or coming to you and saying well, I had difficulties in doing this or that. So did you learn anything from this more personal? Feedback.

51 MS

H6-1 19:38

I think that the most important point:. I think that there are a lot of opportunities about

networking and knowledge sharing and so on. But a lot of times the stakeholders want conrete opportunities, for example funding opportunities .

52 ML
Martina Lindorfer 20:02
Yeah. Yeah. No. Yeah. OK. Yeah. OK.

53 MS

54 ML
Martina Lindorfer 20:09
Then the next phase would already be in the the implementation of the action. Then of course, once you have your action plan, then of course you have to implement the actions. So I don't know about all the actions that you implemented, but it also includes the training actions and the organisation of course of events and workshops and setting up the networks. So now looking back at the last years, what for? You seem to be or from your hub, what was maybe.
Especially Successful actions action activity that you implemented.

55 MS
H6-1 20:41
first of all, as mentioned before, the providing of visibility opportunities for stakeholders. So for example, we involve them as speakers in networking session in events and so on. But also be part we we ask them to be part to promotional videos to present the realities and th activities.

56 ML

57 MS
H6-1 21:07

After that I that that Very important were the training activities because.. in particular target training activities. Because ML these help stakeholder to build a knowledge and to be more informed about the biobioconomy aspect. That could be useful for their work and the KPIs.
After that, I think that also study visit were very useful because we organised a study visit

just one week's ago and we see that the physical activities Generate strong interest among stakeholder.

58 ML

59 ML
Martina Lindorfer 22:18
Did any unexpected challenges emerge during this time of implementing actions?

60 MS
H6-1 22:28
I will repeat the same thing that I already said: I think the stakeholder engagement because they are very busy and so on.

61 ML
Martina Lindorfer 22:35

Would it? Are there any? Would there be any support structures that would have helped you? Maybe anything that you could have kind of in the back services from the project that would have helped you maybe? Is there anything you can think of? Any support or service that would have helped you?

62 MS
H6-1 23:05
Yes, as cluster we have a lot of stakeholder networks, so these help us to, for example, engage different types of stakeholder, but also to create synergies and collaboration. And as I said before, also the collaboration with other project, this was the best. The best practise ever.

63 ML
Martina Lindorfer 23:29
Yeah. OK. But were there any gaps for you in the projects, you know, missing links, gaps where you say, well, this was really missing for me this was missing to be able to really be able to perform better?

64 MS
H6-1 23:49
I don't know. I I don't have any additional information about what I have. I have just.

65 ML
Martina Lindorfer 23:51

I'm not talking about the sustainability of your hub. I don't know if there are any ideas already of strategies to keep up the hub in in any form. Is there anything that you have already thought about?

66 MS
H6-1 24:10
And I think that probably long term partnership between the different stakeholder, so try to create this long term partnership.

67 ML
Martina Lindorfer 24:21
OK.

68 MS
H6-1 24:21
For example, create a the base for a new projects or a new collaboration in the in the future.

69 ML
Martina Lindorfer 24:30
OK. Thank you. And then I already come to my last questions which are like summing up again our discussion. So really summing up the whole project and everything we have now talked about what are for you like the top lessons learned. So for example, if somebody would come to you and saying, oh, I'm going to build up AI want to build up a bio economy hub, what I may be there one 2-3 pieces of advice that you would give the person.

70 MS
H6-1 24:57
Yes. First of all, the stakeholder engagement, so this was very important.
Is important to have a continuous dialogue with the stakeholder to align the priorities of the of the region and the stakeholder with ML MS our activities.
I think that the second point could be that visibility is very important, so provide visibility opportunities to stakeholder can help the hub to engage them also in a longer Term.

71 ML MS And As I said, before the collaboration, with other projects or initiatives is essential because they gave the possibility to share best practice but also to create new collaboration and the new opportunities.
And as I said before to implement structural mechanisms to help the hub to have information about the impact assessment of the activities from the stakeholder. Because the collecting feedback was very very hard.

72 ML

73 ML
Martina Lindorfer 26:33
OK. And then last question, I'm moving like going beyond your EUR region and going more to the European level kind of.
What do you see? What are the main gaps on the European level that need to be filled so that we can strengthen bio economy in Europe? Can you think of anything if you, yeah, that would you would tell, I don't know European stakeholders.

74 MS
H6-1 26:57
Yes, I think that it's it's important that the access to funding will be easier. because I saw that many companies Have great ideas and the potential to have a better contribution to the by economy, but the lack of financial resources to develop and scale up their project was a very hard point.
Because there a lot of time there is bureaucracy, complexity, the the processes were very time consuming, requests a lot of administrative effort and sometimes especially for the SM ES and then the startups and the small reality. It is very difficult to ML face these aspects.

75 ML

76

Key Lessons Learned from the H6

77

1. Early and Continuous Stakeholder Engagement is Crucial

78

- Engaging a broad range of stakeholders—including SMEs, research centers, policymakers, and sector associations—was fundamental to the success of the hub.

79

- A major challenge was getting policymakers actively involved due to their busy schedules. A key lesson was to engage policymakers from the very beginning, rather than later in the process, to ensure better participation and alignment.

80

- Different stakeholders have diverse priorities and levels of awareness regarding the bioeconomy. Using questionnaires to identify common interests and expectations helped in aligning the hub's activities with stakeholder needs.

81

2. Visibility Opportunities Enhance Stakeholder Commitment

82

- One of the most effective incentives for stakeholder engagement was offering visibility opportunities.

83

- Allowing stakeholders to participate as speakers in events, workshops, and webinars or featuring them in promotional videos increased their motivation and involvement.

84

- Collaboration at the European level was particularly attractive, as stakeholders valued the opportunity to learn from best practices in other countries.

85

3. A Structured but Flexible Approach to Action Planning Works Best

86

- The hub used a co-creation approach to develop the action plan, first gathering insights through stakeholder surveys and then refining the plan through feedback sessions.

87

- Differences in stakeholder priorities were inevitable, but focusing on common key areas helped ensure a balanced and inclusive action plan.

88

- Challenges in engagement persisted, especially in obtaining feedback (for the impact assessment and evaluation), as stakeholders were often too busy to respond to online questionnaires. A proposed solution was to collect feedback in person at events, rather than relying solely on online surveys.

89

4. Concrete Opportunities Matter More Than Just Networking

90

- While networking and knowledge sharing were valuable, stakeholders were primarily looking for tangible opportunities, particularly in the form of funding opportunities.

91

- The hub's expertise in public funding was a significant advantage, allowing them to provide stakeholders with relevant information and support for accessing financial resources.

92

5. Training and Study Visits Strengthened Engagement and Learning

93

- Targeted training activities were highly successful in building stakeholder knowledge on bioeconomy topics.

94

- Study visits generated strong interest, as they provided practical insights and direct exposure to best practices in the sector.

95

6. Collaboration with Other Projects and Hubs was Invaluable

96

- Working closely with other regional and European bioeconomy hubs helped in sharing best practices and avoiding redundant efforts. It was a great help to know about good practices of other hubs at the start.

97

- European collaboration also enhanced stakeholder interest and provided opportunities for cross-border partnerships.

98

7. Ensuring Long-term Sustainability Requires Strategic Planning

99

- To maintain momentum after the project's end, the hub emphasized the importance of establishing long-term partnerships between stakeholders.

100

- Encouraging follow-up projects and collaborations beyond the initial three-year period was identified as a key sustainability strategy.

101

8. Access to Funding is a Major Barrier at the European Level

102

- Many SMEs and startups have strong bioeconomy ideas but struggle with complex and time-consuming funding processes.

103

- Bureaucratic hurdles and administrative burdens limit the ability of small companies to scale up their innovations.

104

- There is a need for simplified and more accessible funding mechanisms at the European level to foster greater participation and innovation.

105

Advice for Future Bioeconomy Hub Managers

106

If you are planning to set up a bioeconomy hub, consider these key pieces of advice:

107

1. Engage policymakers from the start – Getting them involved early makes it easier to align strategies and secure long-term support. Engaging policy makers was one of the major challenges.

108

1. Offer visibility opportunities to stakeholders – This increases their motivation and involvement in hub activities.

109

1. Focus on delivering concrete benefits, not just networking – Stakeholders are more interested in funding and practical support than just knowledge exchange.

110

1. Use structured engagement techniques – Surveys, co-creation workshops, and in-person feedback collection can help maintain continuous stakeholder engagement.

111

1. Collaborate with other projects and hubs – This provides access to best practices and expands opportunities for stakeholders. It also makes it easier to start setting up the hub in the first place.

112

1. Plan for sustainability early – Establish long-term partnerships to keep the hub relevant beyond the project's official timeline.

113

1. Advocate for easier access to funding – Complexity in funding applications is a major barrier; pushing for streamlined processes at the European level can help foster more bioeconomy innovations.

114 ORIGINAL TRANSCRIPT

115

Transcript

116 14 February 2025, 10:03am

117 ⍰
Martina Lindorfer 0:06
OK, so I don't know. Did you get the chance to to read through the interview guideline?

118 ⍰
H6-1 0:12
Yes, yes, I see the guidelines and I tried to I I know I know some consideration for all questions, so I will probably read.

119 ⍰
Martina Lindorfer 0:22
OK.
OK. But it was not. Yeah, it was not an obligation just for you to know. So you know, more or less what we're going to talk about that what? Yeah.

120 ⍰
H6-1 0:25
Something and.
Yes, yes, yes. No, just in this way, I don't miss any information and.

121 ⍰
Martina Lindorfer 0:35
Yes, excellent. So let's start with to go back like to sum up again, maybe you could say in a few sentences what was like the main mission of your hub, what was its main purpose, would you say what, what, what was the reason for for its existence, let's say?

122 ⍰
H6-1 0:54
Yes, OK. The main objective of the H6 hub was to promote the development of a sustainable by economy.
In particular, through collaboration among the different stakeholder, the local stakeholder. That includes different realities. So for example, businesses as means, but also resource Centre, university, police, maker and.
Sector association.
In particular, our idea was to support the devaluation.
Of biomass and bio based innovation.
Through the collaboration, but also through knowledge sharing and freight opportunities for networking, but also for funding opportunities so.
Uh share information about about refunding opportunities and give the possibility to the stakeholder to create a new partnership and and collaboration.

123

Martina Lindorfer 2:07

So maybe like the summing up, what would you say you you now are named several key objectives, which of those you would say you reached fairly well and maybe are there others that you you were not able to reach so good?

124

H6-1 2:07

So all.

Sorry I don't can't today the question.

125

Martina Lindorfer 2:29

Well, now you just summarised the the objectives of the hub, several objectives. And now my question is, is now, you know as the project it is coming to an end, I'm just curious, do you think that you achieved all of this objectives quite well or are there some that you achieved very well you would say and others maybe not so much?

126

H6-1 2:33

OK, OK.

OK.

No, no, I think that we achieved this objective.

Yes, we have some problem after the beginning with stakeholder and in particular with the police maker. But I think that during the process of of the activities we we reach almost this objective, yes.

127

Martina Lindorfer 3:03

Mm hmm.

OK. And what was your concrete role in responsibility in in the hub?

128

H6-1 3:17

Yes, I am the reference point for the H6 up in particular, as the project manager of the H4 Green Chemistry Association.

In particular, I coordinated all the activities of the H6 up.

129

Martina Lindorfer 3:31

OK. What kind of structure did you have? Did you have very concrete roles, let's say the core

team, did you had a fixed core team and with very clear responsibilities or was it more like more flexible and and more dynamic that whenever something came up, you kind of took parts or so or we had a very clear roles and responsibilities?

130 ⍰
H6-1 3:55
No, I have clear responsibility. Yes, yes, yes.

131 ⍰
Martina Lindorfer 3:59
Yeah. OK. So then I would go through the different phases of the project, you know.
Being you've seen it in the in, in in the interview guidelines. So let's start with what we call the preparatory phase. So that is, you know, that was the first phase when you really had to find the focus of your hub, the thematic kind of focus that you have to define your concrete scope, the concrete objectives of the hub to identify the value chains you wanted to work with and also assess the state-of-the-art of the bio economy.
So what was your kind of method to to, you know, to find this focus to identify the like this this main key objectives and how did you go about it and how did it work out?

132 ⍰
H6-1 4:44
Yes.
We start with a study.
Studying the state-of-the-art and the start of thought, the by economy in our region in particular, we will do as what analysis. So we focus on straight weakness opportunities, entries of of the bio economy in our region. After that we our second main point was to engage the key stakeholders of the region.

133 ⍰
Martina Lindorfer 5:14
Mm hmm.

134 ⍰
H6-1 5:14
And in particular, we try to engage all the different stakeholders. So as I said before, as means businesses, but also resources, policymaker and association.
To understand their challenges, their needs and but also their expertise expectation from from by economy and.

135
Martina Lindorfer 5:35
Yeah, yeah.

136
H6-1 5:38
Our idea was to create a network that can.
Help us.
To identify the main the main aspect.
Where we have to focus the during the the UP activities.

137
Martina Lindorfer 5:59
Mm hmm, where the animated major challenges in this first phase. Anything that was especially difficult, maybe I could start start, maybe you could think of something already.

138
H6-1 6:11
Yes, yes, yes, yes. I totally think about the the difficulty to get in contact with local authorities because they have a lot of responsibility. They have a busy schedule, so.

139
Martina Lindorfer 6:11
OK.
Yeah.

140
H6-1 6:25
They often don't have time to actually actively engage with the project activities with the app activities, so this was a very hard point.

141
Martina Lindorfer 6:29
Yeah.

142
H6-1 6:39
In particular, during the first part of the UP creation and the UP activities.

143
Martina Lindorfer 6:44
Mm hmm.

144

H6-1 6:45

And I think that probably the second, I mean challenges was.

Respond. Ever.

Create activities and opportunities for all the different type of stakeholder because they are very different. They have different priorities and also different levels of awareness about by economy opportunities. So I think that these are the main challenges.

145

Martina Lindorfer 7:14

Mm hmm. Did you find any solution or how did you solve kind of this problem as you said that there were very different priorities. So how in the end could you motivate different stakeholders with different interests and different priorities to still find something that they would kind of they all of them would have an interest in?

146

H6-1 7:35

We try to understand what are the priorities that can bring together a stakeholder. For example, I remember that during the first period of the hub we create some questionnaire about the bio economy and the expectation their needs and in this way we can we try to compare the different.

The different.

Respond and in this way we try to.

147

Martina Lindorfer 8:05

Yeah, yeah.

148

H6-1 8:09

Focused on the most common aspect.

149

Martina Lindorfer 8:14

OK, so in the end we could find topics that were interesting for all of them, OK? And was there would have there been anything that would have helped you in at the beginning? Was there something, I don't know, some kind of support information?

150

H6-1 8:15

Through the sticker.
Yes, yes.

151
Martina Lindorfer 8:30
Whatever something that you say, wow. If we would have had that from the beginning, it would have been easier this first phase.

152
H6-1 8:37
Yes, because we work with, we are involved and we coordinate in a lot of different European project and initiative about repay economy sector with the the clusters. So in this way we have assessed two more structured data or existing initiative and marketing opportunities. So these this was a very important point but also.
We are expert in the public funding raising so.
We have also some information about, for example, the opportunities on the defending opportunities, so we can.
Share concrete information about about that and finally.
At at the beginning of the of the of the process of the creation of the app, we have a lot of collaboration with the other two The hubs countrys hubs, so the market, the the market region and the Pula region.
And this was very, very, very important for us because we have the opportunities to, we have the opportunities to.

153
Martina Lindorfer 9:44
Mm hmm.

154
H6-1 9:50
Have a best practise example from similar similar hubs to help us to.

155
Martina Lindorfer 9:52
Yeah.

156
H6-1 9:58
To programme the activities and and so on, yes.

157
Martina Lindorfer 10:02
Yeah, yeah. And is there anything that you would do differently if you had to do it again this first phase?

158
H6-1 10:11
I think that.
I think that we try to.
Have a more contract contact with the police maker, probably trying to involve them at the very begin at the very start phase of the of the project. So I think that could be easier to engage them.
During the the process of the hub.
Because we try to involve the police maker after some months from the start of the hub and.

159
Martina Lindorfer 10:48
10.

160
H6-1 10:52
These create yes.

161
Martina Lindorfer 10:53
Yeah. OK. So do I have them on board right from the beginning? The policy makers would have been, yeah.

162
H6-1 11:00
Yes, yes, yes, yes.

163
Martina Lindorfer 11:02
OK.
I mean then I would come to the second phase and I think you have kind of already touched upon that. So that would be the stakeholder engagement. As you remember we we tried 10 or we we provided some exercises to do the stakeholder mapping to see which stakeholders you needed in the team to get really diverse stakeholders also to create a communication strategy with the stakeholders.
So but as I understood you all, that's what you already did like in this very first phase, right?

164
H6-1 11:32
Yes, yes, yes.

165
Martina Lindorfer 11:34
And what kinds of incentives worked for you to engage stakeholders? You know, how did you motivate them? How? What did you offer them that that made them think, OK, they, they would join? Yeah.

166
H6-1 11:47
Yes, we saw that today. Two main important aspect for for stakeholder.
After.
Opportunities for them.
Was providing visibility opportunities for stakeholder we. We saw that when we gave them the possibility, for example, to be speakers at workshop or a webinar or heaven so.

167
Martina Lindorfer 12:06
Yeah. OK. OK.
OK. Yeah.

168
H6-1 12:17
For example, to be part of promotional videos where they can present themselves, their activities, their needs.

169
Martina Lindorfer 12:25
Mm hmm.

170
H6-1 12:27
This help help help us very much to increase their engagement and their involvement in the activities.

171
Martina Lindorfer 12:31
OK. Yeah.
OK. Was it for them also important that it is an international project, so very more interested

to be visible in the region or it was it an issue than as well that there would maybe also be visible like in in other countries or in a in a wider context?

172

H6-1 12:52

I think that the second option yes, because we see that we collaborate a lot especially. After after.

After.

2-3 months from the start of the up, we see that the collaboration with other, for example European project or European activities was very helpful to engage stakeholder because they have the opportunity to create new collaboration to know different realities.

For example, to know about the best practise that.

173

Martina Lindorfer 13:30

Mm hmm.

174

H6-1 13:31

That are that were.

That gone OK in the other countries. So I think that yes also a more big vision was was great.

175

Martina Lindorfer 13:45

OK, so then I would go to the next phase that is then really the working with the stakeholders because the idea was really to to develop everything. It is Co creative method. So you know there was the time when you had to to come up with the with the action plan and trying to develop this action items and and agree on milestones agree on common objectives and actions and so on and also harmonise the road maps with the regulatory frameworks in the region.

One. So how about how was that process? How was it possible to, for for you to find actions together with the stakeholders for the action plan?

176

H6-1 14:26

We start.

We start to to to write the action plan. We start to we share a questionnaire. As I mentioned before with stakeholder to understand that their needs and expectation, but also their vision about the economy and these help us to identify key priorities and the focus area and also to select our true value chain.

177
Martina Lindorfer 14:39
Yeah, yeah.

178
H6-1 14:56
To focus on during the UP activities.
After that we we try to discuss and structures and create specific meeting with the stakeholder to try to implement these preliminary information and to.
Have feedback about the the action plan that we create and in this way we implement it and we change the information.
That they think that are better in another.
Another way. So yes, this was the day. Our approach.

179
Martina Lindorfer 15:32
OK.
Let's do it. Yeah. OK. Yeah. It's just to make sure that I understood it correctly. So like you, the Happcore team, you defined kind of, you wrote the first version of the action plan based on these needs assessment and then you kind of showed it again to the stakeholders and ask them if they needed some wanted to have some changes or is that the way? Yeah.

180
H6-1 15:39
Yes.
Yes.
Yes, yes, yes, exactly.

181
Martina Lindorfer 15:59
OK, so I imagine in that case I mean rather than very contradictory opinions as you presented like your your idea of the draught that then different interests came in and people were saying. But I think rather this is a is a more important priority or we should rather do this action instead of this action.
And did that happen or?

182
H6-1 16:21
Yes. Because as I said before, the stakeholder are very different. So the priority are very different as well, but we try.

To.
Put together the main important point for stakeholder and to focus on that point.

183
Martina Lindorfer 16:42
Well, for you were there any, like, major challenges or problems coming up in this process of kind of creating this action plan, anything that was different, difficult challenging?

184
H6-1 16:55
Yes, I think that the the point is the same that I said before because as policymaker also stakeholder as they, their activities, their their priorities. So sometimes with challenges to obtain feedback from them and have a constant.
A constant engagement of them in the in this process.

185
Martina Lindorfer 17:18
Yeah, yeah.
How did how did you in the end succeed to kind of what do did you do? Try out to keep them engaged during the project? What was what were your methods to kind of keep them, keep them on board?

186
H6-1 17:37
We tried to.
We tried to demonstrate them that they are. They will, they will have.
Benefits to be part of this process because they will decide about the activities of the ABB and so that their their involvement will be very important.

187
Martina Lindorfer 17:59
You know.
There.

188
H6-1 18:05
Also for them, not only for us.

189
Martina Lindorfer 18:08
OK. Is there anything that you would do differently concerning this setting up of the action

plan?
I think what you're fluent now.

190
H6-1 18:17
About the action plan in particular, no. But what I have to mention what I I'd like to mention is that.
It was very difficult to ask to have feedback about the impact assessment of the AB activities. We tried to send, for example, the questionnaire online, but we.

191
Martina Lindorfer 18:40
Yeah.

192
H6-1 18:41
We have no feedback. It was, it was very difficult for us. So I think that.
A very good.
Aspect could be to.
To ask a stakeholder during the in present 7th was so when they are with us in presence.

193
Martina Lindorfer 19:03
Yeah.

194
H6-1 19:04
To complete the questionnaire. So in this way they can't.
You know.

195
Martina Lindorfer 19:11
OK, I understand, but did you get any other feedback from stakeholders during the process? Because often you often times you know, the feedback is kind of between persons and people come to you and say, well, I don't know this this action versus or this this, whatever meeting was especially interesting or coming to you and saying well, I had difficulties in doing this or that. So did you learn anything from this more personal?
Feedback.

196
H6-1 19:38

I think that the most important point.
Was that?
There aren't contract. I think that there are a lot of opportunities about networking and knowledge sharing and so on. But a lot of times they call their ones for contract opportunities, for example funding opportunities so.

197
Martina Lindorfer 20:02
Yeah. Yeah. No. Yeah. OK. Yeah. OK.

198
H6-1 20:04
Yes, I think that.

199
Martina Lindorfer 20:09
Then the next phase would already be in the the implementation of the action. Then of course, once you have your action plan, then of course you have to implement the actions. So I don't know about all the actions that you implemented, but it also includes the training actions and the organisation of course of events and workshops and setting up the networks. So now looking back at the last years, what for? You seem to be or from your hub, what was maybe.
Especially.
Successful actions action activity that you implemented.

200
H6-1 20:41
Uh, first of all, as mentioned before, the providing visibility opportunities for stakeholder. So for example, we involve them as speakers in networking section in events and so on. But also be part we we ask them to be part to promotional videos to present the the realities and the the.

201
Martina Lindorfer 20:47
Yeah, yeah.
Mm hmm.

202
H6-1 21:07
Activities after that, I think that very.

Very important to where the training activities because in particular target training activities because.

203
Martina Lindorfer 21:17
Mm hmm.

204
H6-1 21:24
These help stakeholder to build a knowledge and to be more informed about the bioconomy aspect.
That could be useful for the worker and the and the KPIs and.
After that, I think that also study visit were very useful because we organised a study visit just two weeks, one week's ago and we see that the physic physically seeing activities.
Generate strong interest among stakeholder.

205
Martina Lindorfer 22:03
Yeah.
Yeah. Thanks, Paul. What all of that? All of the help coordinator said in all of the interviews that this personal interactions were the best ones actually. And the practical ones.

206
H6-1 22:05
Yes.

207
Martina Lindorfer 22:18
Did any unexpected challenges emerged during this time of implementing actions?

208
H6-1 22:28
I think that as all I think that I I will repeat today the same thing that I already said. Yes, I think that this decoder engagement because they are very busy and so on, yes.

209
Martina Lindorfer 22:35
Yeah.
OK. So then.
Yeah. Yeah. OK.
Would it? Are there any? Would there be any support structures that would have helped you?

Maybe anything that you could have kind of in the back services from the project that would have helped you maybe? Is there anything you can think of? Any support or service that would have helped you?

210 ⍰

H6-1 23:05

Smaller as cluster, we have a lot of stakeholder networks, so these help us to, for example, engage different types of stakeholder, but also to create synergies and collaboration. And as I said before, also the collaboration with other project, this was the yes the best.
The best practise ever.

211 ⍰

Martina Lindorfer 23:29

Yeah. OK. But were there any gaps for you in the projects, you know, missing links, gaps where you say, well, this was really missing for me this was missing to be able to really be able to perform better?

212 ⍰

H6-1 23:49

I don't know. I I don't have any additional information about what I have. I have just.

213 ⍰

Martina Lindorfer 23:51

10 *******.
K that's fine.
I'm not talking about the sustainability of your hub. I don't know if there are any ideas already of strategies to keep up the hub in in any form. Is there anything that you have already thought about?

214 ⍰

H6-1 24:10

And I think that probably long term partnership between between the different stakeholder, so try to create these long term partnership.

215 ⍰

Martina Lindorfer 24:21

OK.

216 ⍰

H6-1 24:21

For example, create a debase for new projects or a new collaboration in the in the future.

217 Martina Lindorfer 24:30
OK. Thank you. And then I already come to my last questions which are like summing up again our discussion. So really summing up the whole project and everything we have now talked about what are for you like the top lessons learned. So for example, if somebody would come to you and saying, oh, I'm going to build up AI want to build up a bio economy hub, what I may be there one 2-3 pieces of advice that you would give the person.

218 H6-1 24:57
Yes. First of all, the stakeholder engagement, so this was very important.
Is important to have a a continuous dialogue with the stakeholder to align the priorities of the of the region and the stakeholder with.

219 Martina Lindorfer 25:15
Yeah.

220 H6-1 25:20
With our activities.
I think that the second point.
I could be that visibility is very important, so provide a visibility opportunities to stakeholder can help.
The the app to engage them also in a longer in a long.
Term aspect.

221 Martina Lindorfer 25:44
Yeah.

222 H6-1 25:46
And.
As I said, I said before the collaboration, the collaboration with our initiative other project is essential because they gave the possibility to share best practise but also to create new collaboration and the new news opportunities.
And as I said before.

223 Martina Lindorfer 26:29
Mm hmm.

224 H6-1 26:29
Evan said is this aspect is very important.

225 Martina Lindorfer 26:33
OK. And then last question, I'm moving like going beyond your EUR region and going more to

the European level kind of.
What do you see? What are the main gaps on the European level that need to be filled so that we can strengthen bio economy in Europe? Can you think of anything if you, yeah, that would you would tell, I don't know European stakeholders.

226 H6-1 26:57
Yes, I think that it's it's important that they assess to funding.

227 Martina Lindorfer 26:58
European policymaking.

228 H6-1 27:05
Will be easier easier. Sorry because I I see that I saw that many companies.
Have great ideas and the potential to have a better contribution to the by economy, but the lack of financial resources to develop and scale up their project was a very hard point.
Because there a lot of time there is bureaucracy, complexity, the the processes were very time consuming, requests a lot of administrative effort and sometimes especially for the SM ES and then the startups and the small reality. It is very difficult to.

229 Martina Lindorfer 27:50
Yeah.

230 H6-1 27:52
To face these these aspects.

231 Martina Lindorfer 27:55
Yeah.
OK. Thank you. So that would be all from my side. Anything else that I forgot that you for you as import that you want to mention still now covered everything?

232 H6-1 28:05
One Kingdom, OK.

233 Martina Lindorfer 28:06
OK, then. Thank you so much for your time. That helps a lot to to build the deliverables. Yeah, if you have any questions deal, we're happy to answer them.

234 H6-1 28:17
That's no problem. It was a pleasure. And if you have any other question, you can contact me and and I will provide you all the information.

235 Martina Lindorfer 28:25
Super, then thank you and have a good day. Have a good weekend. Bye bye.

236 H6-1 28:29
Bye bye bye.

237 Martina Lindorfer stopped transcription

H7

1	**Margit Hofer:** The recording is working, right?
2	**Samire Gurgurovci**: Yes, it is.
3	**Margit Hofer:** Very good. OK, thank you so much. Basically, we have certain areas that we wanted to talk about regarding this whole process of setting up the hubs. We are looking for what we call lessons learned. I think you have already dealt a little bit with that. However, what we are specifically looking for are these lessons learned during the process of setting up the hubs. My first question would be: Can you quickly explain what was the main mission of the hub, what was its purpose, and what was your role in that? Who would like to start - H7-2 or H7-1?
4	**H7-1:** H7-2, do you want to start, or maybe I can start if you want?
5	**H7-2:** It's OK, I can start. So about the main goal and our role, right?
6	[Brief greetings exchanged as H7-3 joins]
7	H7-2: So let's start. For H7 region, we had two different roles. The first one was being the bridge between the stakeholders and the regional contact point, which was the H7 region with a session of competitiveness in agrifood. It was basically being a bridge between these two different groups - from one side the policymakers, from the other side the ecosystem we were developing in the H7 region.
8	Our second role was also working as a supportive measure, providing consultancy for the regional departments to help understand their needs and transform them into actionable activities.
9	Regarding the aim, I think the main aim was to guide specific interventions at the regional level on topics where the stakeholders were interested. That's why at the beginning we tried to select three different value chains. As a lesson learned, I would say that having three value chains is quite a lot. Maybe it would have been better to narrow it down, but in the end, we are really focusing on one value chain where the region is really involved.
10	I think that was our main goal - supporting the region in their initiatives, supporting the needs of the stakeholders, working with a mentoring and coaching function for them, and trying to also raise awareness among students because we worked a lot on that.
11	**H7-2:** I don't know if H7-3 and H7-1 want to add something because we are collaborating together. Sometimes it's me more than them, sometimes it's H7-PROJECT_PARTNER_1 more than H7-Project_Partner_1_2. We are quite aligned, but sometimes we can miss some pieces.
12	H7-1: For our side, for H7-PROJECT_PARTNER_1, we are working together with H7-Project_Partner_1_2, and we are working as a facilitator for two regional hubs. Sometimes we work together, not with the same activities because these stakeholder groups are different, but the approach is similar.

13	From our point of view, I would like to make a consideration that may be important for your work package. In particular, from our experience, the lesson learned is that thanks to the different activities, we realized it's very important to be concrete. It's very important to bring innovation in a concrete way because if you consider that the stakeholder groups are not only from the research sector but also include farmers and entrepreneurs from the private sector, it can be difficult sometimes for them to collaborate in the regional hub because they don't have the time.
14	Therefore, when you want to explain what kind of innovation is possible to replicate in the territories and what kind of opportunities you can bring together in close collaboration with Public Officers, Regional Officers, and researchers, it is very important to use clear language, not academic language. It's very important to bring innovation through, for example, study visits.
15	This is one of the best ways to include and share information and to be practical. Because we included in our approach methodologies based on learning by doing, learning by seeing, and learning by touching, we worked strongly during the previous months thanks to the collaboration between H7-Project_Partner_1_2 and H7-PROJECT_PARTNER_1. For the coming months, we're focusing on creating these study visits in collaboration with regional officers and by involving local farmers. This has been successful.
16	**Margit Hofer:** When you started this project or when you started the hubs, I had the impression that you already had certain stakeholders or certain networks. What I would be very much interested in is what were the major challenges during this preparatory phase? So before you started all these activities, what was really difficult for you during the preparation?
17	**H7-1:** Yes, from my side - H7-2, please correct me if needed - I realized that at the beginning it was very hard to involve the private sector, especially farmers. When you explain to them what kind of actions we will do in the project, sometimes they have the view of "I don't have so much time, I don't want to lose time, maybe we'll see later." So in this first step, we had to put more effort into creating strategic regional working groups.
18	**H7-2:** Regarding the preparatory phase before defining the action plan, I think the good thing from H7 region was that there was already an ongoing discussion and collaboration between the regional facilitator and the hub contact point. That made things easier in the end. But on the negative side, people want to see a real impact or real change.
19	I won't say this project didn't bring change or impact because it did, for sure. But it's difficult to convince people at the beginning that we would be able to make an impact on their businesses or initiatives. Only the people who were able to think long-term were properly engaged. Otherwise, the other people were more skeptical.
20	I think this was the main downside point because most of the time, these coordination supportive actions are written in a way that pragmatic people want to know what value you're bringing to their lives when they already have a lot of things to do. That's the main thing that made stuff difficult at the beginning, but luckily, with people talking to each other and with the good connections and relationships we had in the H7 region territory, we made it through. We were able to prepare an action plan, but if I say now that the action plan was really something focused on what we had to do - maybe not, because we had to produce something when we didn't yet know how to develop it.

21	**Margit Hofer:** So do I understand correctly that while it's good to have this action plan at first, once in the process it would have been better to have it a bit more open so that you would be able to adapt it more?
22	H7-2: Yes, I think they requested too many details at the beginning. I understand there are KPIs and such, but for me it would have been enough to engage and define the value chain, and then through the process with stakeholders, we could see how to improve things. But we had to come up with plans already, which made it difficult to cross-check and align expectations.
23	It's not as simple as sending a text. You need to collect stakeholders together in an event, discuss things - it requires a lot of time.
24	Margit Hofer: Is there anything else you would do differently next time in terms of the preparation phase? Something you'd include or skip?
25	H7-2: I think we need more clarity on the guidance for action plan preparation. I had the feeling that the action plan was just "here's a template, go fill it out." Now that we understand how the hub functions and how the work can be done, we can better divide steps into smaller, more manageable tasks.
26	Without achieving certain tasks, you cannot proceed. There was probably some misalignment on tasks and work packages. We need better organization, like a Gantt chart, and more clarity on tasks - especially when creating technical guidelines for the hub. We had many activities: engaging stakeholders, writing the action plan, organizing events, doing the kick-off meeting, and creating questionnaires.
27	If you have many activities, you can only provide based on the time you have. I would say we did a great job, but the more focused we are, the better the outcome.
28	H7-1: When you organize the project with its deadlines for several deliverables and actions, you have to consider that each stakeholder has their own activities. Trying to organize the regional hub and engage different stakeholders while aligning their various interests is very hard. It requires strong management and consideration of the different interests of regional stakeholders and public officers.
29	Margit Hofer: That's an interesting point. My question is: Given that stakeholder engagement was challenging, what methods did you find most effective?
30	H7-2: We primarily started with our existing connections. H7-Project_Partner_1_2 works in the bioeconomy sector, and H7-PROJECT_PARTNER_1 works with related federations. We collected stakeholders from several sources:
31	• Our existing network
32	

	• Operational groups from the European Commission's AKIS (Agricultural Knowledge and Innovation System)
33	• Relevant projects from the AKIS operational groups
34	• Input from the regional contact point
35	We then expanded our stakeholder base through dissemination, events, and communication. Our initial pool was quite substantial - we engaged around 70 stakeholders, with about 30-40 consistently participating.
36	H7-1: We also leveraged links with regional stakeholders and key actors from previous national and European projects. This approach was very useful because it helped us identify which key regional actors would be sensitive to our activities.
37	H7-2: A key strategy is maintaining good working relationships. If people trust you and your work, they'll participate. The most challenging part is targeting people outside your existing network and keeping them engaged.
38	The best strategies include:
39	• Empowering stakeholders through activities
40	• Showcasing their businesses and initiatives
41	• Using questionnaires to involve stakeholders
42	However, we realized it's challenging to engage all stakeholders at the same level. You often end up with the same active participants.
43	H7-1: The approach depends on the type of stakeholder. Younger stakeholders might be more receptive to online meetings, while older farmers or traditional stakeholders require face-to-face, traditional approaches. Working with farmer associations is crucial because they represent local culture and can help disseminate information.

44	For example, in the South of H7-country, they found a "door-to-door" engagement approach effective. Instead of sending emails that might get lost in spam, they directly visited businesses to explain the project and invite participation.
45	Margit Hofer: That sounds like a very logical approach - building personal trust through direct contact.
46	Margit Hofer: What activities and actions did you test that worked well, and which ones didn't work out at all?
47	H7-1: For the market region hub, and considering all activities carried out so far - also for H7 region, since we collaborated on many events - we have a lot of information about workshop and study visit organization. I think in the Rural View hub, for the first time, I realized the good collaboration between different regions.
48	For example, we created a specific event where regional officers from H7 region and Marche had the opportunity to collaborate and share information about circular bioeconomy and action plans to be developed in their specific regions. This type of activity is quite special and not usual to see at the European regional level.
49	Another important opportunity we created through the Rural View project was during the international event in Romania last October - the European Regions Meet event. It was one of the first important occasions where different regional hubs talked together, not just at the national level, but at the European level. This could be highlighted as an unexpected result of the project.
50	H7-2: One of the main challenges was the working table about bioeconomy that we included in the action plan, which will not actually happen. This is something important to keep in mind: we need to focus on actionable activities instead of wishful thinking. With limited time, you have to be very specific about what you can realistically achieve.
51	Margit Hofer: So you're saying it's better to focus on activities that are clear and targeted to a specific group, rather than trying to involve too many stakeholders?
52	H7-2: It's not just about stakeholder groups, but about the activities themselves. We should focus on fewer activities but try to bring them to completion, like we did with some specific initiatives.
53	Regarding long-term sustainability, we're trying to work through maintaining the level of regional facilitator and contact point. We'll continue to support the ecosystem by helping write call proposals and supporting the selected value chain.
54	H7-1: For long-term sustainability, we need to consider funding for specific actions. When suggesting to public authorities that they should develop a bioeconomy platform, the problem is securing funding to manage these actions. We also need to determine which department is responsible and how to include different departments democratically.
55	Her top recommendations for regions establishing a bioeconomy hub include:

56	1. Creating an interdisciplinary group within the regional hub, including different departments
57	1. Using a bottom-up approach for organizing the bioeconomy platform
58	1. Collecting recommendations at higher levels
59	1. Developing a consistent approach across European regions
60	H7-2: Funding opportunities are crucial. We can't imagine doing this for free or solely for our company's purpose. The project was a means of starting something, but funding is important for sustainability.
61	**Margit Hofer:** Do you have any final thoughts you'd like to share?
62	**H7-2:** I think we've covered the main points - both the best practices and the bottlenecks.
63	**SUMMARY of INTERVIEW**
64	**Interview: Regional Bio-economy Hubs Implementation**
65	Participants: Margit Hofer (Interviewer), H7-2, H7-1, H7-3 , Samire Gurgurovci
66	**Main Mission and Role**
67	H7-2 explained their two main roles:
68	1. Acting as a bridge between stakeholders and the regional contact point (H7 region region)
69	1. Providing consultancy support for regional departments to understand needs and transform them into actionable activities

70	The aim was to guide specific interventions at the regional level. They initially selected three value chains, though H7-2 noted this might have been too many, as they ended up focusing primarily on one.
71	H7-1 added that the hub worked as a facilitator for two regional hubs, using similar approaches but with different stakeholder groups. They emphasized the importance of being concrete and bringing innovation in a practical way, especially considering the diverse stakeholder groups including farmers, entrepreneurs, and the private sector.
72	**Challenges in Preparatory Phase**
73	Key challenges identified:
74	• Difficulty in involving private sector, especially farmers, due to time constraints
75	• Need to demonstrate real impact to stakeholders
76	• Challenge of convincing stakeholders about long-term benefits
77	• Complex coordination between different stakeholder interests
78	• Time management with multiple concurrent activities
79	**Stakeholder Engagement Strategies**
80	Successful approaches included:
81	1. Door-to-door engagement (especially effective in Southern H7-country)
82	1. Face-to-face meetings rather than digital communication
83	1. Working through local farmer associations as key information points
84	1. Study visits and practical demonstrations

85	1. Creating trust through personal relationships
86	They managed to engage about 70 stakeholders, with 30-40 regularly active participants.
87	**Implementation Challenges and Successes**
88	Successful elements:
89	• Study visits proved particularly effective
90	• Cross-regional collaboration between different hubs
91	• International events fostering European-level connections
92	Challenges:
93	• Coordinating between different administrative departments
94	• Managing diverse stakeholder interests
95	• Time constraints for implementing planned activities
96	• Balancing ambitious goals with practical limitations
97	**Recommendations for Future Bio-economy Hubs**
98	1. Create interdisciplinary groups within regional hubs including different departments
99	1. Use a bottom-up approach while maintaining high-level guidance

100	1. Establish clear funding mechanisms for long-term sustainability
101	1. Focus on fewer, more targeted activities rather than trying to accomplish too much
102	1. Consider establishing dedicated bio-economy offices within regional structures
103	1. Develop common methodologies that can be replicated across different regions
104	1. Maintain strong relationships with stakeholder networks
105	1. Ensure practical demonstration of benefits to stakeholders
106	**Long-term Sustainability Considerations**
107	Key factors identified:
108	• Need for dedicated funding mechanisms
109	• Importance of institutional support
110	• Clear departmental responsibilities
111	• Continued stakeholder engagement
112	• Integration with existing regional structures
113	• Connection to funding opportunities and project development

114 # Transcript

115 6 February 2025, 01:03pm

116 MH

Margit Hofer 0:05

The recording and I hope it's recording right?

117 SG

Samire Gurgurovci 0:08

It is it is, yes.

118 MH

Margit Hofer 0:10

Very good. OK, thank you so much. So basically we're having like certain.
Areas that we wanted to talk about and basically it's about this whole process of setting up the hubs.
Because what we are looking for these what we call lessons learned. I think you can you you have already dealt a little bit with that already. So you are looking a little bit in the same direction. However what we are specifically looking is these lessons learned during this process of setting up the hubs so.
My first question would be can you can you quickly explain what was the main mission of the hub and So what was his purpose and what was your role in that?
It's gonna start H7-2 or H7-1?

119 CC

H7-1 1:07

H7-1, can you do you want to start or maybe if you want, I can start it's it's OK.

120 LG

H7-2 1:11

It's OK, I can. I can. I can start.
So again, the main goal and our role, right?
Right. I'm not there is here.

121 SG
Samire Gurgurovci 1:24
Yeah.

122 LG
H7-2 1:28
I'm a tilt.

123 MM
H7-3 H7-3 1:29
Hi everybody.

124 LG
H7-2 1:31
So let's start.

125 CC
H7-1 1:31
No.

126 LG
H7-2 1:33
OK, so for.
Is let's say is we are quite aligned with both regions fully and market. But for regarding pugia.
So our main role was I think we had two different roles here. The first one was.
The bridge between the stakeholders and the regional contact point, which was the.
The.
Pooya region.
With a session of competitive competitiveness in agrifood, and I think Agri food, the session.
And so it was basically a a bridge, a bridge bridge. These two different group of like, you know from one side, the policymakers from the other side, the ecosystem. But we we're developing in H7 region region.
And this our second role was also a kind of working as I would say.

Being a supportive measure, so a bit of consultancy also for the.
For the regional departments.
In order to try to understand their needs and transform their needs into actionable.
Activities.
And regarding the aim, I think the main aim was to.
Guide specific intervention at regional level.
Topic where the stakeholders were interested in so. That's why at the beginning we tried to select three different value chain. I would say that probably less from the lesson learned. I would say that having three value chain is quite a lot. Maybe was better to narrow down these but at the end of the day we are really focusing on one value chain not only but like we are developing.
This kind of.
Documents for the region and this is specific on one-on-one value chain.
Where the region is really involved into and so I think, yeah, I mean, I'm probably answering already other questions, but.
I think that's was our main goal, like supporting the region in their initiatives, supporting the needs of.
The stakeholders.
Working as.
With a mentoring coaching function for them.
And try to also raise awareness between.
Students as well, because we really work a lot on on that.

127 MM
H7-3 H7-3 4:16
OK.

128 LG
H7-2 4:19
I don't know H7-3 and H7-1, if you want to watch something because we are collaborating all together. And sometimes it's me more than more than them. More than our. Sometimes it's H7-Project_Partner_1 more than H7-Project_Partner_1_2. So you know, we are quite aligned, but sometimes we can miss some pieces.

129 MH

Margit Hofer 4:19

OK, very good.

130 CC

H7-1 4:35

A little bit.

And for our side, for the hub, we are working together with the H7-Project_Partner_1_2 and maybe and we are working as a facilitator for two regional hubs and sometimes we work together and with the same not not with the same activities because of this group, stakeholder groups, groups are are different, but we are the approach is the same and more similar.

And so the the approach we take in accounted that we are.

Working with the same approach in two different regional hubs with the and that we are created two different stakeholders, group and from this from our point of view, I would like to yes to to make a consideration that this is very important. Maybe for your and for your work package and the more in particular from our.

For interview, the lesson learner is.

Thanks to the different activities we realised that is very important to be real, concrete, concrete and is very important to to bring innovation in a concrete way and because.

If you consider that the stakeholder groups are not only research sector, but also we are included also the farmer.

Entrepreneurs and.

Yes, the private sector and from their part of the view is very difficult sometimes to collaborate in the regional hub because they don't have the time and therefore and when you want to explain which kind of innovation is this possible to?

131 MH

Margit Hofer 6:15

Mm hmm.

132 CC

H7-1 6:35

Replicate in the territories and which kind of opportunities you can bring together.

In close collaboration with the Public Officer, Regional Officer, and the researcher, it is very important to have the clear languages.
Not the structure or maybe, but using the academic languages and it's very important to bring the innovation by using, for example, the study visit.
This one is the one of the best weight if you want to. I can say include.
And to share information.
And to be practise and because we included in our approach.
The methodologies is based on the learning by doing, learning by seeing and learning by touching know and so 14 reasons thanks to the collaboration with the H7-Project_Partner_1_2 and our hub, we work strongly in the during the previous months.
And and maybe for the next in the coming months and for a creation of this study, we're it organisation of this study visiting collaboration with the regional officer and by involving the local farmers. This one I think it's a successful it was a successful.
Meet yeah.
Yeah.

133 MH
Margit Hofer 8:15
Is when you started this project or when you started the hubs.

134 CC
H7-1 8:20
But.

135 MH
Margit Hofer 8:21
You I had obviously impression, but correct me if I'm wrong. You had already certain stakeholders or you had already certain networks. I would say what I would be very much interested in is what were the major challenges during this preparatory phase. So before you started all these activities but sort of really preparing beforehand.
Did you have some major challenges or what was it that was really difficult for you?

136 CC
H7-1 8:56

Let's start. Yes, from my side I I realised and H7-2, if you correct me, please stop me.
I think at the beginning it was very hard and to involve the private sector and especially for the farmer, because when.
You explain them which kind of actions we will do in the. Here we which is the project and sometimes they.
Or if they see, then they have the visions of about OK, I don't have so much time. I don't want to lose the time and maybe OK, we will see later this one is it? So in this first.
Step it was very.
Can I say we we put more effort in order to create yes strategic regional Group working group.
None.

137 LG
H7-2 10:01
Can you read the lesson again please?

138 MH
Margit Hofer 10:04
I was asking in this preparatory phase what was specifically tricky or was you were saying, OK, that was a bit hard or this was a bit like.
Difficult to organise in his first phase where you started this project like OK defining the stakeholder.

139 LG
H7-2 10:19
The first phase before defining the action plan.

140 MH
Margit Hofer 10:22
Exactly.

141 LG
H7-2 10:23
OK.
So I think the good thing from the preparatory phase from Puyab was an already

ongoing.
Discussion and collaboration between the regional facilitator and the UP contact point. So that was for sure something good that made things easier in the end. OK, but from the other side like negative things.
I think people want to see a real impact or a real change, you know.

142 MH
Margit Hofer 11:01
Yeah.

143 LG
H7-2 11:01
So in this project I I won't say it didn't bring change, it didn't bring impact because it did. It did for sure. But it's difficult to, let's say, convince them at the beginning that.
We were able to make an impact on their like businesses or initiatives or whatever they were doing, right.
So only the people that were a bit.
Were able to think in a bit further, looking a bit like in front of their, you know, long term, right, they were able to be engaged properly. Otherwise the other people were more like sceptical, you know.

144 SG
Samire Gurgurovci 11:35
Long term, yeah.

145 MH
Margit Hofer 11:44
Mm hmm.

146 LG
H7-2 11:45
I think this was the main downside point, because most of the time this coordination supportive action are written in a way that people are pragmatic. People want to know what what is the value of you bringing me or bringing initiatives into my.

147 SG

Samire Gurgurovci 11:54

Yeah.

148 LG

H7-2 12:00

Lives where I I've already like, you know, a lot of things to do. So that's the main thing that made stuff difficult at the beginning, but luckily, you know, with the people talking to each other with good knowledge is we could like connection relationship we had in the pool territory as well as Mark. I guess we made we made it through. We were able to prefer an action plan but yet.

Yeah.

If I say now that the action plan.

Was really like something.

Focused on what we had to do, maybe not because we had to produce something.

We didn't know yet how to develop it, so you know that's, I mean, the main downside I think of having this action plan at the beginning. But then, yeah, I need to write you some. I need to write on the action plan something but yeah.

149 SG

Samire Gurgurovci 12:48

Mm hmm mm hmm.

150 LG

H7-2 12:58

Is what the right what I really wanted or what they're really going to do or not? That's the main thing.

151 MH

Margit Hofer 13:07

So basically, do I understand you correctly that?

What I mean it's good to have this action plan at first, but then on the other hand, once in the process it would would would have been better to have it a bit more open like that you would be able more to adopt it. Do you understand that correctly?

152 LG

H7-2 13:26

Yeah, I think I think it was. They requested too many information at the beginning, so. And I understand that there are KPIs and stuff like that, but.

I think for me it was enough engaging and defining the value chain and that was it. And then on the process of.

With the stakeholder and with the stakeholder, you were going to be able to see, OK, we're going to improve this and this and that. But like we had to come up already with some plans, so.

It's like, you know, and it's always difficult to cross check and with the 2nd order, do you like do you do you not what do you want to do? I it's not like I send them a text. It's like I need to collect them all together in an event to speak to them creating what? So it's something that requires a lot of time.

153 MH

Margit Hofer 14:00

Yeah.

154 SG

Samire Gurgurovci 14:11

Yeah.

155 MH

Margit Hofer 14:17

Yeah. Is there anything else you would do differently the next time in terms of the, I mean considering the preparation phase, is there anything where you were saying that was something that I if I would have to do the exactly the same again, I would include this. So I would skip that.

156 LG

H7-2 14:45

I think a bit more clarity on the guidance of this action plan preparation.

157 MH

Margit Hofer 14:54

Mm hmm.

158 LG

H7-2 14:54

'Cause I had the feeling that the action plan was like, OK, this is the template and you go. That was my feeling.

And and as I as I mentioned like.

I know it's difficult on the proposal preparation phase, understand how I have to do the work, so I'm not blaming. But now that we know like the all the functioning or all the function of this hub and how the work can be done and actually what?

Because I didn't know what was in reality and.

I think we can just like.

I say divide steps into little steps and just like you know.

Because without achieving a certain task, you cannot proceed any. This was, there was a probably a bit of misalignment on on the on the task and then on the work packages I guess. So that's that's a more.

Care of like, yeah, I say.

A better like a Gant organisation of the task, probably, and even like a better like a clarity on task, especially when you have to create the app like you know guidelines could really like.

Technical guidelines on how to create hub and.

And so division of steps.

Without putting too much work on the apps, because if you think about that at the beginning, we had to engage, we had to write the action plan, we had to organise event, we had to.

159 MH

Margit Hofer 16:24

OK.

160 LG

H7-2 16:35

Do the kick off meeting, I mean. And we had to do also some other things. So you know I like.
Many activities on us, the questionnaire and.

161 MH
Margit Hofer 16:47
Yeah.
Yeah, it it was a lot for the apps. I I totally understand your point.

162 LG
H7-2 16:54
That's I think that's that's the thing. You know, if you are, if you have an activities, then you're gonna provide.
Based on the time you have, you know you cannot really like do I. I would say we we did a great job. But of course you know, the more we focus the better is the outcome so.

163 CC
H7-1 17:06
Yeah.

164 MH
Margit Hofer 17:15
OK.
H7-1, anything else to add here or?

165 CC
H7-1 17:23
I was thinking just.
As I I think it's the same after lunar because so when you organise when you have to consider the deadline of the project and therefore the deadline of several deliverable and the actions in the maelstrom and.
So when you have to organise the regional hub within and especially the engagement of different stakeholders, and you can imagine.
That for each stakeholder, each stakeholder can have an other activities, and when you have to try to organise and to to put in the same line.

The interest of different interest of different stakeholders and the different actions it's it's it's very hard.
Just these specific action is that require a lot of work and a lot lot of effort this one.

166 MH
Margit Hofer 18:21
Mm hmm.

167 CC
H7-1 18:29
The good, the strong management and in acting.
Is necessary also to consider which kind of interest.
They have the regional stakeholders, the public officers, because it's different, it's different conditions.
And therefore, yeah.

168 MH
Margit Hofer 18:55
Yeah, that's a very interesting point you're raising. My question would be because beforehand you were also talking about the engagement of the stakeholders, so which, which methods or what did you do?
So which methods were most effective or which ones didn't work out at all? Actually, H7-2 is is raising hand.

169 LG
H7-2 19:17
Yeah, sorry. Just two finish. Don't like, you know, forget what I had in mind. Like, also, I don't remember. Like the up contact pointer at the beginning like.

170 MH
Margit Hofer 19:21
Mm hmm.

171 LG
H7-2 19:29

It was meant to be someone from the regional department. It was.
Mandatory requirement or it could have been someone.
Not from the that from this they called the groups. I don't remember is a question for you if you remember.
Because then just to maybe we can cross check it later so we have everything recorded, but then.

172 MH
Margit Hofer 19:49
Do.

173 LG
H7-2 19:56
If this was the case that the up contact point was mandatory coming from the policy maker, they call theirs group.

174 CC
H7-1 19:59
None.

175 LG
H7-2 20:08
Then I'm an II can say that what H7-1 said is relevant because.
If.
Say the ARB is is going to be built around this point, OK, that.
Has specific.
Requirements OK. And since is it is working in the administration, you know in the in decision making process yes like really.
Specific needs, which may might be different a lot from the others. They call the groups from the Quadrillex, right? So that's that's really relevant when you are like writing.
A project and when you're like defining KPIs and what you want to achieve, because then here we are coming at two different levels.
Of importance, yeah, and of actionable results.

176 MH

Margit Hofer 21:04

How about you able to align these different needs? I mean you were talking about that you had many different stakeholder groups. And so how did you manage to to align all these needs and different interests within like let's say they or common actions, how how did you do that?

177 LG

H7-2 21:11

Yeah.

The end at the end we try to, let's say, collect relevant information from both so relevant needs from both side. But at the end of the day.

The the the we are referring mainly to our up contact point which is the region which is. He agreed to be the contact point because we were going to provide back, right? So at the end of the day we have we can collect from these, you know pool which are the stakeholders. But then we have to report everything to the main pool, which is the.

The up contact point and in this case we have two, let's say mainly provide you know to the to the up contact point so to their needs and we try to match a bit. But if you ask me. You work mainly on the app contacts point side or so-called aside. I don't know what to answer.

178 MH

Margit Hofer 22:25

Very tricky task. At the end there.

179 LG

H7-2 22:27

Yeah.

180 MH

Margit Hofer 22:28

OK.

Then.

Yeah. What is what question is with, I mean how did you identify and prioritise the key

stakeholders? I mean, was there any strategy you had behind or did you sort of just throw back from the pool of stakeholders that you had already?

181 LG

H7-2 22:50

There were. There was a well, mainly starting from our connection, because we are both, I mean H7-Project_Partner_1_2 is working in the BI economy as it all. But H7-country's working on the hub and all the related affiliation like you make a Verde federal canapa they are working on the bicommy as well in more specific sectors. Also H7-Project_Partner_1_2 is covering many sector and the other they are covering specific sector. So we could let the stakeholders from our network.

Mainly we collect the stakeholder from the operational group.

From the European Commission, so the archives system is providing operational groups on agriculture and forestry. So basically we collected from the relevant projects.

From the archives. So from the operational group we collected, we define and listed all the relevant stakeholders that were involved in this.

In this in this in these operational groups and we had also input from the up contact point.

That was our idea. And then we through dissemination through events, through communication, we were able to target more stakeholders in the process, but the main pool was defined, as I said.

182 MH

Margit Hofer 24:18

So basically it makes sense to have like this collaboration. So in that sense you 2 collaborating with each other made totally sense, right? Because you had a huge pool of sickle.

183 CC

H7-1 24:18

Yeah.

184 LG

H7-2 24:28

Yeah, I mean, but that's that's a specific case because we are like The hubs countryss, we are, we are, we had like 3 The hubs countryss partnered and I think that's the only case where this happened because if you consider the for, for France, they didn't have two partners from France but one partner and two ABS. So it's a bit different.

185 MH

Margit Hofer 24:49

Yeah, I I.

186 CC

H7-1 24:50

Yeah.

Also we exploited.

We exploited the the links with the regional stakeholders and with the key.

Key actors, but using the the previous project, the national level and the European project also where the regional hub hubs not regional hub but the territories or the regional agency and where involving as a partner, we also explo exploited the links thanks to the regional projects.

A local project in in this way. OK as we keep in contact and again and this kind of approach has been very useful for us because it's a facilitates we know.

Which kind of key actors or regional actor where?

Sensible to our activities for the for rural Bioup project and therefore OK, we.

Selected the stakeholder, the regional stakeholder before to start and to have the key contact. I think it is very essential if you want to start in the correct way because if you consider for example the the project officer just because you see the link by I don't know websites or something like that because.

Without to to have any contacts.

Have to, I don't know. Maybe you are lucky.

187 MH

Margit Hofer 26:35

Yeah.

188 CC

H7-1 26:35

No. Yeah, but it is essential to have to consider.

The common activities, yeah.

189 MH

Margit Hofer 26:44

Yeah.

Would you say that this sort of identifying the common activities that this is also good strategy to keep the stakeholders within the project or to keep them sort of motivated because this is also something that came several times, it's sort of you address first the stakeholders, but then how do you keep them in the project, how you keep them motivated?

Did you find a good strategy or strategies you can?

Yeah.

190 CC

H7-1 27:17

Increase awareness.

As I said before that.

We create a methodologies where the study visits divorce, the key action and and the workshop OK for in order to increase.

The the collaboration between different stakeholders, of course, but the study visit I think it's one of the best.

Practises are the best actions in order to motivate the stakeholders.

191 LG

H7-2 27:57

Yeah, I think sorry, H7-1, if you finish, if you if you have finish. OK now from from my side I think.

192 CC

H7-1 27:58

So sorry. No, no, no, I finished.

193 LG

H7-2 28:08

A super easy strategy is having good working relation with these people.

194 CC

H7-1 28:09

None.

195 LG

H7-2 28:13

Which is what is how you create networks and is how you people are. If they trust in you and they trust you in your work, then they're going to participate. Doesn't matter what. But the most difficult things is when you have to target people that are not in your network and.

Keep them attached to the project to idea, to the purpose right and there I think is is the most is the most tricky part. And as H7-1 said like empower them.

Through activities through showcasing their business, showcasing their initiatives is the main strategy we applied.

But again, a questionnaire is also.

How to involve all the stakeholder at the same level? This is not going to be possible.

Be for sure they call it that are more. Let's say they are a bit more shy past midterm.

To organise to you know, showcase and stuff like that. And then there is difficult because at the end you're going to end up on of having always the same people.

Participating actively to the initiatives and this is so the question is not what was the best strategies to engage them, but what is what can be another strategy to engage the people that are not being engaged at the same level. I think this is relevant also to understand.

196 MH

Margit Hofer 29:48

Mm hmm.

That's a. That's a good quote, actually. Yeah, it's a. It's a very interesting thought you bring up here.

Well, if you think about your work with the stakeholders, like engaging them and working

with them, is there any, I mean and also I think the strategy like you mentioned H7-1 saying, OK, we build our activities and and we sort of attached them around an activity that was very practical and what they were very fond of. However one one question I do have is that.
Thing that you would do differently the next time related to the stakeholders.
What advice would you give other stakeholders?
Other hubs in terms of working with stakeholders, what are like let's say the five best advisors you would give?
But the three best advices you're thinking so intense.

197 LG
H7-2 30:51
The father quite a lot. No, because there are many questions here in this one question.
So what we what we will change H7-1, is that something what we would like to change in the stakeholder engagement process.

198 MH
Margit Hofer 30:59
Start somewhere.

199 CC
H7-1 31:13
Oh.

200 LG
H7-2 31:15
It's a good one.
But I think in the engagement process, so when we have to go to the stakeholder and.
Asking him if he's interested into the project. If you want to join us, the caller. If you want.
If you want to join the the the the platform I think.
I won't say I don't have proper answer now, but I feel we quite be we we were quite able to engage a lot of people because we actually in in our list we engage 70 stakeholder.
So there are quite a lot. Of course, not all of them are like let's say.
Active. OK in participating into the initiatives, but 70s means that more or less 40 the call

that was 30 stakeholders are always present.
Which is a good quantity, OK.
But maybe I think, OK, I have it now. I think a good practise we a good strategy we had maybe this can be suggestions but we didn't apply that this strategy much but.
This applies in H7-country, especially in the South.
We had this kind of door to door.
Engagement.
So we we brought rural bio up in today businesses, we went to them and to say OK, you know what we are doing this and this and that we would like to have you on board and not like the usual e-mail that is going to be in is going to finish in the spam session or the. This online engagement, right? It was more to face to face. So we were giving value to them. I think this was a really good practise.
Actually, H7-3 did it with a hub colleague and other colleague. So that's a good I think. Is a good activity, but probably applies all in H7-country because I don't know where. I don't know. In South of H7-country was pretty nice because you know we.
Is how the cultural this is a cultural barrier, I would say so this is it is what it is. So we need to also understand like how to engage with people based on their culture.

201 MH

Margit Hofer 33:53

Well, it could be an The hubs countrys thing, but then on the other hand, it could be it could be really a global thing that that one is saying, OK, it makes more sense to talk face to face and like, having spilled up a personal contact, especially because I remember one of you said beforehand, it's also a question of trust. And obviously I have more trust in a person that I talk to directly face to face rather than in an e-mail. So in a way, it sort of fits.

202 LG

H7-2 34:00

Yeah.
Yeah, yeah.

203 MH

Margit Hofer 34:21

It's very logical. So it sort of makes sense what you're saying.

204 LG

H7-2 34:25

In my fit in all the all the apps, because we are talking about rural areas and your rural areas, there is not probably then.

Is I don't know, awareness of using even like online means you know to disseminate or to start projects.

205 CC

H7-1 34:43

Yeah.

206 LG

H7-2 34:48

Yeah, that's that's my that's my the only answer that comes pop to my mind now.

207 MH

Margit Hofer 34:53

OK.

208 CC

H7-1 34:55

As the physical approach it it's it's quite better and especially depending of the farmer, depending of the kindness city stakeholders know and if you consider the young stakeholder maybe can better or.

Is more.

Better to we are facilitated to connect through online or I don't know, and the online meeting.

Or something like that. But if you consider the hold people or the hold farmers, I have to use the traditional approach.

They're completely different. You have to consider. Yes, the face to face, and maybe by using them. I don't know the old contacts and Association Farmer Association is another important point as a stakeholders.

Because he's at the represent.

209 MH
Margit Hofer 35:57
Yeah.

210 CC
H7-1 36:01
The territories, the culture in the specific area and without association as a pillar, and therefore if you want to.
Disseminate the events or the new information about the project or the activities or the innovation.
You can do it, but you have to.
Would the local and the rural association, because it's represent that? Yes, there is the pillar for many, many, many farmers.

211 MH
Margit Hofer 36:40
In Austria, it's exactly the same. So these associations? Yeah, totally. These these associations are basically the main information point for the farmers.

212 CC
H7-1 36:42
Oh.
Yeah. Information points, yeah.

213 MH
Margit Hofer 36:52
So yeah, so and I guess it's it's a bit the same with with H7-country then. So it sounds very much like that. OK.

214 CC
H7-1 37:02
It's like accreditation at the regional level. You know, if the station say, OK, this project is very good and so one and then you can ensure a lot of farmers at your event.

215 MH
Margit Hofer 37:02
Good.
Yeah.

216 CC
H7-1 37:19
It's often OK.

217 MH
Margit Hofer 37:21
Yeah.
OK. Then I wanted to ask you regarding the implementation of these different activities and actions you mentioned beforehand already. You were saying that one of the best ones were the study visits, right? So this is something where you were very fond of and where you had the impression that worked out very well. Now thinking about these actions and activities, in your opinion.
Which ones do you work well or which ones have you tested and worked well and which ones didn't work out at all?

218 CC
H7-1 38:02
Sorry, can you last? Because it.

219 MH
Margit Hofer 38:06
I was asking about these different activities and actions because you remember you were you had to write down in the action plan what different activities or actions you would like to do with your stakeholders. And I was wondering whether you could give some insights which of the activities worked out very well.
And why do you think that they worked out well?

220 CC
H7-1 38:37
That's from regional hub for for the market regions, but I think and if you consider the all

the activities carry out so far, but I we have a lot, but also for the pooja because we close, we collaborated to together for a lot of events.
And fair and something like that and.
Yes, a lot of informations concerning the federal organisation of the Workshop and study visit that also included in the SharePoint and we are uploading the activities also in this last two days.
And happiness. A good place to learn.
This one I I think in the rural view hub for the first time I realised the good collaboration between the different regions.
And for example, the original the original officer from Hudia and the market.
We, we.
And the we created the the specific event, the specific workshop where the the original officer and had all the opportunities to to collaborate at the shared informations about the Biocon circular bio economy and the actions plan to be.
OK, to came to be developed in the specific region and this one I I think it is very special.
Activities that is not usual.
To see in the European regions, but more in general at the national level, it's very it's very, it's not usual, it's very special.
Yeah.

221 MH

Margit Hofer 40:34

So do you understand you correctly that you are saying?
Activities and actions that are like, say, extraordinary and very special. They work out well.

222 CC

H7-1 40:46

Yeah, yeah. But also I was wondering another.
Another important opportunity that we have, we have created that through the rural you have projects. It was during the international event that we have.
I don't remember. It was last year when we went all together in the Romanian.
October 2024.
The European even there was the European event, the regions meet European meet regions.

And yeah, OK. But I remember that.
There was the first one of the important occasions where the different regional hub and talks together, not only at the national level, but also at the European level, this one it's, I think that.
Could be.
An A key point that we can highlight in the projects.
As a result, unexpected results.

223 MH
Margit Hofer 42:04
Yeah.

224 CC
H7-1 42:06
Yeah.

225 MH
Margit Hofer 42:06
Megan.
When you were implementing those actions and activities.
Were there any unexpected challenges? So was it hard for you, or was it? Was there anything that you were saying? OK, this was rather tricky to implement.

226 CC
H7-1 42:33
I didn't know. H7-2, do you? What do you think?
An expected challenges.

227 LG
H7-2 42:41
I mean.
I mean, if I go back to the action plan, I think I was mentioning before we had to, we had a lot of we.
We we wanted to achieve a lot of activities in this regional hub, right, but for instance, one of the main one which was probably also challenging it was that this working table at the

at the regional at the regional level about by economy.
That we place into the into the action plan and are and this is something that for sure will not happen.
Because that's something too big to be.
We created like right now, right?
So one of the challenges is something that maybe is important to keep in mind that we need to really focus on something that is actionable instead of something that we would like probably to have that right. And because the time is not much.
If you because you have, you have to. You know you have some project activities and then some other activities that maybe you want to.
Provide to that contact point so.

228 MH
Margit Hofer 44:01
Do you understand you correctly that what you're saying is if I would summarise that that you would say.
Rather, focus on activities and actions that they are very much focused and they clear to certain target group rather than have like many, many different stakeholders making a huge and sort of trying to to be too wide.

229 LG
H7-2 44:15
Mm hmm. Mm hmm mm hmm.
I think this is not really a matter of stakeholder groups, but is a matter of.
Activities right is like.
Some activities that can be you can.
Yeah, create something like like we did with the with the pull up. Or we did with market with the market up some I mean.
Focus with like on less activities, but then you know try to.
Bring them at the end.
But if I misspell it properly.

230 MH
Margit Hofer 45:02

OK.
Were there any support structures where you were saying this was helpful in implementing different activities and actions?
What was helpful in that phase while implementing these activities?

231 LG
H7-2 45:24
And so if there are some statute that were helpful for the implementation of the activities, that's the question.

232 MH
Margit Hofer 45:33
Yeah. Were there anything helpful while implementing the activities?

233 LG
H7-2 45:40
Helpful for for us.

234 MH
Margit Hofer 45:42
Yeah.

235 LG
H7-2 45:45
Yeah.

236 MH
Margit Hofer 45:55
If there wasn't anything, then there is nothing, so don't.

237 CC
H7-1 45:55
I don't know.

238 LG

H7-2 45:58

Do you have an example?

239 MH

Margit Hofer 46:00

Must could be as an example that you have.

Seen that in a different country they had done. Don't know whatever.

An activity in it works. That's so fine that you were deciding. OK, we will do the same. Or where you have depression that don't know.

Study visit to Ireland was super and so then you did also one so it could be either other good best practise example could be that you were saying OK.

240 CC

H7-1 46:21

But maybe.

241 MH

Margit Hofer 46:33

We use that in that corporation or that in that network so.

242 LG

H7-2 46:37

Sure.

Well, from us for sure was the possibility to collaborate between the different apps in H7-country. Therefore sushante, but also like a cross checking with activities of the other hubs was somehow somehow important because maybe we can we can, we can. We were able to get BTM pieces from from the other activities and try to implement these in ours so. Yeah.

243 MH

Margit Hofer 47:07

OK. Do you?

244 LG

H7-2 47:07

I would say it is.

245 CC

H7-1 47:10

We can.

Yeah. And we can send just for example for our side, I think it could be useful and to hike light for different regional hub and the key person dedicated for the circular bio economy. Subjects there because when you if you want to develop an action plan.

And maybe to engage the regional stakeholder, sometimes the problem is who is the responsible.

Responsible for to implement and regional platform about the circular bio economy, regional circular bio economy and within the region institution is very difficult sometimes because it's a concept to divide it from different departments environment.

246 MH

Margit Hofer 47:54

Mm hmm.

247 CC

H7-1 48:08

Department Agricultural Department, Energy Department.

Industrial department.

And you can either know in our strip, but I realised in not in the in this project but in the previous project and realised that this is very difficult sometimes and to collaborate with different departments within the regional institution because the department don't want to share information.

248 MH

Margit Hofer 48:38

Yeah.

249 CC

H7-1 48:38

Don't want to collaborate in a common project.
If you consider the region institutions as a partner of the project is not sufficient, but you have to have include the departments and sometimes the different departments don't want to collaborate. The project is one department or for another department there is the competitions is a.

250 MH
Margit Hofer 48:59
Mm hmm.
Yeah.

251 CC
H7-1 49:09
It's very strange. I don't know that this one is typical countr behaviour. I don't know if it's another, I don't know, but.
Is this this one? Is this situation? No, but you can imagine, and the circular bio economy is interdisciplinary.

252 MH
Margit Hofer 49:25
Yeah.

253 CC
H7-1 49:32
Topic and you have to consider a lot of.
Matter topics and then persons so.
Maybe we can suggest.
To consider the by economy.
Of office.
I don't know, maybe this one could be.
Suggest and recommendation recommendation but I don't know if it's a practical.
Well, this one is in a question. My question for you, but is it enough to, for example, in your regional institution there is a specific office?

And.
For under, circular by economy or not?

254 MH
Margit Hofer 50:19
No, not really. We have a bit the same the same like you, which I totally agree that it makes it complicated because none of the departments would like to you to lose the power of having like sort of this.

255 CC
H7-1 50:20
No, no.
OK.

256 MH
Margit Hofer 50:37
So everybody claims it's his or her topic bioeconomy and it so we do have some. Especially when it's the overall structure. So even if if it's from government, you have several ministries who are dealing with minor economy.
Although there's one now which is really like only one department for Bio economy, still they have to collaborate with the industry, with the Agri Ministry of Agriculture and so on. And that is most tricky. You know, straight to as regards for the regional departments.

257 CC
H7-1 50:58
OK.

258 MH
Margit Hofer 51:13
Even there, it's tricky because here we have a split up to. So we have very much the same situation and I do think that it's not only H7-country and Austria and this is what makes it complicated to implement.
Economy because.
Many different stakeholders, many different departments, many departments who claim that Bioeconomy is their responsibility. With this responsibility, there's the funding and

the money, and nobody would like to sort of get in their money small down. So it's yeah. And then you have to be very, very careful if you invite one person to have invited the other person as well.

259 CC
H7-1 51:52
Yeah, yeah, yeah, the same.

260 MH
Margit Hofer 51:54
So it's it's also a very diplomatic.
Balancing which is needed when we talk about stakeholders in Austria.

261 CC
H7-1 52:00
Yeah.

262 MH
Margit Hofer 52:06
Yeah.
But yeah, this is.

263 CC
H7-1 52:08
Maybe yes, we.
We can include in the recommendation of our projects, why not?
As a result.
No, just I was wondering, yes, this one is because this could be very and can I say it light the key point.
For the European Commission's and to discuss.
In but using the approach top down.
And to discuss with different government and therefore the regional hub, the approach that we have to we must to use.
It's very.

264 MH

Margit Hofer 53:00

I wouldn't if I would be you. I would include that recommendation because we this is a tricky one. Really. I have one more question. I actually two more questions and then we are done with our interview. But in terms of long term sustainability, I mean we've been talking about already like this, if we would manage to uniform and the one department bio economy then it would make it easier. But do you see other?

265 CC

H7-1 53:08

There we go.

None.

266 MH

Margit Hofer 53:28

To other long term sustainability strategies for hubs of sort of for regional.

Networks of bio economy.

Is there anything you've been thinking about already, or do you even follow up already long term sustainability strategy?

267 CC

H7-1 53:51

Good questions and I was.

I'm thinking that's for the in for sustainability for the in the long term is what if we want to think the sustainability in the long term, I think OK we can suggest for example, the bio economy office within the regional structure, but it is also very important to consider also the funding.

For the specific actions because.

When you suggest to the public authority, OK, you have to include the plan by economy platform. You have to develop, you have to.

We have to do a lot of things in order to implement the byka circular by economy platform, but the problem is.

The funding in order to manage this.

Action.

And also to include.
Which kind of the department is responsible for the person selected by using the different department in? In this way we have.
A democratic approach? Diplomatic approach.
And.
Yes, I think this one is another crucial point.
Because we have to maintain from economical point of view the activities within the regional.
Institution.

268 MH
Margit Hofer 55:32
Mm hmm mm hmm.

269 CC
H7-1 55:35
Do you have a cost?

270 MH
Margit Hofer 55:38
Yeah.
OK. I mean my closing question would be what are your top lessons learned for regions that want to establish their own bio economy hub? So what would you recommend?

271 CC
H7-1 56:00
As I've seen before until now.
As a first, is necessary to create interdisciplinary group within the regional regional hub and included the different department of course and therefore the engineer, the research chair or the the officer comes from the Rural department or something like that. That's and that this one is the 1st.
And another important things is also to consider which kind of approach we want to include in order to maintain the original hub and therefore it's essential to to drive the original hub about using the button up approach.

The regional legal but for organisation of the bio economy Platform or bio Economy regional office, we have also.
To to collect.
Some recommendation from not European commissions, but.
At the other high level, this one I think it is essential to have the same approach from you. At the European level.
Because it's not possible to to think or to organise the circular bio economy, the European legal one, each regions they follow this the different methodologies of the different approach. I think we have to decide all together and maybe this one is could be another recommendation for from.
From.
Develop from rural view up.
Projects and maybe to discuss which kind of approach is necessary to have by using the different results comings from different regional hubs and.
Maybe two, I don't know to decide, or maybe to share the approach methodologies and that they try to identify which kind of common methodologies is it possible to applicate to the OR replicate in.
Other regional hubs.

272 MH
Margit Hofer 58:26
OK.

273 CC
H7-1 58:26
This one it's.

274 MH
Margit Hofer 58:28
Yeah. So are you saying also this, it would be very helpful to have this best practise cases. Would those be helpful too?
Or is it too specific? Is each region too specific?

275 CC

H7-1 58:42

Best practise?

As the best practise about this approach.

I don't know.

I don't have that feedback.

276 MH

Margit Hofer 59:10

OK.

OK. H7-2, do you have anything to add here or?

Is there anything that you would still would like to mention here?

Are you happy with what the colour was seeing? Actually you're muted, OK.

277 LG

H7-2 59:29

I mean, I was speaking. I was muted. No, I align with H7-1, probably with with the long term sustainability.

From our side, we are trying to work.

On on these.

Through the through the fact that we can still again the level of regional facilitator up contact point. So we're going to discard the ecosystem and we are going to probably work because it is difficult to keep the sustainability of all the hub. But again we focused on the up contact point we we we tried to.

Give idea to the region.

On the.

Call proposal writing.

Supporting well, actually the ecosystem is involved supporting the value chain. We selected, OK, this is one of the long term sustainability strategy we have.

278 CC

H7-1 1:00:39

I.

279 LG
H7-2 1:00:40
And.. I'm connecting this to the funding opportunities because of course.

280 CC
H7-1 1:00:48
I.

281 LG
H7-2 1:00:50
We can imagine we're doing this for free or for the sake of a good relationship.
With and for our purpose of our own company, right? Not for the purpose of project, but Project was a mean of then starting this, but the funding opportunities are quite important also in general for for the apps as well.

282 MH
Margit Hofer 1:01:12
Yeah, sure.

283 LG
H7-2 1:01:16
Yeah, that's I think I think I'm pretty agree with H7-1, what she said.

284 MH
Margit Hofer 1:01:16
Push.

285 LG
H7-2 1:01:22
Yeah.

286 MH
Margit Hofer 1:01:30
Is there anything else you would like to mention? Because we are at the end now of this interview.

Yeah, if you would, if if there's still something that you were saying, OK. This is very important. I this is something I wanted to mention here at this point and then.

287 CC
H7-1 1:01:38
None.

288 MH
Margit Hofer 1:01:48
Please go ahead, but I don't want to stress you too long because I think we've done an hour interview and it's quite exhausting to think about this very in depth question. So yeah.
But thank you so much for your time. Really.

289 CC
H7-1 1:02:03
OK.

290 LG
H7-2 1:02:03
No worries. No, I think we previous cast the main bottlenecks of the the the goods, the best practises, but also the bottlenecks I think quite mentioned them also.

291 MH
Margit Hofer 1:02:16
Yeah, yeah.
But we do this transcript and then we will send it to you.
At some point and H7-1, we anyhow keep in touch because I think it makes sense that you would read the outcome because then I could imagine it might be easier for you also to write up the recommendations. I think that is a bit of a hint that goes hand in hand this work.
And we explicitly exclude in our believable model recommendations, so we only do the lessons learned so that you have material for your lessons learnt.

292 SG
Samire Gurgurovci 1:02:45
Yep.

293 MH
Margit Hofer 1:02:50
That makes in a good a good match then possibly.

294 CC
H7-1 1:02:54
Yeah, yeah, yeah. And I was. I was discuss about this one is for our deliverable and with the Mateo in this morning and we are OK. We are collected the information about the questioner and now we are.
Working yes for the structure of the deliverable and we are thinking also to include your contribution.
Derive from a three-point 3.3 if I OK if I if if it's correct task 3.3 OK the work package 3 the results from the work package three as well as the results from work package four and. When we, we will finish the deliverable, the draught and we will send the yes, the first version. So in in this way you can you can put your contribution in the specific subsea section.
And indeed, in this way we can create the common recommendation and the links with other work package.

295 MH
Margit Hofer 1:04:04
OK, very good.

296 CC
H7-1 1:04:06
Yeah. Yeah. OK.

297 MH
Margit Hofer 1:04:07

Great. Thank you so much. Greetings to H7-country. Thanks for your time and your valuable information. OK, great. Thank you so much. Bye Bye H7-3 also.

298 CC
H7-1 1:04:11
OK. Thank you. Thank you. Bye bye. Bye bye.

299 LG
H7-2 1:04:12
Thank you. Have a good day. Talk to you soon. Bye bye.

300 SG
Samire Gurgurovci 1:04:14
Thank you. Have a good day.

301 MM
H7-3 H7-3 1:04:17
Oh, bye. No.

302
Margit Hofer stopped transcription

Statement: AI supported the cleaning of the files.